# She-Ra And The Nightmare Warrior

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29723952.

**Rating:**
General Audiences

**Archive Warning:**
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

**Category:**
Other

**Fandom:**
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

**Relationships:**
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

**Characters:**
Adora (She-Ra), She-Ra (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Swift Wind (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra)

**Additional Tags:**
Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, She-Ra The Movie, catradora, Glimbow, Inspired by She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Queen Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora/Catra is Canon (She-Ra)

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by Mica_agata, Red_Liepard

Summary

After defeating Horde Prime and rebuilding Etheria, the friend squad will launch to a new adventure: give planets their magic back. But, upon arriving at the last one, they'll meet with an unexpected challenge. Will they be able to overcome it?

(This story continues from the end of the series, so if you haven't seen it yet, I recommend doing it first)

# Alone Together (Part 1)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After Horde Prime's imminent defeat, the slow process of rebuilding Etheria started, because, even though the big evil was long gone, the destruction left in its wake remained. For this reason, it took some time to reestablish everything back to "normal". Plenty of villages and kingdoms had been severely damaged, and as such, it required plenty of hard work to try to fix all the damages. To a large degree, they were succeeding but not yet to a 100%.

In the meantime, and with lots of arguments about it, Micah decided that his daughter should remain the queen. Glimmer had refused numerous times, but the Etheria's former king insisted, arguing that she successfully completed the ritual, that she was more than capable, and that he would always be by her side to guide her whenever she needed him. He ignored to mention that governing without Angella would feel weird to him, furthermore, her daughter as the ruler made much more sense.

Bow, Adora, Catra, and Glimmer hadn't been able to rest properly since the newfound peace and the rest couldn't say they were so much better; everybody, somehow, collaborated with each other putting Etheria back to its feet, as strong and stable as possible. Afterward, it could be said that true peace and quiet reigned, and except for some small problems now and then, everybody managed to rest… at least for a while. As the calm days went by, the friend squad started to grow more and more restless. They needed new challenges, new adventures. Something to get them on track once more. That's why, one day, they decided to get up and leave. They were sure that it was the right time to carry out on their promise after Horde Prime was defeated, undertaking them, on one last adventure; seeking to aid

the planets that Horde Prime and the First Ones left in shambles, returning the magic back to those who were robbed.

Although at first, everything seemed to go well and easy, with each passing moment, the experience turned a little more intense, extensive, and exhausting than expected. But at the same time, they couldn't deny they were having a great time helping so many planets and beings who believed they were done for.

After many months of hard work, there was only one more planet left to come back home, something that Bow, Adora, and Glimmer lamented a little since it meant the end of the trip, and possibly, of their last great adventure. Catra, on her side, couldn't wait to get back y take a big break; she doubted they could ever have real peace until their final days, her negativity clearly didn't allow her to think otherwise.

She-ra was outside the ship destroying a meteor rain, while Glimmer watched her attentive, Bow was trying to find out how to reach the new planet, and Catra sighed in a corner, a little annoyed and bored. The last couple days hadn't been anything but them locked in the ship, struggling to find the exact coordinates, as they travel to an "approximate location", which wasn't at all near their previous visited planet. In some other time, the girl would have found entertainment in watching She-ra smash things, but even that became a mundane occurrence. Neither was she worried that something might happen since there were no doubts of how strong She-ra was, and how little of a threat this situation was to her.

A couple of more minutes passed, and Adora finally could end her chore. She entered the ship with a graceful air, agitated for the adrenaline and the excitement of the moment. Immediately Glimmer teleported beside her, really excited.

"Adora, nice job, you made it!" she congratulated her, with a smile and a short hug.

“And we only suffered much less damaged than I anticipated” added Bow, relieved and content, “Plus, I have some more great news”

“What?” asked Adora, curious.

“I found where the new planet is located!”

“Really, Bow? That’s awesome!” Cheered Glimmer, as the boy, nodded. Both girls walked to him and gave him a big hug, celebrating their goal, as Catra clapped unenthusiastically in the background.

“Awesome, wow. It was time we traveled with a set course… Were we even going to the right place at least? “said with unwillingness, making Bow and the rest get a bit upset.

“Catra!” Yelled Adora, disapproval tainted her blue eyes.

“I’ve been working as fast as I could” Retorted Bow, irritated by her comment and the added tiredness. “If I’m not fast enough, you can do it”, after this statement he attempted to walk away, only to be stopped by Catra who sighed and grabbed his arm

“I’m sorry, I’m tired, didn’t mean to offend you…” she apologized honestly, without meeting his eyes, “I really want to get back to Etheria and take a long break”, she admitted calmly.

“Try not to be so mean to me, I’m tired too...” answered Bow, causing Catra to grow more regretful of her sayings. Adora came closer to them and put her arms over her friend’s shoulders.

“This is the last one, okay?” she reminded them, conciliatory. But Catra was still unconvinced to resume the mission, “We’ll do it quickly, it'll be easy, none of the previous ones were super hard…”

“Oh, no?” asked Catra raising her eyebrow. Adora looked sideways, pretending to not understand, “We were chased by a pack of…” she started listing but stopped herself as she tried to think what to called those horrible beings, “giant abominations

that almost eats us alive, we climbed a giant mountain and almost froze to death, oh and how to forget those beautiful gigantic plants that almost eats us… AGAIN!" exclaimed upset.

Adora knew that Catra had a good point, but she wanted to try to be as positive as possible, which is why she wasn't going to give in so easily.

"The mountain barely counted for you" Interrupted Glimmer. Catra rolled her eyes. "We barely made a few steps and you immediately asked Adora to carry you as She-ra" she retorted, as the other girl smiles remembering the moment; she had clearly taken advantage of Adora's innocence, but already at that time she was exhausted with all of the missions.

"I was tired" Catra shrugged. Glimmer looked at her with incredulous eyes and a raised eyebrow.

"Don't forget the fire planet" added Bow, thinking this was a sort of game or remembrance of what they've been through.

"Bow!" Glimmer and Adora snapped at the same time, giving him a murderous stare, making him understand he messed up.

"Sorry…"

"No, thank you, you gave me another point to show I'm right" Catra smiled triumphal, looking at Adora, who seemed to be a bit frustrated.

"Well, okay! But because of all that we are ready, nothing can be worse" Adora sentenced, trying to convince her, but it seemed like she didn't; not wanting to keep on arguing, Catra got up from where she was sitting and walked to the door, with Melog alongside her.

"Let me know when we're there," she asked with a serious tone, as she yawns, abandoning the place. Adora couldn't help but let out a loud sigh, because of that, Glimmer placed her arm around

her friend's shoulder, to show her support. Adora turned around to meet Glimmer's kind smile.

"She'll get over it, don't worry," she said, trying to calm her.

"I hope so"

"She's like a child, surely after her nap, she'll feel better" added Bow, making Adora laugh, "And, if you want me to feel a little better too, I wouldn't mind if you give me a hand to prepare for the last mission," he asked shyly. Both girls hesitated. "Please?", he said almost begging. Adora and Glimmer looked at each other, sighed, and nodded simultaneously.

"Fine, what should we do?"

Glimmer wasn't expecting many instructions, but, to her surprise, she was wrong. Bow started to prepare different groups of "possible equipment" for the mission, which confused the girls a lot, they didn't understand what was the need of all this, but either way, they got to work, helping him using the spare time they had.

"Bow, are we really going to use of all this stuff?" asked Adora, puzzled. She placed the box she was carrying to the side.

"Maybe…" answered the boy, as he kneeled to the ground, revising one of the boxes, searching for something. "We don't have much information about this planet, so I don't know what's going to be more adequate, that's why I'm preparing plenty of alternatives" he informed her, while he grabbed stuff from the box, observed it carefully but upon realizing it wasn't what he was looking for, he'd discard it.

"What are you searching for?" Glimmer asked, entering the room and placing yet another box in the ground, staring at him curiously.

"This!" Bow stood up quickly, with a triumphant smile on his face, holding a small group of pellets in his hands, not quite answering

the queen’s question.

“And what is that?” asked puzzled, while Adora lost her focus in the conversation and placed it in one of the controls, one she never saw, placed in the control desk.

“These are small, but lethal explo-“, started to explain Bow, but stopped when he saw the blonde woman holding the detonator, checking it out curiously.

“What’s this for?” Adora’s finger getting dangerously close to the red button.

“Adora don’t touch that!” the boy’s voice cracked under the pressure, causing the girl to stop on her tracks and lift her arms above her head. Bow walked to her and removed the detonator from her hand carefully; sighing once he had it and leaving Adora speechless. “ It’s a detonator, and these are the bombs” he clarified the doubts of the girls.

“Sorry…” said Adora still processing what almost happened.

“Do you really think we’ll need them?” asked Glimmer, eyeing the bombs with distrust.

“I hope it’s not necessary, but I admit I’ll like to see them in action” Bow couldn’t hide the enthusiasm in his voice; he was truly intrigued with how powerful those small dispositive could actually be.

“Oh, are those my bombs?” Entrapta´s voice could be heard from behind. The group turned around, startled, where the hologram of the young scientist materialized. Without a second thought, they hurried to her projection, quite excited.

“Entrapta, hi!” greeted Glimmer cheerfully, “how are you?”

“We are” she started to say, but a loud explosion in the background interrupted her, worrying them a bit.

“What was that?” asked Adora.

“I think Hordak failed again on what he was doing…” said the girl, laughing careless.

“I don’t fail!” his angry shout was loud enough to be heard for everybody, causing them all to react like Entrapta.

“How’s the rest? Have you been in contact with them?” asked Bow happy to speak to her after such a long time; with how busy they been, and the interference that happened sometimes, it was difficult to keep in touch with their home.

“I think they’re about to log in…” answered Entrapta, confusing the group again, but soon they noticed another small screen that showed an over-exaggerated close-up of Sea Hawk’s face.

“Is it working?” he asked, getting even closer.

“Sea Hawk, move, you’re covering everyone,” said Mermista annoyed, as she pushed him out of frame, which made everybody laugh.

“But I want to see them too” begged the sailor.

“No” denied sharply the princess, then she looked at the group, “Hi everyone”

“Is Catra there?” asked Scorpia, unconsciously moving closer to the screen, trying to enhance the image to get a better look.

“I think she’s sleeping right now, but I’ll tell her you asked for her” answered Adora kindly.

“Oh…”

“Guys, how are you!?” Perfuma, energetic and happily joined the call, greeting with both her hands.

“Glimmer, daughter, how’s the mission going?” asked Micah at the same time, the squad started to get a bit dizzy due to this situation.

“Adora! Are you okay!? Can you hear me?! Swift wind’s strident voice covered the rest, adding himself fervently to the conversation, as the rest tried to speak at the same time, creating a big bustle.

“This is going to be hard…” sighed Glimmer, watching and listening to the mess of that attempt at a group call.

Luckily, after a while, the conversation turned more organic and easy going. Soon enough, everybody was up to speed about the friend squad adventures and the news from Etheria.

“So, the last remaining planet is Zeiren, right?” asked Entrapta curious, Bow nodded.

“Yes, we don’t have much information on that matter, so I’ve been preparing some alternatives…”

“Oh, I believed I found some more information” interrupted Entrapta, “Zeiren is a planet with a high magnetic atmosphere, so I wouldn’t recommend taking any of these…” explained, as she wrote a list on her computer and sent it to him. Bow quickly grabbed his communicator and stared at it intently.

“Okay…” He said a bit worried, “I think nothing I planned will work” he finally added, unhappiness in his voice.

“But you still got time, you can do it,” Perfuma said conciliatory, making Bow smile.

“Actually, if the information I have is right…” corrected Entrapta, staring at her screen and typing on her keyword, “You only have about two hours.”

“Two hours?!” exclaimed Bow, upset. Entrapta smiled and nodded without worries, “Alright I love you all, but I have so much to prepare… Send my regards to my fathers”, after blurting all that out, Bow dismissed himself quickly.

“Is he okay?” Asked a confused, and recently logged in Frosta.

The girls only stayed a little bit longer speaking with everybody, but in the end, they decided not to extend it much further. Although they missed their friends and family, they also wanted to help Bow. He left them very worried with his nervousness; they understood there was a lot that needed to be done and so little time to do so, as such, they followed him to get the preparations done.

The hours went faster than expected, and soon enough they realized how close their new destiny was, to the point that they could observe such imposing planet displayed before them, with a great variety of warm colors; red being the main one, which was the color of the ground. Despite the whole experience, and all the places previously visited, they couldn’t help but be in awe of each and every one of the planets, which were so incredibly unique on their own terms.

After a couple of minutes of admiring fascination, Bow walked to the control desk to type in the database of the old map they had of the place, trying to get the coordinates of the main village.

“I’m gonna get Catra” Adora let her friends know, placing the small backpack they managed to load, on the floor.

To the surprise and discomfort of Bow, according to Entrapta's list, only a few items could be used on the planet, so he prayed to no meet so many problems out there.

Adora left the room in a rush, begging that Catra was already awake, so she wouldn’t have to and face her broody mood; but luckily to her, before she made it to the bedroom, Catra appeared rubbing her eyes, with Melog by her side.

“Are we there yet?” asked then yawned.

Adora was about to respond with a big smile, but a huge tremor interrupted her, pushing her and Catra to one of the ships’ walls.

“Sorry girls, we’re landing” explained Bow, a bit tense and nervous, “I made a tiny mistake, hold on.” He warned while the ship started to shake more and Adora and Catra ran to hold onto some metal bars near them.

“I wouldn’t have mind to be notified beforehand…”, complained Catra as she wrapped one arm around the metal bar, and the other to Melog.

“I’m sorry but we’ve been busy, Bow had to change all our plans because Entrapta told him what we had was worthless…” she explained fast, with difficulty. She could feel her arms giving up. Catra was in a similar position, or even in a worst one since she was holding herself and Melog at the same time; that’s why, when the pressure got higher she couldn’t take it anymore prompting her to let go.

“Adora!” she yelled, at the same time Melog whimpered. The blonde girl, who had her eyes closed, opened them quickly and without thinking twice, transformed into She-ra and threw herself down to catch them both and use her own big body as a receptor for the impact, it left a big yet shallow bash on the wall.

Chapter End Notes

Hello, my name is Oriana, first of all I want to thank you for reading this chapter. I also want to clarify that the story is already finished, so there is no risk that I will leave it in the middle or anything like that, it will be published every Monday and Friday (There are 7 chapters (14 parts)) . (It is available in Spanish for those who want to read it in that language).

Do not hesitate to leave your comments or criticisms. For news and curiosities of the story, follow me on Instagram (@

redliepardw) or on twitter (@ redliepard), I will be uploading news and warning each time I upload a new chapter.

Thank you very much again, I hope you like it!

Translated by: Micaela Agata
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# Chapter 1: Alone Together (Part 2)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Adora!” she yelled, at the same time Melog whimpered. The blonde girl, who had her eyes closed, opened them quickly and without thinking twice, transformed into She-ra and threw herself down to catch them both and use her own big body as a receptor for the impact, it left a big yet shallow bash on the wall.

Fortunately, it didn’t take much longer for the ship to stabilize itself, confirming that they were close to touching land, which meant an end to the girls’ problems.

“Are you guys okay?” asked Adora, far more concerned about their safety than her own.

“We are fine. What about you?” Catra examined her worryingly, which made Adora smile, she drifted from the wall and returned to her normal shape.

“I’m…”

“Oh my god!” Yelled Glimmer, running towards them, and alarmed once she saw the hole in the ship, “Are you okay?”

“We’ve been worse” answered Catra with a smile, looking at Adora who smiled as well.

“I’m so glad you’re okay. Bow was so nervous that when he types the coordinates he unconsciously accepted the automatic landing” she explained sighing, still shaken.

“Don’t worry, we are fine” repeated Adora with a reassuring smile.

The three girls walked to Bow’s location, the boy was focused, supervising that everything worked accordingly as they were a few meters away from landing, so the trio stood there in silence observing how Bow managed even the slightest detail. Once they finally landed, Bow let go of all the pressure inside him with a loud sigh.

“I’m sorry for what happened…” he whispered turning around to face them, verifying that they were safe and sound.

“You almost kill us, but we survived” commented Catra exaggerating, trying to upset him.

“It wasn’t so bad!” interrupted Adora nervously, not wanting the boy to feel bad, as she tried to give Catra a menacing look.

“If it wasn’t for She-ra, we’d be probably dead…” she added without paying attention.

“Catra!”

“No, it’s true…” Bow stopped her, getting up from his seat and walking towards them, “It was dangerous and I’m sorry, but I’m very tired and I did almost everything without thinking, “he apologized crestfallen and distressed.

“It’s fine, just don’t make another mistake that can kill us” answered Catra without letting go of her pride.

“Soon we’ll arrive at the town and you’ll be able to rest.” Glimmer hugged him, trying to show her support. The boy smiled briefly, but he couldn’t move past the guiltiness he felt.

After their rocky landing, the friend squad- equipped with the small backpack full of equipment- exited the ship, still somewhat dizzy. Their discomfort heightened with the extreme heat and the high humidity that slap them as soon as they touch the red earth; a big and thick jungle surrounded them, not allowing them to see anything beyond a few meters.

Bow remained nearby the ship and seemed to get stuck in a loop that consisted of staring at the map to look around where they stood. The boy noticed that something didn’t go according to plan. Nervous, he started to curse under his breath, unable to believe how unlucky they were.

Glimmer, Adora, and Catra watched how the young archer lowered and lifted his gaze from the device countless times. After a while, the anxiety of not knowing what was happening started to grow deep in Catra, until she finally exploded:

“God, what’s happening?!” Bow seemed to ignore her, so Catra already bothered and without being able to take the situation any longer, walked to Bow and grabbed the map from his hands to look at it herself, not quite understanding what it said.

“I think I miscalculated…” started to explain the boy, shrinking, embarrassed for his mistake.

“What?!” Yelled Catra hysteric, loud enough to make the birds around the scattered, “What do you mean “miscalculated”? “What does that mean?” she asked, grabbing him by the collar of his suit, dramatically shaking him.

“I’m sorry,” said Bow, terrified and truly sorry, not knowing how to keep justifying all the mistakes he kept having.

“Catra, calm down” plead Adora.

Catra looked at her and, after thinking it through, complied with the girls’ plead and finally let go of him. She walked away kicking rocks, trying to defuse her anxiety and bad mood.

Glimmer got closer to Bow, to try to give him some support: the boy appeared desolated, and it wasn’t from Catra mistreatment, but also for everything that kept happening because of him.

“How bad is it?” asked the queen, fearful of the answer, but attempting to be as nice as possible as she stood beside him, putting her hand in his shoulder.

“We’ll have to walk some kilometers, and we can’t use the ship again, because we might run out of energy to go back home afterward…” he explained, looking at the ground. Catra, hearing this, started to breathe deeply, trying to compose herself. Adora, who watched both situations, was growing more and more nervous, given that things weren’t going particularly well. “And it’s getting dark, so we should rush”, he added. Catra kicked a rock harshly.

“Everything will be okay!” said Adora nervously, attempting to defuse the situation. “We’ll spend the night here, Melog will make the ship invisible to evade any predators, and we’ll be safe.” She explained her idea.

“But if we do that…” tried shyly to contradict Bow.

“WHAT?!” asked Adora upset, scaring the boy. She, acknowledging her loss of control, inhaled deeply then looked at Bow. “My apologies, if we do that, what awful thing might happen?” asked again, calmly.

“If we stay in the ship we’d have to turn it on, which means energy loss” explained, already scared of bringing more bad news.

“Well, but we can stay without using energy, right?” she asked him. Bow nodded. ”Great, so, how bad can it be?” retorted Adora, laughing nervously.

Without any further questioning, they chose the alternative raised by Adora; who clearly didn’t take into consideration the coldness of the night time. Something that surprised them, since it was a complete contradiction of the temperature they experienced in the afternoon.

The friend squad tracked and snatched all the blankets available, but these didn’t seem to be enough: the ship was pretty much a refrigerator.

“I think this was a bad idea”, Adora corrected herself, shivering.

“Really? What makes you say that?” asked Catra ironically, staring at her upset, shivering like the rest, and covered head to toes in one of the blankets. Melog, which was wearing his own coat, lied down by her side, eating his food.

“If you had a better idea, you should have said it” Adora retorted quickly, provoking Catra, but before she could answer back, Glimmer entered the room holding a tray with four steaming cups.

“What is that?” asked Bow, with shine in his eyes, as Catra and Adora turned around to look too.

“I used my magic and made something warm to drink… it’s not much but…”

The three, without thinking much more, jump at it like beasts to grab one of those delicious beverages, interrupting the witch’s monologue, which got surprised by such reaction.

“Ah this is amazing, Glimmer, thank you very much,” said Bow charmed, while he sipped from his cup, the queen couldn’t help but smile.

“You are the best, thanks” added Adora happy.

The only one left was Catra, which was smiling slightly at the warm feeling of the cup in her hands, but couldn’t be bothered to say anything about it, something that Glimmer wasn’t gonna let slide, so she centered her gaze on her, waiting with an arrogant yet funny smile, some type of devolution.

“What?” she asked indifferently but got serious once she noticed the queen’s expectancy, who wouldn’t stop smiling.

“Oh, c’mon, at least said that you like it” answered Glimmer, causing Catra to rolled her eyes and let out a small groan.

“Yes, is good…” she said indifferently, taking another sip and looking elsewhere. To Glimmer it was enough, she knew how Catra was and that was more than a compliment coming from someone so annoyed.

The friend squad enjoyed their drinks and then, after some conversations that lighten the mood, they finally went to sleep. Bow resting his back against the wall, and Glimmer on his shoulder; Melog slept nearby Catra protectively, and she was curled up, one arm stretched, her hand barely touching Adora’s, who slept completely scattered on the cold floor.

Everybody rested as placidly as they could in that situation; or at least, the peace remained for a couple of hours until Catra, who wasn’t dreaming anything, in particular, started to. In the dream she opened her eyes, confused as she listened to some footsteps getting close; but the girl didn’t get up to investigate, she just assumed it was probably nothing important. So Catra just decided to take a look at her surroundings and try to resume sleeping once she noticed nothing unusual, but at the moment she tried to close her eyes again, suddenly she felt the hair on her body bristle as a presence materialized behind her.

“Bring her to me,” said the voice of what sounded like a girl, whispering in Catra’s ear.

Catra woke up agitated, convinced that someone was on the ship, and because of that, she started to minutely observe the

place: the first thing she noticed was that she was holding Adora's hand, which made her smile shyly, but then, when she turned to see Melog, Catra found the animal a little twitched and slightly red staring intently at the ship's door. This sent a shiver down her spine since it didn't make it easier to believe it was just a dream, although, at the same time, there weren't any clues that someone has gotten in. So she tried to ease Melog and she lay back down, holding Adora's hand a little bit tighter, making the latter smile subconsciously.

After the incident, Catra lie tense and on edge for the remainder of the night, unable to shut an eye as she thought on everything that had happened, and despite her worries, she didn't want to upset her friends, so she waited as patiently as she could for the morning to arise.

When the sunlight started coming in through the big glasses of the ship, there was no need for Catra to wake up her friends; Glimmer and Bow did it automatically due to the clarity slightly blinding them. The only one seemingly unaware was Adora, who kept sleeping happily.

"Adora, wake up," said Catra, softly shaking her shoulder.

"A little bit longer…" she requested, with a dumb smile, as she turned to her side. Catra spoke no more, she just stared at Melog, letting him understand to wake her up, so the cute animal got close to Adora and started licking her face, "Melog, no" asked the blonde between smiles, but he wouldn't relent, "Okay, fine, I give up." she said, as she sat down, petting him, "Morning" she greeted with a smile watching them all. Bow and Glimmer were stretching, given that the position they slept in hadn't been the best, Catra, who was in front of her doing the same as the aforementioned, answered to her smile with one of her own.

“Good morning, Adora” she greeted, extending her arm to help her stand up.

“Good morning,” said Glimmer and Bow at the same time, a little worn out.

“Good, we already said “Good morning”, now little genius explain to us the new plan,” asked Catra expectantly, looking at Bow.

“Follow the map where the town is supposed to be” he answered, as he took it, “I was able to mark the point where we stand, so it won’t be a problem to just follow it..”

“Yes, fine, but this time I’ll handle it,” said Catra, taking it out of his hands.

“Hey! You don’t even know how to read it” the boy scolded her, trying to get the map back, to no avail due to the young girl’s agility.

“I think I can learn to do it better than you” was her answer, while she sticks her tongue out, smiling arrogantly.

“Are you sure that…” tried to question Adora.

“Are you doubting me” interrupted her, raising an eyebrow. “I defeated you all dozens of times while using plenty of these maps, I’m more than capable…”

“Okay, that’s enough” Glimmer's annoyed voice was heard, causing the three of them to stop. “Bow takes your arrows, Adora

get ready, and Catra "she started to order, then turned to the latter, "I seriously hope you know what you're doing", she added, a bit threatening, which didn't seem to inhibit the girl at all.

"Don't worry, my queen, I promise to take you all safe and sound to the village we were already meant to be at" she answered ironically, to then stare at Bow with some apprehension still.

"I hope so," said Glimmer still distrustful, but Catra kept her snooty smile, which was ignored by her, "Are you guys ready?" she asked at Adora and Bow.

"Yeah, it's just… what are we going to do with Melog?" asked Adora, doubtful.

"I guess the best is for him to stay guarding the ship, stopping anybody from attacking it… or steal it" Catra was quick to respond, interrupting Glimmer before she could speak. Melog let out a groan hearing her words, "Yes, of course, we'll leave you food and we'll try to come back as soon as possible", she answered, caressing his back.

"Well then, we are ready now, shall we go?" asked Glimmer. The rest nodded.

Catra said goodbye to Melog, keeping her promise of leaving plenty of food and trying not to get very sentimental; clearly, the idea of keeping him behind wasn't her favorite, but this planet was completely unknown to them, and they didn't want to take the risk of having the ship exposed in such faraway place.

“We are going to come back soon,” said the girl to her pet, resting her forehead on that of the animal, and before Catra walked away, he gave her a little kiss, causing her to smile, “I love you too” she answered honestly, forgetting that the group was still standing there, watching the scene with teary eyes. Catra, becoming self-aware, turned around to give them a murderous stare. “Don’t you dare say something”, she warned before they did, making the trio tried to contain themselves.

The friend squad had a long walk ahead of them, something, they thought, were mentally ready to face, but after some kilometers, the emotion of the adventure defused as well as their security. It was an overly hot and humid day, completely different to what they experience at night and even worse than the day before; the air was extremely heavy, to the point where they felt drowned, and the sun seemed to burn their skin. The water they carry gave the impression that it wasn’t going to last, and that fear resulted to be true; halfway they ran out. Although they were worried, they decided not to let this completely discourage them.

Catra, tired for being almost unable to sleep and because of the long walk, allowed the rest to get ahead of her, and once she stood out of sight, she pretended to fall. Bow, Glimmer, and Adora, alerted by the noise, turned around quickly, and when the blonde saw what happened, she hurried to the girl. Bow and Glimmer, instead, remained skeptical looking at the scene, doubting Catra.

“Catra, what happened? Are you alright?” asked Adora worried, trying the help her stand up.

“I think a tripped with a bran… ouch” she complained while standing, faking pain, “I think I sprained my ankle.”

“Do you want me to carry you?” offered Adora worried, with a certain innocence.

“Adora, do you really believe her?” interrupted Glimmer, walking over, before Catra got what she clearly intended, unable to understand how her friend always fell for the girl’s lies.

“I don’t get why she’d lie” she answered very securely, transforming in She-ra and letting Catra hang on her back.

“Thanks, Adora,” Catra said, as she stuck her tongue out to Glimmer without Adora realizing, causing the Queen to get completely incensed, but before she could say anything, Bow placed his hand on her shoulder, trying to appease her, while laughing.

“Let her be” Said Bow with a smile, taking the weight off the matter, watching how Adora and Catra went happily on their way.

Glimmer let out a loud sigh but complied with the boy’s suggestion, ignoring the matter and starting to walk again following them.

The friend squad followed Catra´s instructions, and according to her, the main village was just around the corner. So they, albeit exhausted, felt a little more relieved and carefree.

Hours passed by, the sunset grew near and the jungle seemed to get a little thicker. She-ra, noticing this, was forced to utilize her sword to make way for them, provoking the bugs to fly closely.

“Are we th…AH!” attempted Bow to ask, but he was interrupted by the bug climbing up his arm.

“What happened?” asked Glimmer worried turning around, same as Adora and Catra when she heard the scream, but once they saw what it was, they couldn’t help but laugh, “Bow, it’s just a tiny insect, it can’t hurt you,” remarked, walking over him to remove that nasty insect, but to her surprise and disgust, it started flying, “It flies!”, Glimmer yelled alongside Bow, who started running around, chased by the fly. Adora started to do the same, without paying attention to anything in front of her, nor the direction they had taken.

Catra couldn’t see the map due to the branches that hit her face, but luckily the noise it made let her know they were almost there.

“Wait!” she ordered, making them stop abruptly.

Completely exhausted, they all bend over to regain their breath; clearly running hadn’t done anything but completely exhausted them.

The group looked around, seeing nothing but plants and big trees surrounding them, which confuse them a little since it didn’t appear like they were anywhere near any town.

“Catra, you think you can go on your own for now?” asked Adora, agitated, Catra nodded and climbed down with a smile, so the girl could abandon She-ra’s form.

“That’s no problem since I won’t have to do that, because…” she said while, with a conceited smile and staring at the map, she took a few steps and removed some plants to open the path; the rest just followed her with curious eyes, “We’re here”, she indicated looking upfront, but her smile faded by the sight ahead of her. The place was far different from what she was expecting, and when she looked down at the map; she realized that what

she was following up until that point, had vanished. “Wait, I…” she tried to justify herself, but Bow walked over and took the map from her hands.

“Catra, you said you could read it!” he scolded her, justifiably; “We even deviate!” Bow exclaimed, even more, upset as he checked their location.

“Yes, I know, I swear it was there the whole time, now it disappeared.” She tried to justify herself, unable to understand what had happened.

“That’s impossible” Glimmer stressed, upset too.

“I’m sorry Miss Perfection, but perhaps the map your boyfriend built is defective” she retorted, causing the latter to blush, same as Bow.

“Don’t try to move the focus of the conversation!” said Glimmer, her cheeks still red.

The three kept arguing like children, but Adora wasn’t paying attention. Her eyes posed over the ruins of that place, curious for how immense it was. The whole place looked like it had been abandoned a long time ago; and nature had started to proclaim themselves as proprietors, with beautiful flowers and plants, that gave the impression to be a part of the architecture of the tall towers and the vast hallways. Adora, fascinated by her surroundings and interested to see how the inside was, decided to walked in to investigate, without letting the rest know since they stayed focus on their argument.

“Hello!” she yelled, not expecting any answer, her voice echoing around. She turned to her right, nothing but darkness. Then, when she turned to her left, she managed to see a shadow moving afar; Adora walked deeper into the hallway, trying to see if it was a person or some animal, “It’s somebody there?” she asked a little afraid, but still walking until she was met with a staircase, which she climbed without a thought, reaching a floor filled with old and empty furniture, weathered flags hanging on the walls. The blonde girl got clearly worried at the sight; maybe no one had managed to survive, or, if they did, they had escaped, abandoning everything behind them. Adora was so absorbed in staring at that place, she didn’t notice someone was behind her, looking at her intently.

“What are you doing here?” asked a girl, with a serious voice, but with a tone that made her sound sweet at the same time, which caused Adora to jump a little for the scare she caused her.

Turning around, to see who was behind her, she was met face to face with a young woman. She looked a bit older than Adora, with a big burgundy robe, short and white hair, and deep purple eyes, which stared at her attentive, with distrust.

“Oh my god, you almost killed me,” Adora said, a hand on her chest due to agitation, but the other girl kept her severe stare, a fact that made the blonde one think that, maybe, her hostess was not going to be super friendly. “I’m sorry, I didn’t know you were behind me, my name is Adora,” she said, justifying herself and stretching her arm so they could be properly introduced, but the other girl did nothing but look at her up and down, analyzing her. “Do you guys greet each other some other way?” she asked, uncomfortable.

“I asked you a question” was the elusive response at Adora's’, who was surprised at such hostility, but remembering that probably the

people of this place had suffered a lot in hands of Horde Prime, making them distrustful of any stranger.

"I'm sorry" she apologized again, this time more serious, as she stood uptight, "ME and my group came from Etheria to help you."

"And how do you think to do so?" asked the girl with an incredulous smile.

"I'll show you" she answered smiling, taking a step back and raising her hand, "For the honor of Grayskull" yelled Adora, transforming. The other girl stood there, surprised. "I got the ability to transform into She-ra, a legendary warrior…" started to explain Adora proudly.

Bow, Glimmer, and Catra kept arguing, or at least they were until the latter became aware of the glow coming from the tower, causing her to shut up and search for Adora with her gaze, unable to find her nearby. A little nervous, she turned to let her friends know but stopped in her tracks realizing that all noises had vanished, only silence remaining. She could see Bow and Glimmer talking, but she couldn't hear them. This altered her even more.

"Thanks, kitty", she heard all of sudden, almost like a whisper in her ear, with a voice that sounded terrifyingly familiar, since it was the same she perceived last night, in her dream.

Immediately her hearing returned, and without wasting more time, walked over Bow and Glimmer, who were looking at her, awaiting some type of response.

“Where’s Adora?” asked Catra worried and disturbed, interrupting the duo as they tried to scold her for something she didn’t make up, provoking them to shut up as well, to search for her, confused.

“I don’t know” answered Bow, not understanding where she could have gone. “She was here just a moment ago…”

“Catra, are you alright?” Glimmer asked the girl, seeing how pale and nervous she was.

She didn’t answer, given that she believed to have an idea of Adora’s whereabouts, but before she could say it, a big animal pounced over them; without hesitation, Catra pushed Bow and Glimmer out of the way so as not to get crushed.

Adora tried to offer an explanation on who she and her friends were, their story, and the journey they’d embarked up until that moment, but the other girl didn’t appear very perceptive to it.

“You’re She-ra?” asked interrupting the speech, with a victorious smile, “Finally” she murmured. Adora gave her a confused look, but before she could ask the meaning of that word, the mysterious girl quickly materialized a sword and went after her.

She-ra noticed this just in time so that she could stop the attack with her own sword.

“What are you doing,” she asked bewildered, but the other one just walked away a few meters, keeping eye contact with her intact smile.

“Nice to meet you, She-ra,” she said as she charged a spell with her left hand, “my name is Eira” finally introduced herself, to then send another attack with her magic.

Adora this time wasn’t fast enough with her reaction, that’s why her body hit the feeble wall behind her at full speed, creating a huge hole that made her collapsed against the ground harshly.

The rest of her friends turned around automatically hearing the commotion, nonetheless, there wasn’t much they could do to help her, as they were on as many grave problems, trying to avoid the creature- standing across the field- to devour them.

Chapter End Notes

Hi! How are you? This is the final of the first chapter (that’s practically an introduction). I hope you're liking it.
I Will be posting on twitter (@redliepard) and Instagram (@redliepardw) some desings of escenarios and some sketchs from new chacters, so if you want to see them, follow me.
Thanks again for be reading the story, we’ll see you on friday!
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# Chapter 2: Nightmare (Part 1)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Catra go help Adora!" yelled Bow while dodging another lunge.

"Are you sure?" asked her doubtful, the boy nodded focused on shooting an arrow at the animal.

Catra, still feeling apprehensive, but without thinking too much, ran to where She-ra lay. Getting to see from the distance how a white-haired girl peeked over the hole that Adora was ejected a few moments ago.

"We came to help!" continue to yell Adora, not noticing the ground below her started to crack.

"Yeah, cool. Good trip." Answered Eira with a smile, watching from the tower.

Once again, She-ra was slow with her reaction, being that the floor started to collapse with no possibilities to run or hold herself from anywhere.

"Adora!" cried Catra.

She sped up, but she was still too far away to help her. Although, for both the girl's fortune, between the bushes, the hooded figure of a boy appeared and grabbed Adora's arm, helping her up before the latter vanished in the enormous void created.

The boy had a striking physical resemblance with Eira, except for his eyes, which were green. He dressed in a burgundy suit with

some black details, looking like a medieval archer.

"My dear brother, why do you always spoil my fun?" asked Eira as she descended.

"You are using her, but you are not my sister, Laurel" he replied resentfully, making the girl smile and Adora looked confused, not getting why the man referred to her with a different name.

The boy exchanged no more words, he unleashed his bow and darted, at full speed, an arrow to the sorceress. She took it with one hand, breaking it in half, to the boy's frustration.

"Way too slow and predict-" started to say Eira in a jovial tone, but suddenly Catra appeared, taking her by surprise, and punch her hard in her face, provoking her to lose stability and get thrown meters away.

"That's for pushing Adora and messing with my dreams!"

The sorceress stood back up slowly, with a hand on her cheek and a surprising look at Catra.

"You hit hard, kitty" she assured, to then teleport behind Catra, "I really didn't expect that from you," she said, with a voice more similar to the one Catra had heard in her nightmares, paralyzing her.

Fortunately for her, before Eira could attack her, She-ra appeared on the scene, preventing her to accomplish it, and forcing her to teleport over the construction in front of them, to avoid another punch.

Adora was ready to jump to the attack once again, but she stopped when she heard Glimmer and Bow struggling with their opponent, making her turn around to look at them, then back at the sorcerer, unsure of what to do.

"You should help your friends, She-ra" she advised smiling like she could read her mind. "We'll meet each other again, but for now, I think it's enough."

The girl disappeared as fast as she had appeared. Leaving a bitter taste on Adora, who stayed tense and a bit frustrated, however, there was nothing else to do. Without a second thought she, Catra, and the mysterious boy ran over to help Glimmer and Bow, ready to face a ferocious battle against such a terrible creature. Yet, their surprise was extreme as they noticed that the creature that, a couple of seconds ago wanted to devour them, had become a tiny and adorable feline.

Bow, who had bravely interposed in between the, up until that moment the terrible creature and Glimmer, to protect her, still kept his eyes closed, unaware of the change. Glimmer, who did observe it, walked slowly, and over the boy's shoulder, she stared at the creature, which made sounds similar to a meow trying to gain their attention.

"Oh my god," said Glimmer tenderly, getting closer to the little animal. Bow opened his eyes confused. "And you wanted to eat us a second ago?" she asked as she picked it up, and the feline rubbed her as it purred.

"Glimmer, what are you doing?! Be careful!" yelled Bow, running to her side.

"But Bow, look!" she said as she brought the animal closer to him, yet the boy remained skeptical. "He won't hurt us, is harmless."

"Glimmer, two seconds ago he wanted to eat us!"

The queen of Etheria seemed to have completely forgotten about whatever had happened.

"My sister can control animals, it's probable he attacked you for that reason" explained the stranger man, observing the small animal that kept enjoying the Glimmer's love.

"And you are…?" asked Bow at seeing him.

"My name is Archie, I am the brother of the girl who attacked your friend." he clarified, looking at Adora, who was standing at his side, alongside Catra, "By the way, I'm sorry about that."

"It's not your fault, you tried to help us, so thanks." Reassured the archer. "I'm Bow, that's Glimmer, those are Adora and Catra.

"You're welcome, it's a pleasure to meet all of you and I'd like to keep talking but if we don't want to be attacked, we ought to move along to get to the village as soon as possible" Archie explained cordially, and the rest agreed.

"Bye, little friend" whispered Glimmer sadly, leaving the feline on the ground and watching it go away, getting lost in the breadth of the vegetation.

With no further delay, the new group of five started to walk, guided by Archie, who opened the way through the jungle with a machete. The rest felt extremely curious, they wished to ask a lot of questions, but none of them dare to break the ice, so they walked calmly and quietly, listening to just the birches falling and some other bird around them. This was so until Adora posed her attention in what seemed to be houses made of dirt, stopping and walking over, intrigued.

"What's this?" she asked, her hand inching closer to touch it.

Archie, seeing what she was about to do, stopped in his tracks, and ran to stopped her.

"Don't you dare do that!" he warned as he pushed her away.

"Why?" Adora stared at the guy like he was overreacting until she saw how a gigantic look-alike ant came out of it, making her scream in terror. "What is that?!" she asked terrified, hiding behind Bow, who wasn't far better than her.

Catra witnessed the scene quite entertained, but Glimmer appeared to be just like the other two.

"The Punquis get extremely violent if someone touches their home, and these are so big because they expect their victim to get in to…"

"We get it!" interrupted Bow, Adora, and Glimmer even more horrified by picturing the scene.

"If that's the case, then let's move along, but please don't touch anything without asking me first" he warned as Adora and Bow nodded quickly like two children.

"Oh, Adora, I can't lose you from my sight for two seconds that you are trying to enter the trap of some alien bug with an adorable name," retorted Catra, faking indignation, while she placed her elbow on the girl's shoulder, laughing at the bizarre situation.

"Well, excuse me, an expert on alien insects, but at least I can dodge a luminous spider web." Said Adora, containing her laughter.

"What…?"

Catra couldn’t finish her question that she saw herself being covered by the web; it was quite sticky, so it was difficult to take it off. When she finally managed, she noticed a small spider staring at her from her hand, this made her let out a wheeze as she shook to get rid of it, then she walked over to Adora, staring at her angrily as if this was all her fault. Although nothing became of it, because Archie stopped in his tracks putting the group on alert mode.

“I think it will be best to camp in this abandoned town, nearby” he explained as he looks up at the sky, which was already all dark and filled with stars, “We still have some stretch to do and it won’t be a good idea to do so without light… and cold.” He added grabbing a branch, lighting it on fire with an artifact, “If you’re able, try to collect some wood, it might be a tough night unless we are prepared.”

“Don’t tell us about it, we already experienced it” said Catra angrily, side-eyeing Bow, who immediately felt alluded by it.

“How many times do I need to apologize?!” exclaimed the boy with his broken voice.

“Enough Catra, get over it,” asked Glimmer, “Besides it wasn’t so bad” she remembered with a smile how cozy she had been with Bow.

“Yes, because you were with your…”

“Could you guys stop fighting, Archie is already moving” interrupted Adora, who was a bit ahead of them, pointing at the young man, barely visible in the thickness of the jungle by his small flame.

Catra and Glimmer stared at each other with play pretend enmity, sighing simultaneously. Then they hurried in their steps, same as Bow, trying to reach Adora and their guide.

It wasn’t long enough until they got to the place, proving that Archie hadn’t lie about it, and neither did he about the weather. The coldness was already present and it had even frozen the plants slightly. Which again, differed with the extremely hot temperature of the day, and it was even lower than that of the previous night.

The group entered the town, which seemed to had been abandoned without prior notice; there was furniture, clothes, paintings, instruments, and all sorts of intact belongings. The friend squad observed everything with some heartache. Archie looked at it as well, and he couldn’t help but feel a big nostalgia at remembering all the moments he had spent in that town, playing with his friends and being happy, without feeling any sort of worry or fear at anything.

Adora saw something on the floor, she kneeled balancing the wood she was carrying, to grab something that caught her attention. A small doll that had seen better days. Now, it was covered in red dirt, just like the rest of the abandoned stuff. Her mind drifted away for a few seconds by picturing a young boy dropping it, later unable to come back for it.

“What happened here? It doesn’t look that they were under attack” asked Adora, the same thing the rest was thinking, given the good state of the surrounding structures.

Archie stopped and opened the door of a giant house, and then he looked at her.

“When the invasion arrived, all the faraway villages were evacuated and taken to the main center” he explained, looking everywhere and rememorizing like it happened yesterday.

“Because Horde Prime was unpredictable to us, we took advantage of his seconds of peace to translate everybody as quick

as possible, so most people didn't have the time to grab their stuff…"

"We get it, it was terrible for us too" sympathized Bow, remembering as well everything they been through.

Archie just answered with a sad smile, the boy would have like to resume the conversation, but this couldn't happen since water drops started to fall, accompany by some loud thunders.

"We should get in" he advised, checking at the ugly turning weather.

Adora grabbed the firewood with both hands again, and obeyed like the rest, entering that cold and dark home. Archie immediately started to lit more torches, attempting to generate some light.

"You can drop the wood over there" he pointed at a majestic chimney," but keep half of it for your rooms"

"Our rooms?" asked Glimmer puzzled, doing what they were told, Archie walked over to light the chimney.

"There are two rooms; one with two single beds, and the other, at the end of the hallway, with one." Explained the host, pointing to the right place "Someone will have to share, or sleep in the ground… which I'd advise against…" he said, while observing a tiny insect walking on the floor. "Hmm… I don't remember seeing one of this kind" he said, holding it, as the rest stared at him grossed out, the bug tried its best to escape from his touch and the boy inspected it attentively, searching for familiarities until he finally found it. "Ah, I know what you are" he affirmed as he dropped it where he found it, and then he faced the squad, that

stared at him disgusted. “He is harmless” Archie clarified, innocently.

“Yeah, whatever you say” answered Catra still grossed out, looking as the bug escape under a door frame.

“Where will you sleep?” asked Adora.

Archie looked at her and pointed at a large couch at the end of the room, behind a round and big table.

“This place is not too bad, because this is where I usually come or where my people come when they’re out hunting or scavenging resources” he explained, as he sat in that comfortable seat covered in fur. “So don’t be afraid to use whatever is in here” added with his raspy voice while he took a water bottle, sipping from it. “Want some?”

They all looked at each other, and, desperately, they took the recipient to each drink from it.

“Thanks so much, I felt like I was gonna die of thirst” acknowledged Bow.

“I also have some food, if you’d like” offered Archie, taking some fruits, and some other snacks from a small purse he carried on his waist.

“That’d be great!” yelled Adora with her mouth filled with water, her stomach rumbling.

The squad, not waiting much, started munching what Archie gave them. No doubt they were hungry, especially Adora, who had to be controlled by the rest, so she wouldn’t eat all of it mindlessly.

While they dine under a roof solid enough to contain the rain, Eira found herself walking under it. The weather worsened each time, and it didn't appear to want to improve in the slightest. The sorceress was protected by her hoodie, but even this started to leak a little, making her shiver at the cold. Although, to her luck, she was close to her destination; some buildings she used as a refuge, not far from where she faced the friend squad.

Upon arrival, she entered as fast as she could, removing her soaking cape and lighting a fire. Eira stood near the glowing flame, rubbing her hands on her arms, trying to give herself some warmth.

In the middle of the silence, she couldn't avoid remembering what happened some hours ago; her cheek still hurt due to Catra's hit, and, at rubbing slightly her bruise with her hand, she let out a small whimper.

"She hits much harder than I expected" she murmured, putting a bit more weight with her cold hand, trying to relieve the pain a little bit.

"I'm sorry; I didn't realize she was close" she heard Laurel say as if she was physically there, but actually only she could hear her.

"No, it's also my fault" Eira sighed while she sat on her improvised bed, staring at the fire.

"Should we stopped challenging her?" asked Laurel, while Eira lay down, covering herself with a few blankets, "Because it's interesting how much she lost control, we should take advantage of that… but if you don't want to put yourself at risk, I'll get it."

"Yes, you can do anything you want, if you think is a good plan, I'll follow you" Eira accepted, a little tired, with her eyes closed, she drew a shape in the air which created a small gleam of light, "But try to not get me beat up again," she asked her with a smile, feeling like she was about to fall sleep.

"Deal. Sweet dreams, princess."

Eira smiled again, and without much difficulty, she fell asleep; the confrontation against the friend squad left her exhausted, and things looked unpromising from now on, as such, she didn't want to spend her valuable rest time thinking of anything she had spoken with Laurel a hundred times already. Besides, sleeping was her second favorite activity, after magic. It had always been, even when the usage of the first didn't imply what it did now, so any excuse to do so was more than welcome.

Many kilometers away, the friend squad was finishing eating. Adora, who had finished first, kept ogling the food on the table, still hungry, but aware that the food didn't belong to her.

"Here" offered Catra, giving her the last portion of her plate, faking disinterest.

Adora looked at her with shiny eyes, emotional, but stopped before grabbing it.

"Are you sure?" she asked politely, even if she was dying to eat it.

"Yep"

"Thanks" she appreciated with a big smile on her face, and still a bit emotional, she started eating happily.

Catra, who was looking at her side-eye, couldn't help but smile; Bow and Glimmer witnessed the scene, touched, but when Catra noticed it, she directed a not-so-friendly stare at them, keeping them to make any comment about it. They got the message and kept eating ignoring the tender scene they watched.

They chat entertained about superficial stuff about Zeiren, and about Etheria too, until Adora suddenly remembered how Archie had called Eira "Laurel", something that at that moment confused her a lot, but up until that moment she didn't have the time to resolve, so she decided to seize the moment and do it.

"May I ask something?" finally asked, interrupting the conversation, and making all the eyes focus on her and Archie, who seemed unprepared.

"Sure."

"What happened here? And who's Laurel?"

Chapter End Notes

Hi! I hope you're liking the story. This entire chapter is, without doubt, one of my favorites and in the second part there going to be some interesting revelations…
I want to ask you a something, Do you prefer to read the chapter this way, split in two, or would you rather the whole chapter per week? So far I chose to split it so it wouldn´t be so long, but if you preferred it the other way I can change it.

Thank you for reading, I hope you have a great weekend and I'll see you on Monday!

Written by: Oriana Ruiz Diaz (@RedLiepard (twitter) / @ redliepardw (ig))
Translated by: Micaela Agata (@BlondePhoenixx)

# Chapter 2: Nightmare (Part 2)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"What happened here? And who's Laurel?"

The young man knew that question was inevitable, so he had tried to prep himself during their journey, but facing the past was never easy, much less when that meant remembering stuff that still hurt him.

"The story is long, I must explain other things too, and maybe you are tired..."

"No problem, if you want to talk, we'll listen" answered Bow.

"Okay" Archie sighed loudly and, maintaining his eyes on the fire, he started to answer Adora's question, "This planet was full of resources, we used them, but we respected nature so she would respect us, for that, we wouldn't take more than we needed. We never expected war, but still, we had soldiers in case of need; but they weren't as technologically advanced as in other planets." He explained, his head transporting him to those good old days of peace. He smiled, and looked back at the fire, "Neither did we need them. Because we had amazing sorceresses like my mother-the queen- or my grandmother; and great warriors like my father the king-. As far to Eira and me, we were both apprentices of my grandmother, I was still young but my sister, a bit older than me, already showed signs of being a powerful wizard, quickly overcoming any challenge put in her way." He affirmed proudly, as the rest listened attentively" We all lived in peace and harmony, until Horde Pride came..." he said, erasing any joy his face showed moments before, "He thought we were wasting potential, and he claimed he'll teach us how to really reach it, but of course, we didn't want that, because that implied abusing our land, which we wouldn't accept under any circumstance, so he, seeing we

wouldn't follow what he asked for, started to attack. At first, we resisted a little bit, but it got worse each time, to the point where it didn't matter what we did, we always lost. We didn't know what to do any more until my grandmother remembered an old tale her ancestors once told her..."

"What tale?" asked Glimmer completely absorbed in the story.

"One about a warrior that Eternians were afraid of, and who had been locked in the shadows, under their command, by one of my forefathers. What my grandmother knew, was that our ancestors helped the scientists of Eternia to understand a bit more about magic, as they work on a very important project, which would be used in another planet" Adora looked at him curiously, wondering if maybe that project had something to do with the Heart of Etheria, "It was in the middle of this, that the warrior appeared, destroying everything at her sight, without no one able to stop her, that's why they asked for my family's help and they, not knowing why they were condemning her to that dark fate, locked her up."

"Laurel..." whispered Adora.

"Exactly. We didn't know what was going to happen, but we didn't have much choice, so they had to bring her here, and for that, they needed a bearer, which happened to be, sadly, my sister."

"Why her?" asked Bow.

"Because she was the strongest, the youngest, and who could control magic the best besides my grandma, and clearly she didn't doubt to help because that's what her town needed" he answered sadly, "they managed to do the spell, but Laurel put a condition, if she helped us, my sister would need to assist her to complete her revenge, and, Eira couldn't deny her, Laurel was, without a shadow of a doubt, an exceptional warrior. And with the power of my sister, they were unstoppable." He recognized remembering that one moment when he first met her. "Horde Prime had no

other choice but to retreat, he had no chance against the two of them, and, having persisted, they would have surely destroyed him and his whole army" he confirmed while the rest looked at him, surprised.

"Horde Prime did this to your planet?" asked Catra, confounded.

"No, it was the magic used by Eira to keep Laurel around during the fight and as well in the revenge of the latter..." explained Archie, his eyes set on the fire once more; he still couldn't get over the whole ordeal nor the anger it had caused him.

"But Horde Prime said he destroyed Eternia..." Adora remembered his words, making her feel jumbled by the narration until an idea crossed her mind, something she hoped would be denied by the young man, " Did Laurel..." Archie beheld at Adora, who stopped her question, gulping nervously, "Did Laurel join forces with Horde Prime?" asked finally, feeling her body tremble with anger. Adora couldn't understand what may have caused Laurel to form such a horrible alliance, in her mind; there was nothing to justify it.

"Yes," he stated seriously, a bit embarrassed once he noticed how the rest stared at him, impacted. "She gave him two options, either they'll destroy him or he'll help her commit her revenge, so he clearly chose the option that benefited him; so he was able to destroy them all, except for one that got away..." he remarked while he raised his gaze, placing it on Adora again.

"Me..." she murmured.

"Yes, and she was unable to go after you, because that would have meant to let our planet deprived of magic, making it collapsed. So Eira gathered forces against Laurel, she stopped her and they came back here. My mother and grandmother, however, got prepared for the worst not knowing what might happen to Eternia, so they decided to lock the magic needed so the planet could still function and hid it, stopping Laurel to try to search for you with Horde Prime's technology." Archie lower his eyes to the

ground, observing the dark wooden floor, "The price to pay was my grandmother, she couldn't take it, and she had to sacrifice herself" he said shutting his eyes and fists strongly, holding back tears, as the rest remained shaken up. The young man breathed deeply, trying to let go of his feelings, then looked serious at Adora again, "Now that you're here, Laurel won't stop until she gets that magic to destroy you."

"I'll stop her" stated Adora, serious and confident, "But it's there a way to get your sister back?" she asked worried, because, although she wanted to defeat Laurel, she wanted to avoid hurting any more members of Archie's family.

"There's a spell, but the book containing it is hidden in a place that only a great sorcerer..."

"I can do it" assured Glimmer, standing up from her seat, "We would defeat Laurel and get your sister back" she sentenced as she checked on the rest, they nodded assertively.

"I truly hope you're able... or else we are lost" answered Archie sighing.

Bow walked over him, patting him in the back; a gesture that made Archie looked at him, confused.

"Don't worry, we'd saved other planets and also defeated Horde Prime... Well, She-ra did it" he corrected himself, proudly staring at her friend.

"I couldn't have done it without you."

"You were able to destroy Horde Prime?" asked Archie amazed.

"We almost got brainwashed and die trying, but yeah, we did it" answer Catra, a bit haughty.

"So I think I can have a little faith in you guys," he said with a small smile, putting his hand over Bow's shoulder, while the rest smile because their support seemed to have some effect. "Either

way, if we want to accomplish such a challenge, I think we need to call it a day, tomorrow we'd still need to walk a little bit more, and you would be introduced to the Queen."

"Not arguing here," said Glimmer, who started to show signs of tiredness, "Catra, you'll sleep with Adora, right?" she asked, making the aforementioned blush, "nothing else to add, goodnight."

With that being said, she walked away before Catra could retort, leaving her mouth-hanging while Glimmer grabbed Bow's arm and dragged him. Catra looked at Adora incredulous, but the latter was smiling, so she just decided to drop it to not cause any nonsensical fight; after all, it wasn't like wanted to sleep with anyone else but her childhood friend.

Everyone headed to their assigned dorm rooms. The rain became more and more intense, and the temperature kept dropping, so both couples tried, with the remaining firewood, to lit a small fire in their rooms' chimney. An orange blaze inundated the surroundings coming from Glimmer and Bow's room; but the situation was different for Adora, who battle trying to start a fire, as Catra looked at her expectantly, lying in her bed.

"Adora, do you want me to call Glimmer? She could light it up in a blink" she suggested for the third time.

"No, I can" she answered stubbornly, rubbing two rocks against each other, completely focused but uselessly.

Catra rolled her eyes, lying on her back with her arms stretched up, she noticed the small light coming from the torch Archie gave them. At this sight, she almost jumped to tell Adora, but the scene of the latter trying to lit the fire was entertaining to her, so she decided to lie down again and see how long will it take her to notice.

"I'm thankful we never got lost in the forest, Captain," said Catra, remembering their days in the Fright Zone, laughing briefly.

"I haven't done this in in while, in another time it would have been different..."

"Sure, whatever you say..." replied the girl smiling, then she yawned.

Catra stared back at the ceiling. Every once in a while, it while glow up due to the thunders entering the window, and also because of the small torch that Adora still ignored, the lightning showed the dismal decoration of cobwebs, and what seemed to be an antiquated light system that didn't work anymore.

Catra got sleepier as the seconds went by; the sound of the rain and the crunching of the rocks started to work as a sedative. Her eyes shut involuntarily, and despite her best efforts, she couldn't keep up the fight, quickly falling asleep. At first, there was only darkness, but as soon as she fell asleep, she began dreaming with a sweet scene; where she found herself with Adora, in a beautiful place in the middle of the jungle, of that pretty planet they were visiting. Adora was resting on Catra's legs, as the latter tenderly caressed her hair, looking at her with an expression full of love. Such a sweet scene made the girl feel even more relaxed, but soon the scenery changed completely. She was no longer with Adora, nor she was in the pretty place, she could barely distinguish anything because of the smoke that started to appear. The latter wouldn't stop spreading around, filling her lungs and making her cough.

Worried, and clueless about the situation, she started to run, searching for Adora everywhere.

"Adora!" she yelled as she coughed once more, realizing the smoke came from the houses around her, which she couldn't quite make up, but they seemed eerily familiar to the buildings that were in Zeiren. This disturbed her even more, so she kept awkwardly searching as she started to hear screaming from people. "Adora, please, answer..." She asked, almost to herself, overwhelmed but still walking, covering her nose.

It was getting harder to keep going through the smoke, and when she felt she was about to collapse, hopeless, soon a golden glow caught her attention; Catra, without thinking too much, started to run in that direction.

"Adora! Is that you?" she asked, but there was no need for an answer. She- ra was lying on the ground, gravely beaten. Catra kneeled down in front of her, and held her tight, "Adora, what happened?!" she asked desperately, but to no avail. Adora was entirely unconscious. "Please, talk to me!" Catra begged in tears, looking around for help, but no one was there, or at least that's what she thought until she noticed how a shadow started to form behind the smoke.

Catra narrowed her eyes to try to get a better look, as she coughed, unsure if it was a hallucination or someone real, soon she was able to see clearly the silhouette of a woman. She had long, black hair; glowing amber eyes, and an armor similar to She-ras', but in black and gold, with a cape and a sword of the latter color. Catra didn't know who that person was, but she could now visualize her face more clearly, and the big, malign smile she was forming. This alerted her, as she hardened her attempts to lift Adora, fruitless.

The air felt thicker, the energy of that place had suffered a sudden change, making her feel an intense pressure in her body, paralyzing her.

"Hello, kitty" greeted gnarly the unknown warrior, with a deep voice, looking at her with a certain air of superiority.

Catra looked up, terrified, trying to let her sharp nails out to attack her, but she couldn't even raise her arm. The warrior laughed at her poor state.

"Who are you?" asked Catra, maintaining eye contact while she saw the girl raising her sword, placing it over Catra's shoulders.

"You'll know soon enough." She answered with a smile, raising her sword, to clearly, finish both her and Adora. Catra, by reflex, closed her eyes instants before she received the attack.

"NO!" she yelled, waking up agitated, crisped, and sweaty.

Adora, who walked over happily to let her know she finally managed to set the fire, looked at her worryingly.

"Catra, are you okay?"

The girl didn't respond immediately, she needed a few seconds to calm her heart, still beating hard. She breathed deeply, trying to make sense of what had happened.

"I had a nightmare."

"Want to tell me about it?" asked Adora, looking at her comprehensively as she sat by her side, placing one hand over Catra's shoulder.

"There was a girl... she looked at She-ra, but she was evil and dark," she said, trying to envision the dream, Adora looked at her puzzled. "The energy felt horrible around her. I don't know where I was, but my surroundings were destroyed, there was fire everywhere and people screaming. I was looking for you; I walked for what felt like hours and when I finally found you..."

The memory of seeing She-ra so badly injured made her stop abruptly, she placed her hand on Adora's face like she was trying to make sure she was truly okay, and everything was nothing but a dream. Adora looked at her still worrying, but she decided not to ask any more about it. She clearly understood what Catra saw, and if that anguished her so much, maybe the best would be to drop the matter.

Catra shook her head in an attempt to erase the images in her mind. Adora got a little bit closer, delicately hugging her. Catra tensed up, still in defense mode, but upon feeling the familiar warmth, she quickly relaxed.

"Everything's fine," she said with her sweet voice, they remained like that for a few seconds. Catra smiled listening to Adora's heartbeat, purring involuntarily, which made the latter smile, "There's only one She-ra, and that's me, no one would hurt us. I won't allow it." She added calmly, carefully removing herself from Catra's tight embrace, so she could look at her in the eyes while she placed both her hands on Catra's shoulders. "Besides, the only thing that could turn me evil was that weird First One's technology, but we already destroyed it..."

"But it wasn't you, and it felt so real...."

Catra stared at Adora, thankful the previously lived was nothing but a horrible nightmare. The blonde-haired softened at Catra's worried state, so she placed a hand on her cheek, the other girl let go of her tension when she felt the contact.

"Everything will be fine, I'm here, I'm fine" Catra opened her eyes slowly, smiling at her. Adora continued, "We listened to too many stories when we got here, I bet those influenced you," she said trying to appease her, then she kissed her on the forehead, "Let's go to sleep, okay? Tomorrow we'll continue the hike, and I am not planning to carry you this time" she warned her, smiling sassily. Catra nodded, and they lay down on the bed, which was a bit more comfortable to those in the Fright Zone but had no ground to stand on the ones they had on Etheria.

They were ready to sleep when suddenly Catra remembered the fire incident, so she couldn't help but ask:

"Adora, how did you light the fireplace?"

The girl turned around to face her, a bit surprised by the unexpected question.

"I did it scraping the two rocks" she exclaimed, proudly. "Although I hurt my hands a little" she added observing the small cuts. Catra let out a laugh, "What are you laughing at?"

"Adora, you idiot" the aforementioned gave her a confused look, unable to understand her comment, while Catra wiped her tears trying to stop laughing, "Really? You didn't notice?"

"No, what are you talking about?"

"The torch, Adora," she said, pointing at it and starting to laugh again when Adora followed her finger.

"And why didn't you tell me sooner?!"

"I'm sorry, I thought you'd figured it out faster, and also, I fell asleep," she said, trying to shield herself to keep laughing, but Adora was offended. Catra, at seeing this, snorted and rolled her eyes, "Oh c'mon, it's not such a big deal, you should have seen yourself, it was very fun..."

"We should sleep" she sentenced shortly, turning her back against Catra, who, leaving her pride aside, cut the distance between them, leaving a small kiss on her cheek. Adora blushed.

"I'm sorry, don't be mad, I promise not to laugh at you anymore."

Catra looked at her expectantly, with a smile, knowing that Adora would forgive her like she always did, but this time she took her sweet time to respond, generating a bit of tension in the air. Until, finally, Adora sighed resigned, and turn around to look at her.

"Whatever, it was dumb, let's sleep." She pleaded while yawning, "Today was exhausting"

"Yes, I hope I can..." Catra whispered worryingly, her smile fading at the memory of her nightmare.

The girl curled near Adora, shutting her eyes tight, waiting and hoping with all of her might not dream anything similar or worse than she did before.

Catra wasn't the only one dreaming that night; Eira, for the first time in a long while, started to see weird scenes in her head, like a movie playing as she rested. It seemed to be an old memory of Laurel, something that never happened before because, despite the warrior telling her all her life, Eira was unable to see the past in that way.

On what appeared to be a remembrance, Laurel was entering a hall of arms, accompanied by two guards. Judging by her face, it wasn't of her liking being there. Once inside, all but her greeted with a small reverence to the man waiting inside. He walked over, staring with disgust at the girl's defiance, and with a hand gesture, he motioned the guards to leave. That person irradiated plenty of respect by just looking at him: he had a white beard, very long and properly groomed and, a uniform filled with medals telling of his accomplishments, and the important role he occupied.

But none of this seemed to matter to Laurel, who wasn't afraid to show her own disgust that this meeting caused her.

"I apologize for my outfit, General, but I was training. For what reason do you request my services?" she asked, mocking seriousness. Perhaps, in another time, the man would have pointed out her insolence and her taunting tone, but this time he preferred to give her an angry stare, and not respond to her provocations.

"I'd like to introduce you to someone" Laurel gave him a genuinely surprised look, "This person will be your replacement." He sentenced without delay, rushing to not be interrupted by the warrior.

"My replacement?"

"Yes, your replacement in the Heart of Etheria's mission."

Laurel couldn't quite believe what he just said, thinking it must have been a tasteless joke.

"Are you serious?" she asked, incredulously smiling.

"Indeed. We consider that, with your training, this person would be more efficient for the expected job."

The General was prepared for the fit of rage that was going to explode on Laurel, so he had previously taken into consideration any extreme reaction she could have against him, that's why the room was filled with guards, waiting for an order. The latter was, instead, completely ignored by Laurel, who, against all odds, was flabbergasted by such news.

"This has to be a joke... I've been preparing for this mission my whole life! And now a rookie is going to replace me?! I just conquered an entire planet, I am the most qualified person for this job!" she yelled, upset, starting to raise her tone, alerting the guards.

"Control yourself. You'll do what you're told, and that's it. Understood?" he ordered firmly while climbing down the stairs dividing them, "If they consider this girl is the chosen for this mission, so be it, and I expect you to deliver your part."

Plenty of people feared Laurel, but not this man. Like her, he had no problem addressing her threateningly.

Laurel felt like she was going to explode from anger. But she knew better of herself, so she let out a long a loud sigh, and tried to speak again, a bit calmer this time.

"As you order, General"

"That's what I wanted to hear"

"When will I have the pleasure of meeting this powerful warrior you speak of?" asked Laurel with a tone of sarcasm.

The man once again ignored her taunts, and signaled to let the new girl in. laurel, not expecting the moment to happen right away, turn around to see who she was. Expecting someone strong

and intimidating, instead, she found that the person crossing the entrance was a girl a bit younger than her; with a big, charming smile, the exact opposite of the mental image Laurel had just created.

The new girl walked until she was facing Laurel. The latter was speechless, not by the indignation of being substituted by a novice, but because of how captivated she felt. The young girl irradiated energy far different from anyone Laurel had ever crossed path with; and, for a split second, she thought they were right. Maybe she was someone truly special.

"Nice to meet you, my name is Mara" she introduced herself with such a sweet and kind voice, that Laurel could no longer maintain her anger, then she lifted her hand to shake the girls'.

"Mine's Laurel" she replied clearing her throat, shaking her hand.

"I hope we get along, Laurel," Mara said honestly, smiling, a gesture that made the other girl demolish her guard entirely.

"Likewise..." she stammered.

Eira witnessed the memory before her, amazed and a little moved; she knew that story but never before had the chance to almost lived it, and also, to see Mara. This made everything have more sense to her.

She was so absorbed in her thoughts; she didn't notice at first that Laurel was right beside her. Both stood in a dark place, specifically the limbo in which the warrior was held, prisoner.

"I'm sorry, I don't know if you wanted me to see that..."

"It's fine, you already know so much about me," said Laurel smiling, although she showed certain signs of sadness.

"This is a first..." Eira referred to the recent experience she just lived, still intrigued by how clear that memory had been, "Why do you think it happened?"

"I suppose She-ra's apparition made my memories more present, but I don't really mind, somehow I've gotten used to reviving them" Eira gave her a puzzled look, not quite catching what she meant, Laurel noticed this: "The place I've been trapped for so long was a constant nightmare; I lived my happiest memories over and over again, and so did the more painful ones..."

Laurel's voice cracked remembering such experience, for it had been the very hell. She couldn't do more than fixed her eyes to the floor, frustrated, but unwilling to cry. Eira emphasized her friend's emotions, but she understood that her own feelings weren't a quarter as bad as everything Laurel has ever gone through.

"I promise that when we defeat them, with our new earn powers, I will try to bring you to our dimension again. I don't want you to stay here, and I won't allow for you to be sent back to that place" she affirmed, breaking the silence and getting Laurel's grateful attention, who smiled.

"Thank you Eira, I hope we made it..."

"We will don't doubt it" Eira sentenced, smiling too.

Laurel would have wanted to be far more grateful and sentimental; after all, Eira did too much for her, more than she could have ever imagined or expected to deserve, but the words and opening up to others was never her strong suit, especially after Mara... that's why she hoped Eira could understand her beyond words, and for that to be good enough.

Chapter End Notes

Hello, I hope you had a great weekend and that you liked the end of this chapter ♥.

I have to admit that everything related to Mara was difficult to write because it made me a little sentimental hahaha

A curious and funny fact is that the scene of the torch and Adora actually came from the fact that I wrote the scene and I didn’t realized that, when they entered the room, I clarified that they entered with the torch. When my girlfriend read it, she emphasized it to me and, when I went to correct it, I found it fun to make a kind of parallel with what had happened to me and Adora hahaha.

Thank you very much for reading, see you on Friday!

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# Chapter 3: Monsters (Part 1)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

In the morning everybody met up in the main room where Archie decided to spend the night; he wasn't there, but the group didn't notice it yet. Bow and Glimmer were splendid and brimming with energy, as usual, however, that wasn't the case for Adora and Catra, who showed big bags under their eyes and couldn't stop yawning.

"What happened to you?" asked Bow surprised at the sight of his friends.

"Catra had nightmares and moved a lot" responded Adora sleepily, looking to her partner who returned nasty eyes.

"I'm sorry but sadly, I can´t control what I dream," Catra said a bit defensively, "Besides I wasn't the only one moving. Seemingly someone dreamt she was fighting" she explained looking at Adora.

"That's not true!"

Bow and Glimmer witnessed the scene unfolding before them very entertained. Something that Catra, noticing this, didn't like at all.

"What are you laughing at?" asked sharply, causing the two to stop their laughter, but before the couple could respond, Archie interrupted the scene, barging into the room through the main

door, catching everybody's attention.

"Good morning" he greeted politely. In his arms, he carried a cloth that had something on the inside that caused weight.

"What's that?" asked Glimmer first as the rest paid attention, Archie walked to the table in the middle of the room and dropped its contents on it.

"I went to gather something to eat before parting" he explained with a smile, the pile of odd-looking fruits resting before him, "Eat without worries, I already did on the way" Everybody's faces lit up immediately and, except for Catra who walked slowly, they ran happily towards the food. Upon arriving, Catra took a seat beside Adora, side-eyeing the stuff on the table.

"Thanks very much" They thanked almost at the same time. Archie simply did a small reverence and smile at them.

"If you'll excuse me," he said, walking to the exit, "I will prepare and gather some more things. Once you're done, we'll meet outside… Is that ok?" he checked on them before leaving.

"Excellent" replied Bow.

With that, Archie left, allowing them to have breakfast peacefully. The boy was amazed at how much fruit he managed to recollect, and he wondered if perhaps, his planet was returning to what once was.

As Adora ate as if she never did before, Catra couldn't even watch the food; she was still worried and anguished for the

dreams she had the previous night.

"What is it?" asked Adora, her mouth full with food.

"You shouldn't speak with your mouth open" replied Catra mean-spirited, while she rested her head on her arms. Adora sighed slightly, swallowed, and then tried again.

"I'm sorry" she apologized between laughs, "Is it because of the nightmare?"

"What nightmare?" asked Glimmer curiously, interrupting Catra as Bow gave them a similar stare.

"Catra had a nightmare with an evil and dark She-ra" Adora said exaggerating like she was telling a horror story, Catra gave her a nasty look.

"It was very re-" she tried to justify herself, but before she could, Adora grabbed a piece of fruit and shoved it in her mouth.

"You should eat to gain some energy," joked the girl laughing, trying to soften her, but Catra looked murderous.

"Maybe you got suggested by our encounter with Eira," said Glimmer, who had listened attentively, also trying to get Catra to calm down.

"Also Archie's story…," added Bow.

"That's what I said," agreed Adora still eating. Catra sighed, resigned because apparently, no one took her seriously; although she did have her doubts about it, maybe her friends were right, maybe it wasn't the same as the dream she had on the ship.

"Don't worry, we'll solve what we need to solve here, and everything will be okay" said Bow positively with a smile.

"Yeah, I don't know" replied Catra staring at the food with disdain, but finally starting to eat. She no longer wished to speak about the matter; perhaps in that way she would forget about it.

The breakfast resumed in between trivial conversations until they were all done, and after stretching a little, they retired from the house that had served as a refuge for the night. The heat was as present as the day before, despite the nights so cold it froze the plants a little bit.

It didn't take so much walking until they found Archie, resting below a tree, a few meters away. He, upon seeing them, got up and walked over to the group.

"Are you guys ready?" asked the boy.

"Always!" replied Bow energetically. Energy Catra and Adora wished they had at that moment.

Like this, they started the last section of the hike before arriving in the town. But despite being way closer, the high temperatures, the humidity, the red dirt- sticking everywhere- and the bugs, made it feel like an eternity. Bow and Glimmer walked at the same speed as Archie, asking him about the planet. In the meantime, Adora and Catra dragged themselves a bit behind, slow-paced and

with big bags under their eyes, not even bothering to talk to each other; they were way too exhausted to initiate a dumb conversation.

Everything was normal until Catra started to feel what, at first, was a small headache, something that made her stop her slow walking. The rest didn't notice instantly, and also she tried to keep going like it wasn't a big deal, but shortly after the pain got far more intense, sharp. It made her fall on her knees, as she held her head, groaning. This sound alerted the rest, who stopped on their tracks and turned around, worried. But immediately they remembered all the other times in which Catra faked a never-ending amount of accidents; so they remained distrustful.

"Oh, c'mon Catra, we are not falling for that again," said Glimmer rolling her eyes, Adora and Bow smiled in agreement, but Catra wouldn't get up, nor removed the hands of her head.

"I'm not lying" she replied with gritted teeth, letting out another groan, this made the group and Archie, who studied the situation attentively, walk to her.

Catra tried to get up but was unable; her gaze turned blurry, but instead of passing out as she expected, she started to have little visions, seemingly memories, that didn't belong here. It was similar to the experience of wearing Horde Primes' chip, who, by the way, she was seeing at that very moment. It appeared as that memory belonged to Laurel since it fitted Archie's story. The warrior was walking towards the throne where Horde Prime sat- a place Catra wouldn't forget so easily-, easily destroying all of his clones in the way as if they were as light and fragile as paper. With ease and an envious speed, she defeated Horde Prime. Laurel was in front of him, threatening him with the same sword Catra saw in previous dreams, but that's where the scene ended; then she jumped to other memories that seemed to be the fight with the First Ones. It was all war, combats until the chaos

stopped too, and, suddenly, Catra saw an unknown girl smiling at her as she turns into She-ra, with almost the same armor Adora used to wear, and even the same sword.

"You shouldn't be seeing this" she heard clearly in her ear the voice of the warrior, who didn't sound happy at all, then everything turned black.

"Catra!" she heard Adora screaming, as she fell to the ground, losing consciousness on her arms.

In the midst of this, Eira was sleeping peacefully, resting her weight in a big, voluptuous tree, taking advantage of the shadow it casts. The tiredness she felt for using her powers and also having to maintain Laurel, exhausted her more than it normally would, besides, she couldn't afford to use magic freely, especially when it was a limited as this one, and they still had a long way to go.

"Eira…" she heard the raspy voice of her partner, interrupting her lumber.

"What is it?" asked groggily, slowly opening her eyes a bit blinded by the strong sunlight.

"Catra started seeing memories of mine and…"

"Who?" interrupted still fazed, not remembering who Laurel was talking about.

"The girl with the ears…" Eira remained clueless, "Who came with She-ra…" she added, but the sorceress still couldn't point her

out, she yawned.

"I'm sorry but…" she was about to deny again until she remembered the fight they had the day before, "Oh, the one who hit me in the face!" she exclaimed happily.

"Yeah, I didn't want you to remember that precisely, but it is easier that way…" Laurel muttered, a bit confused by the cheerful tone in which she had said it.

"So what happened with her?" she asked yawning again.

"She started seeing my memories, memories I didn't want her to see" Laurel explained dryly, upset at the lack of reception of her partner, but now Eira was listening attentively, almost as if they were side by side.

"That's weird, maybe my instability, plus your strong reconnection with your past, opened up the link you created to her, causing an unpredicted leakage," Eira theorized, worrying Laurel, who didn't wish for anything like this to happen again, "But don't worry, I'll make sure she won't remember as much when she wakes up," she said with a smile, trying to calm her down, drawing up a conjure in the ground, "But then I will need to rest a bit more," she added stretching her arms.

"I understand you get exhausted very easily and I hope we find a solution very soon," Laurel said, serious yet hopeful, "I'm thankful you're going to help me" she continued while Eira activated her spell, listening carefully to what the other girl was saying, "But you don't have much time to rest, we have stuff to do" Laurel sentenced, causing Eira to frown.

"You're mean! You made me do it before I knew that!" she stressed, letting out an upset sigh, "But fine, a few minutes will suffice"

"Sleep tight" Laurel wished, smiling briefly, while Eira fell asleep again, with a smile of her own.

Already at the village, Catra finally woke up. Sweaty and agitated, unaware of where she was or what was going on. She straightened quickly, dropping a cloth that rested on her forehead, her eyes scanning her surroundings, scared for not being able to remember anything that had happened. And it wasn't until she spotted Glimmer sitting by her side- who stood from her seat immediately at the sight of Catra being awake- that she felt a bit more relaxed.

"What happened?" she asked, breathing heavily, still twitching, "Where's Adora?"

"Easy, everything's fine" Glimmer replied, trying to calm her down, "You passed out while we were traveling" she explained. Catra gave her a confused look: she still couldn't remember much, "It might have been the lack of sleep," Glimmer added, trying to justify it someway, although deep down, she was very worried.

"Yeah, it might have…" Catra said trying still to recall whatever happened, noticing the blankets covering her."

"Adora…" tried Glimmer to explain the girl's whereabouts, but the sound of the door opening made her turn around, meeting the girl in question.

"We are back," she said entering alongside Bow, who was holding a small basket and a jar with water.

"And we brought some stuff" added Bow proudly, but neither of them kept talking since both realized that Catra was awake. Adora, with no thoughts in her head, almost ran at full speed to see how she was.

"Catra, are you okay?" she asked dumbly, standing by her side.

"No, I'm dead," she replied sarcastically, a bit annoyed by the slight headache she still felt.

"We brought you some food," said Bow, handing her fruit and a glass of water. Catra stared at it reluctantly.

"Thanks but…"

"You have to eat something" interrupted kindly Glimmer.

"At least try" insisted Adora. Catra sighed and took some of the food, eating slowly. The three smiled.

While Catra finished her food and drink, Adora sat on the edge of the bed and Bow in a seat next to Glimmer.

"Can you remember anything of what happened?" inquired Adora worryingly, still trying to wrap her head around the incident.

"No, not too much," she replied, trying to think about it, she managed to recall the passing out, but suddenly her head pinched slightly. She dropped the glass.

"Catra, what's wrong?" asked Adora, ready to hold her again just in case. But this time the pain was caused by another memory invading her mind. Catra stared at the blonde-haired girl, a bit dazed, but overcoming it.

"I think…" she tried to explain, interrupting herself by attempting to visualize more clearly the small image inside her head, "I think I saw stuff… visions" she added under the scrutiny of the rest, "But I can't remember them all, only one of them, one that had a girl in it. A girl that could transform into She-ra…"

"The same girl of the nightmare?" questioned Adora, puzzled.

"No, she was She-ra, and even had the old sword," she said firmly at the group, who still couldn't connect the dots, "But it wasn't you, Adora, it was another person: her hair was dark, and had a very warm smile…"

"Mara!" exclaimed Bow, Glimmer and, Adora at the same time. Catra looked at them puzzled; she didn't know who they meant.

"But how…?" quizzed Bow, looking at the ground first and then at Catra with a bewildered expression, "You never saw her once…"

"I don't know," said Catra, "Ever since we arrived here I have all these weird dreams and visions," she hugged herself, "At first I thought it was nothing, but I have suspicions it might be

something more…”

“Eira and Laurel…” interrupted Glimmer astounded. Catra nodded at that, making Adora anxious.

“If it’s really them, what can we do?” asked Adora, frustrated at feeling so helpless.

“I think I can be of help,” said Archie, who had entered the room, scaring them, “I’m sorry I listened to your conversation, but I had something to announce, and I couldn’t help it…”

“It’s fine, if you know how to get them out of my head, I’ll thank you very much, I don’t have the best experiences on this matter,” replied Catra, feeling a shiver down her spine.

“She probably established a type of connection, to watch, torment, and play a bit with you” he explained, the group frown at the latter, “Either way, it won’t be easy to break it if your sorcerer is not as good as you say she is,” he added, giving Glimmer an expectant look.

“I’ll do it, just tell me how” Glimmer stood from her seat, feeling certain of herself.

Archie, upon seeing the girl’s confidence, simply nodded and searched for a small journal, which he provided to Glimmer.

“These are some of my sister’s old annotations, I know what you are looking for it’s there” he assured them.

Glimmer took it carefully and started to read, in search of the appropriate spell and realizing it wouldn't be hard to cast once she found the right page. The girl stood in front of Catra, who was sitting on the bed, scared.

"Everything will be fine if you can focus," said Archie.

The spell started, while Adora and Bow witnessed the situation with anxiety and worry; they didn't know how this might turn out. Catra, with her eyes, shut closed, kept swallowing hard, afraid of ending up fried. Nonetheless, she breathed deeply, leaving her nervousness aside, knowing she wouldn't be of help in that state.

At first, everything went well, until Catra suddenly felt a weird presence around her. She opened her eyes. And she wasn't wrong. Turning her head ever so slowly, she started to see shadows coming into the room; this altered her even worse than before while she blinked compulsively, hoping they'll disappear, hoping it wasn't more than a hallucination.

"Guys…" she whispered, seeing they wouldn't disappear. Bow and Adora looked at her, "Can you see that?" asked horrified as the shadows started to get near to her, almost as if those were arms.

"What is it? What do you see?" asked Adora, worried and alarmed, but without moving since she didn't want to interfere between Catra and Glimmer, whose expression morphed into one of uncertainty and bother.

"Shadows," she replied as they got closer and closer and without thinking she cried desperately, "Glimmer hurry up!" the sorceress kept repeating the chant to make sure to make no mistake.

“Almost done” Glimmer exclaimed nervously, trying not to lose focus.

Catra saw how a shadow took the form of a human, getting even closer to her. The girl, terrified, tried to move a little, but a hand grabbed her face. This caused Catra to shut her eyes with horror.

“Such a shame we cannot play together anymore, kitty” she heard that sarcastic voice with clarity. Then a bright light went through Catra and made the shadow disappear. Catra opened her eyes suddenly, breathing heavily, seeing how everything shifted back to normal.

Glimmer practically breathe again; such a situation had tired and desperate her a lot.

“Are you guys okay?” asked Bow and Adora, who looked perplexed for what they witnessed, unable to assimilate it. Both girls nodded.

“Nicely done” congratulated Archie, placing his hand on Glimmer’s shoulder, with a smile, “I know you’re tired but, whenever you’re ready…” he said, looking at the group, which were still exalted, “The Queen is waiting for you, but take your time” he added kindly, understanding the situation perfectly, the group nodded and the boy exited the room.

“That was... more than I expected” manifested Glimmer while she dropped her weight in a seat she had by her side, exhausted.

"Don't tell me about it" added Catra still disgusted, laying down again, while Adora took her place again on the edge of the bed, "Thanks, sparkles" she said sincerely. The other girl smiled.

"You're welcome, scum" she replied, laughing briefly, helping ease the tension in the ambient. Bow and Adora let out a sigh of relief, finally seeing them okay.

"We were really worried, we didn't know what to do," explained Adora, sighing again, the same as Bow.

"It was something I needed to do, you couldn't but support us and hoped everything turned out well" replied Glimmer, smiling at them.

"What are we gonna do?" asked the boy after minutes of silence, the girls gave him a confused look, "I mean with the Queen…" he clarified, "Are you okay to go talk?" he asked Glimmer and Catra, "because if you don't, we can go with Adora or…"

"No, it's fine" interrupted Catra, getting up and stretching, "I rested enough" she affirmed, "You, sparkles?" she asked posing her eyes on the girl.

"I feel a bit tired still, but it's just a conversation, so…" Glimmer replied, shrugging.

"Good… but we could rest a little bit more, I don't think they'll get mad," said Adora with a smile.

The group decided to do just that, and took a small break, chatting a little and snacking on some of the stuff they had

previously brought. Once they felt ready, they took their modest belongings and abandoned the cabin, meeting with the colorful town that the gang except for Catra, had already seen. The latter started to eye the place with detail: there, all the houses were painted with different tones, but respecting the colors of the vegetation around them, creating a nice and balanced combo. The people and the animals habituating the place acted happy despite everything they've been through. The kids played, dirtying their clothes with the red soil, but that didn't seem to phase them at all. Catra observed all she could with a smile, curiously, as she followed the rest, who appeared to know where they needed to go.

The squad stopped once they reached what presented itself as an old and careless palace, surrounded and almost buried in vegetation, with huge doors watched by two armed guards.

"The Queen has been waiting for you," said one of them, upon seeing the friend squad, opening the gates and allowing them to pass through; they did shyly, entering the place.

Although the palace was huge, it had no comparison with those from Etheria; part of this one had clear signs of attacks, painting, and sculptures all over the place, had been broken and ruined, something the group immediately noticed. They walked slowly, observing everything with attention, their steps and the birds outside being the only sound they heard. But Catra stopped abruptly, causing the rest to stop too, except Adora which remained unaware, clashing against her.

"That's her!" yelled Catra distressed, ignoring the impact and pointing at a painting in the wall, her voice echoing against the walls. The rest followed her finger, but couldn't quite understand what she meant, "The She-ra I saw in my nightmare" she clarified with her eyes still in the painting.

Chapter End Notes

Hello, I hope you had a great week and that you liked the chapter!
This chapter has the name of a song by Ruelle, an artist that I really recommend.
I was thinking on make a playlist to listen with the fic, but it would take some work, would you like me to do it?
I wish you a good weekend and see you on Monday ♥

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# Chapter 3: Monsters (Part 2)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"That's her!" yelled Catra distressed, ignoring the impact and pointing at a painting in the wall, her voice echoing against the walls. The rest followed her finger, but couldn't quite understand what she meant, "The She-ra I saw in my nightmare" she clarified with her eyes still in the painting.

"That's Laurel" indicated the Queen, behind them. Catra jumped a bit due to the surprise, and all, included her, turned around to stared at the woman, which no one saw approaching, "My apologies, it wasn't my intention to fright you" she apologized with a kind smile.

"No, it's fine, we didn't see you coming, you have nothing to worry about" clarified Catra, surprised and a bit nervous, while she observed that beautiful woman, who had short blond hair, and grey deep eyes.

"Apologies to you, ma'am, we didn't even introduce ourselves," said Adora nervously, but smiling.

"You must be Adora" Pointed the Queen, as the aforementioned seemed surprised, "Archie told me about you, guys, you two must be Bow and Glimmer, and you're..." she doubted when she got to Catra.

"Catra..." replied the girl, a bit upset, with her arms crossed.

"Oh, I'm sorry, I swear I tried to remember you all," said the Queen, frustrated.

"It's fine" Catra faked a smile, and the Queen answered with one of her own.

"I believe it's now the time to introduce myself. My name is Rose, I hope we can offer you a warm stay" as the Queen happily presented herself, Archie got inside the room and walked over to the group.

"It's a pleasure to meet you, ma'am," said Bow, as he and the rest did a small reverence, "We are here to help" he added with a smile.

"Yes, Archie put me up to speed" she clarified posing his eyes on the boy, as he stopped his tracks to rest on a pillar, near them. The group turned around to face him too. "I'm deeply thankful for your interest, but this situation isn't easy at all, and neither will be your mission" she explained helplessly, "so I'd understand if you chose not to accept it."

"Trust us when I tell you we have plenty of experience in complicated situations," said Glimmer with a smile, trying to reassure her.

"Doesn't matter how, but we will get your daughter back, and we'll try to get your planet in shape" added Adora in a serious voice, looking at the Queen, who smiled again.

"Thanks, my son told me how brave and strong you are, but I

must warn you the confrontation you had with my daughter it's nothing compared to what she and Laurel have prepared" she warned them.

"I know, I saw it" replied Catra, arms crossed, letting out a sigh.

"We have to try it" Adora posed her hand in Catra's shoulder, trying to be cheerful although she noticed the Queen's face still showed worry.

"If you could provide us more information, we might be more prepared," Bow asked kindly,  smiling.

"I don't know what Archie may have told you, but all I knew back in those times, because of my mother and Eira, is that Laurel was the result of a project my people had to do with the Ethernian's," she started to explain, trying to remember everything, "They wanted to create a warrior, similar to She-ra," her eyes gazing at Adora, "and they did it, but she didn't accomplish the purpose they gave her, and apparently, a time later she tried to rebelled, but they stopped her by locking her up, with magic, in the dark," she finished solemnly.

"So... is she as powerful as She-ra?" asked Glimmer, worried at such possibility.

"I don't know much about She-ra, but according to my assumptions, no" The Queen shook her head reassuringly to calm the squad's fears, "But alongside my daughter, she may be close to it, or even surpassed it" she added, the group freaked out again.

"But Laurel can't use her powers with Eira, right?" questioned Catra, "If can't use magic, we'll be fine and won't be at risk of something like that happening." She theorized with safety, as the Queen nodded.

"That is correct, but the problem is that the separation spell requires a lot of magic, and we could only accomplish this if we freed more magic, so we would need you to bring the gem that holds Zeiren's magic, but if Laurel gets there first..." she started to explain, unable to finish the idea, but succeeding in getting her concept across, "That's why we got to try for her not to get it."

"But if we use magic for the spell, that won't be bad for the planet?" asked Glimmer.

"My planet is unsalvageable, that's a fact, but the spell would be less harmful like it would be for Laurel to get her powers back. If we play smart, Eira could come back to us, and Zeiren will be safe again," The Queen replied, with hope, "Although I must warn it won't be as easy as it seems, my daughter is weak, but Laurel has followers that will try to get the gem away from us."

"I promise we'll do the impossible to stop anything bad from happening" affirmed Adora, staring at the rest who nodded compellingly with a smile, convincing the Queen.

"Thanks, but if that's the case then you should hurry up and get ready, Laurel already knows you're here and it's safe to assume she'll attack sooner than later," she warned, beckoning Archie to go over, "If you agree, my son will help you, there's no one that knows this place better than him" the Queen smiles proudly, as the young man stood beside Adora and the group nodded.

"Before you depart, you'll get lunch, after all, it wouldn't good to venture into this wild jungle with an empty stomach"

"I think we'll all agree to that" answered Catra smiling, appreciating how Adora's eyes lit up after the Queen mentioned food.

"Come with me, then" offered Archie, and the rest followed him to where he wanted to take them.

"Good luck, see you at lunch," said the Queen kindly, waving at them as they abandoned the big hallway.

The group went to another lounge, escorted by Archie and two more guards, the latter stood outside when the rest entered that big place: it only took a couple of seconds to notice it was a hall of arms, filled to the brim with those, flags and suits of armor that decorated the place entirely. Bow, Glimmer, Adora, and Catra watched the place curiously, while Archie seemed very focused searching for something in between the showcases; but he was interrupted by an older man, that walked to them.

"Archie, my dear, do you need help with something?" asked the man kindly, the archer simply pointed at the squad behind him.

"Those are Adora, Bow, Glimmer, and Catra" he gestured at each of them, "And, as you can see, Louis, some need a change of clothes" the old man's eyes shine at that statement.

"Wait a second" he pleaded, excited, while he ran to fulfill his quest, the group seemed completely confused, Archie upon noticing, turn around to face them.

"You can't walk in the jungle like this" he explained, his hands moved up and down at their outfits, ignoring the offended look of the squad. "We were fortunate that no wild animal faced us, but I doubt we'll be as lucky again" Archie clarified. Louis entered again with his arms full of products, stopping anyone from complaining.

"If you shine, you die, bowman," he said while handling Bow a uniform, who grabbed it disappointingly.

"Do I look that bad?" asked the boy, saddened of leaving his iconic suit behind, eyeing the new one: it looked very different from the one he wore, but it was certain it mesh better with the vegetation of the place.

"You can't go through the jungle dressed in white and gold, dear, you'll be very noticeable" explained the old man with a kind smile that let no room to complain, "Dressers are that way" he pointed cheerfully. Bow, sad and defeated, walked to them.

"What about us?" asked Catra distrustful, her arms crossed over her chest.

"You are fine," he replied, the girl smiled triumphantly, "Glimmer?" he corroborated looking at her, she nodded, "You should wear this" he handed her another uniform, very pretty and entirely different from the current one, "And you Adora..." he looked at her up and down, uncertain, "You wear a lot of white and that red is very shiny" his eyes traveling to the girl's outfit and the pile of clothes he had brought, "perhaps just something for the top, and you'll be fine" he sentenced while giving her the new piece, and both her and Glimmer went to the dressers, silent but unwillingly. Catra felt entertained at her friend's attitude.

"Shall we go wait for them to see how they look?" asked Louis enthusiastic to Catra and Archie.

"I'm good" replied the boy, resting lightly on one of the showcases.

"I'm dying to see them" accepted Catra with a mocking smile, accompanying the man.

It didn't take long for the group of three to change, exiting the dressers with their new outfits. Adora didn't look very fazed, after all, it still was a sort of uniform, so she felt comfortable and fresher since it adapted better to the environment. Glimmer was happy with hers as well, but Bow felt like his covered the abdominal zone way too much.

"Could we remove this?" he begged the Bow, pointing to his stomach,

"My dear, you have a death wish?" replied Louis, with exaggerated apprehension, "That bit is vital to cover," he explained, tapping it softly. Bow seemed inconsolable. Louis inspected Adora and Glimmer, "You are excellent," he remarked, enchanted at their looks. Catra appeared to be disappointed, standing a few meters away with her arms crossed.

"Thanks" Both girls thank him, while they stared at their friends' disenchantment.

"What's the deal, Catra?" asked Adora with a mocking smile, walking over her with Glimmer.

"You wanted us to look ridiculous, didn't you?" continued Glimmer, posing her elbow on Catra's shoulder.

"I'll settle for the boy's sadness" Catra replied, pushing Glimmer's arm away, with pride. Both Adora and the princess laugh softly.

"Hey! I heard that!" exclaimed the Bow, undignified at Catra's words, the girl started to laugh as well.

Amidst this exchange, Archie entered the room with the two guards that originally escorted them, when the group remained unaware of his presence; he cleared his throat to make himself heard.

"If you are finished, the guards will escort you to the lunch" he indicated seriously, the group and Louis gave him an expectant look, waiting for his feedback, "Louis, good job" he finally congratulated him, and the old man hugged him tightly.

"You are such a good boy"

"You won't be coming with us?" asked Bow.

"I will be with you in a couple of minutes, I have some things to discuss with him" he replied, meaning Louis, who seemed surprised.

"Okay, but before you go I want to say goodbye" retorted Louis, as he walked over each one of the gang, hugging them tightly, followed by two kisses on their cheeks. The gang didn't know how

to react to so much show of affection, "I wish you guys good luck, I hope everything works out and I hope to see you again" he added, a bit emotional.

"Thank you so much, we hope for the same" replied Adora kindly with a smile, talking for everybody, before retiring.

"Wait a minute" exclaimed Louis, stopping them in their tracks. The man disappeared for a couple of seconds, as the rest stood dumbfounded, but soon he reappears with a large number of arrows in his arms, Bow eyes shined and let out a broken scream of happiness, "These arrows are very special," he explained while Bow cradled them like a trophy, Louis smiled at the boy's emotion, "I'm sure Archie will love to help you,"

"Thank you so much!" he thanked excitedly, hugging Louis.

"Now you may leave, the Queen is waiting for you, and the food might get cold," he said in a strict yet fun tone, the group laughed and waved at him, then left.

Glimmer, Adora, Catra, and Bow were escorted by the guards into the large dining room, this time they got to see new bits of the building, which told a story in each wall that, despite the damage, could be understood still.

The first thing they noticed at entering the dining room was, unavoidably, the extraordinaire amount of food placed on the table located at the center of the room, in which the Queen awaited for them. She stood immediately to greet them.

"Take a seat and grab anything you want" she suggested

amicably, the group sat down and started tuck-in that succulent feast.

"Your fruit is delicious but I was getting a bit tired of it" admitted Catra while serving herself some of the steak, happier and hungrier than previous times.

"I understand" nodded the Queen with a smile, "That's why I asked for more variety on the menu today."

"Thank you, it's great" appreciated Glimmer. Bow and Adora nodded, mouth-full, enthusiastically.

"You're welcome" she replied cordially, "Now when you're ready we'll bring the dessert and..."

"Dessert?!" asked Adora without swallowing, interrupting Rose, who laughed.

"Adora!" Glimmer and Catra scolded her.

"Sorry" she looked shamed.

"No problem" replied the Queen still laughing, "and yes, there will be dessert," she added, making Bow and Adora's eyes shine, "and as I was saying, once you're done, we should begin to discuss your plan."

The group shared a puzzled look, not knowing what to say.

"Our plan?" asked Bow, swallowing hard, "we are still not sure where we need to go..."

"Oh, my apologies, I thought Archie had told you something about it" she excused the misunderstanding, "Shall I explain you now?"

"Sure, I don't see why not" accepted Adora, nonchalantly, sipping on her drink.

"Okay, so I will..." she said as she motioned a guard to bring one big map of the place, for everybody to see, "The two points of importance are here and here" she marked what seemed to be a cave and a waterfall, on two opposite sides of the map.

"But those places are far off between" pointed Glimmer.

"Indeed, that's why I thought that maybe because there's five of you, it'll be better to prepare two groups; one for the waterfall to get the book, and for the cave," she explained.

"No water for me" sentenced Catra, trying to get herself away from that situation.

"The waterfall will only show the library that lies inside, to a sorcerer," the Queen continued, "So you, young lady, must go" she indicated politely to Glimmer.

"That's fine by me" she shrugged, "What are you guys going to do?" she asked Bow and Adora, who were already attacking the desserts.

"Don't know, it's the sam..." started to say the latter with no worries until she felt a sharp stomp on her foot, "I'll go with Catra" she sentenced abruptly, leaving the rest puzzled at the sudden change, but not paying much attention.

"Okay, then I'll go with Glimmer" accepted Bow, and the princess gave her a cheerful hug.

"Okay, then I'll go with you two" Archie appeared in the room, sitting beside Bow and Glimmer, "I'm sorry about the delay"

"Don't worry, son" said her mother lovingly, but Archie didn't appear to correspond to her good mood.

"You'll have a difficult mission," said the young man to Catra and Adora, "the cave it's more than just that, plenty of people had tried to enter and died," he explained seriously, then he took a sip from a glass sitting in front of him.

"Why?" asked Adora worryingly.

"Only one person can enter the cave, and the cave has, as I said, a spell, which makes you face your worst fears. It starts for the more shallow ones, and if you lose control, it'll take to the deepest ones," he clarified, leaving the girls more worried than before, "my sister and Laurel cannot enter because the cave doesn't accept magical beings, and of course, their attempts at sending people inside backfired," he explained, "So you girls have to be very careful when you get there, especially you," he warned at Catra, who swallowed hard, kind of regretting her choice since she understood that Adora couldn't enter with her.

"I'm sure these two charming and brave ladies will succeed" stated the Queen, smiling while she gazed at the girls, which looked very uncertain.

"Yeah, sure. Of course" replied Catra with a nervous smile, Adora, sensing her discomfort, grabbed Catra's hand under the table, and then gifted her with a smile, in an appeasing manner.

"You two will go with me, because I believed the girls will be safer with She-ra, and it's also possible they'll try to stop us from getting the book" Archie explained to Bow and Glimmer, "in your case, be careful at the exit," said to Catra and Adora who nodded, "and if we leave soon, we'll get there before dusk..." he hinted at their empty plates, trying to hurry the matter.

"Okay then, I don't see what are we waiting for" replied Catra, prideful, trying to hide her fear.

"It'll be risky, but I truly have hope in you guys," expressed the Queen, hopeful, getting up of the table, "Good luck"

"Thank you for this reception, we'll try to be up to this challenge" answered Glimmer, intending to sound confident, leaving her doubts behind her, the rest nodded at her words.

"Thanks to you for coming to this planet to help it," the Queen said honestly.

There was no going back, or any time to lose. It didn't matter how afraid or doubtful they felt, they had to try their best, especially because of the poor state of that planet. The friend

squad was aware of it, that's why after a short goodbye, and promises of victory, they wandered off.

Chapter End Notes

Hello, how are you? I hope you had a very good weekend and that you are enjoying the story. Little by little more things are revealed and soon moments with a lot of tension will come...

Thank you very much for reading, see you on Friday with the beginning of chapter 4 ❤

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# Chapter 4: Trouble's Coming (Part 1)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Under the strong sunlight, the guards escorted the squad of five up until the village ended; being the mark where they'll have to split and go to their specific missions. The idea of separating felt odd to them, since they been together for so long that, deep down, nobody wanted to do so; much less now that they felt so much pressure, fear, and uncertainty.

When the guards left, Archie took one map from his bag and gave it to Adora and Catra.

"Okay, here's when we split" sentenced Archie. Bow and Glimmer, unable to contain their emotions anymore went straight to the other two to hug them tightly.

"Be careful" pleaded Glimmer emotionally, as they separated.

"Yeah, yeah, you two, try not to die" replied Catra with fake indifference, she was elbowed by Adora.

"Why do you always have to be so cutting?" said the girl, as Catra shrugged vainly.

"It doesn't matter, I know deep down that hard shell, there's a big heart within" retorted Bow with an overacted feelings, then he laughed with the rest.

"Good luck, see you soon," said Adora with a smile, "Take care of them," she asked Archie, who nodded before leaving with the couple.

Parallel to this, in a seemingly abandoned building- that even had plants growing on its inside- three people waited. A young man with very short and light hair, with a head-to-toes dark uniform, he wore a huge amount of knives in it, and some swords in his back; and two other girls, which appeared to be twins, braiding their reddish hair. The three kept glancing at the door, expecting someone to arrive; the boy looked more impatient than the others. After a couple of minutes, Eira entered, panting, a bit annoyed and upset. The young man, who was lying on the ground, clapped ironically, pissing her off even more.

"Finally, the princess has come" he cheered sardonically while laughing. Eira stared at him coldly, which made him smile defiantly, "I see, no princess today..." he said with fake sadness.

"Sven, for once in your life, shut up," replied Laurel nastily, being her voice the one heard, despite coming from Eiras' body. Sven just laughed and sat on the floor.

"What's the plan?" asked one of the twins, curiously as both stood up.

"They split up in two groups: Archie, sparkles and the try-hard archer will go to the waterfall; while She-ra and kitty go to the cave" she explained, "Semira and Kaia you'll handle the first group," she pointed at the sisters, "And you, Sven, to the cave" she sentenced, without looking at him. She grabbed her head since she started to feel a strong headache.

"You don't expect me to get in there, right?" he asked with an incredulous smile, which made Laurel turn around and stand right in front of him.

"There won't be a better chance to eliminate her than when she's in there, so don't be a coward and do as I say" she ordered angrily, the tension built was immediately broken by Sven's laughter, "What?" she asked, upset.

"I'm sorry, but I can't take you seriously if you look like her, she's so sweet" he explained between laughs.

Laurel, who had already lost any last shred of patience, used Eira's magic to send him flying against the closest wall. The twins witnessed the scene a bit uncomfortable.

"Was that necessary?!" yelled the boy, as he angrily stood up and cleaned the dust off of his clothes.

"Do as I say and stop messing with me" replied Laurel, "Any questions?" The three shook their heads, feeling a little afraid, "Okay then" she affirmed and retired from the place, under the scrutiny of the others.

The other trio already had a bit of their route complete. Archie held the map, going, as usual, a bit ahead of the couple. Without exchanging any word with them, although this didn't seem to matter a lot to Bow and Glimmer, both couldn't get used to that intense and humid heat, added to the fact that Bow kept struggling with his new suit, he felt trapped and stifled. Neither was in the mood to talk.

They walked quietly and peacefully, among shorts breaths of suffocation, until Bow remembered his maps, so he took it and walked right beside Archie, trying to show it to him.

"We could use this" suggested Bow. Archie observed it for a few seconds but then went back to his own.

"My sister can adulterate those things, as you saw, so it'll be better to use my map and my guide" he pointed, sharply. Bow felt a bit useless, putting his device away. Glimmer noticed so she walked to him, to pat him in the back, trying to console him.

"So it was her that made us get lost..." she commented, remembered the uneven complications they had suffered on the first day.

"Yep, it was probably her setting you up" replied Archie, paying attention to the path. Bow smiled again.

"I knew I didn't make a mistake!" he exclaimed victorious and relieved, hugging the girl. Glimmer smiled at his sudden shift mood, then they kept walking, "Catra will have to apologize" he affirmed proudly, and the girl laughed.

"I doubt that'll happen, you know how she is?" Glimmer replied with laughter. Bow smiled.

"Let me dream" asked the boy, laughing too.

On the other hand, Catra- the same as in every trip- sulked behind Adora, dodging vegetation and bugs, enduring the high temperatures, and feeling the dirt sticking in her skin. Unlike

Adora, who appeared to have gotten used, and marched relaxed snapping the big twigs with a small machete, as she whistled a song, checking the map every once in a while.

"Are we there yet?" asked Catra, annoyed, "I'm tired" she added, removing another bug from her; she felt on the edge of losing her mind.

"C'mon Catra, since we got here you haven't walked at all, I always carried you" retorted the girl, turning around slightly to meet her eyes, then she focused again on the front, "You'll lose your shape if you keep this up," she said smiling.

"Yeah, I can also do that in Etheria, ¡Or in any other planet free of this heat and bugs!" Catra yelled, crushing yet another bug off of her, "This is the worst planet of all, even worse than the water planet" she added, arms crossed.

"You didn't even leave the ship!"

"But even then, we were underwater... surrounded of creep creatures" she recalled with a small shiver.

"At least you didn't have to fight them..."

"That doesn't make it better" replied Catra defensively, as she noticed another bug crawling on her arm, this time she let out an irritated cry, "I hate this planet!"

"You need to calm down, let's get this over with, and then we'll come back home."

Although Adora's positivity could be taken as a quality, sometimes it added more bother than Catra already felt. At this point, she already was starting to feel tainted by the other girl's ease in this situation, especially since Catra couldn't stop thinking about the disaster that might happen if events took a sour turn.

"Adora," she said, grabbing the girl by her shoulders and spinning her around, ignoring her puzzled look, "I understand you are looking for the positive side of this, but I need to know if you are aware of how risky all of this is" she pleaded, looking at her eyes with seriousness, Adora just sighed and removed Catra's arms from her, then went back to the trail.

"Of course I'm aware Catra, I'm not an idiot" she replied a bit offended, removing a plant that obstructed her way, "And I'm scared too, I just hope we don't get to find out how strong Laurel and Eira are together".

"Me too," whispered Catra, stopping on her tracks and Adora did the same, she turned around to face her again, "I don't want to lose you, no when we are so close to coming back home" she confessed, lowering her gaze, Adora smiled and got closer to her, to take her hands.

"We've been through a lot; we saved our world and some others. We'll get through this, even if things don't turn in our favor, we'll find the way" she said, searching for her partner's eyes, who smiled, "We should continue" she proposed kindly, Catra nodded and they resumed their way. This time holding hands.

"Sometimes I hate your positivity," confessed the girl. Adora looked hurt. "But sometimes that's exactly what I need," she

assured her, and Adora smiled again.

Both groups kept walking peacefully, luckily for them, the jungle behaved properly and no dangerous animal had approached them; just a few harmless ones, who paraded in front of them, allowing the squads to appreciate their beauty and learn more about the great variety of species that still existed and, apparently, didn't consider humans to be a threat. This turned out to be mutually beneficial for everybody because if any predator came close, the animals will be the first to notify them of such an issue.

Bow and Glimmer felt fascinated by everything they were learning, it distracted them a little of the tedious warmth and the annoying bugs.

"This place is so beautiful" declared the princess, as she and the boy stared mesmerized, what appeared to be some charming and colorful hares.

"And it was even more beautiful when there was more life" remembered Archie out loud, giving his surroundings a nostalgic look, "it still hasn't lost the beauty"

The group walked a few more meters, until Archie stop.

"We've reached the more difficult bit of the way, at this point, it will be uphill, and once we are closer, we'll meet some stairs," he explained to Bow and Glimmer, who stared at him, mouths hanging open, refusing to believe it.

"Okay then, I'm sorry but I won't continue wearing this" sentenced Bow, removing the piece of clothing that covered his

stomach, breathing of relief at the freedom, completely ignoring the frustrated sigh of Glimmer and the incredulous look of Archie, "Much better, let's keep going," he said, walking happily.

The joy didn't last enough for Bow, as they traveled kilometers in advance- which started to weigh on them- the air seemed to denser each time, giving the impression of air loss, and the humidity was almost palpable. Even Archie was starting to feel damped. Everything got a little bit worse when, upon starting to climb the stairs, whose way got them even deeper on a more matted and soggy jungle.

The trio sweated non-stop, to the point where the water they drank every few minutes, didn't seem to satiate them.

Catra and Adora had moved a lot, they only had a fragment more of the path to cover. They walked in silence, observing how the trees grew taller and taller, covering the sunlight, easing their efforts. Suddenly the silence broke and a strong sound of water filled the place. Catra, unlike Adora, didn't know there was a waterfall on the way. Adora, aware of this mark thanks to the map, wasn't expecting such a big scene. But she was wrong. The place was beautiful. Filled with colorful butterflies, flying freely and posing on trees kindling, some even appeared to shine under the shadow given by the vegetation.

"This place is gorgeous," said Catra, amazed, trying to make eye contact with Adora, but she was no longer on her side.

Immediately, she started to look for her, scared. Until she found the girl almost hypnotized by a giant blue butterfly. Catra couldn't help but release a sigh of relief, then she smiled, touched by Adora's innocence. The latter came back to reality upon noticing she was being watched, the butterfly flew away with the rest.

"I'm sorry, I saw it and couldn't help but followed her," she explained, still mesmerized.

"I'm glad it was a simple butterfly and not the trap of a creepy animal," admitted Catra with her hands on her hips, laughing again, and Adora imitated her.

"Thank goodness" she replied laughing, but it was cut short when she noticed that, behind Catra, a big snake crawled, ready to jump at her, "Catra, watch out!" she tried to alert her, as she tackled the girl to the floor, dodging the reptile's attack. The latter, seeing his surprise attack had been frustrated, retired.

Catra and Adora were on the ground, staring at each other, still agitated for the adrenaline, until the tension was broken by the laughter of both, giggling like kids. Adora moved from the top and offered help to her partner to get up.

"That was close," remarked Catra, accepting the girl's help, she dusted off her clothes, and then they kept walking again, crossing a small stream by jumping on some rocks.

"You should thank me for not being a snakes' lunch," said Adora with fake vanity, Catra let out another laugh.

"You think I didn't notice it was behind me? I had everything planned right before you tackled me".

"You will never accept anything, right?".

"Not in this life, probably..." replied with arrogance, laughing, as she moved some foliage with both her hands. They got inside the

jungle again, which began to be leafier than before, this caught the attention of the girls, and annoyed Catra, "Give me the machete" she asked, sharply pushing aside the vegetation getting in her way, Adora gave it to her.

Now that it was Catra who opened the way, Adora took the map to stare at it again, trying to locate the correct path.

"You don't have to destroy it all" she warned upon listening to the noisy twigs falling one after the other, but without taking her eyes off her business.

"Yeah, whatever" replied Catra, not really listening to her, still walking indifferently,

Adora, who had started to place the points together, noticed that a few steps away there was a cliff that she had completely forgotten about.

"Catra, watch out!" she yelled in horror as she watched the girl stepping into the void, trying to grab her arm, but it was too late. Catra had already misstep and Adora couldn't catch her.

Archie, Bow, and Glimmer were more than exhausted, but very near their mark. They walked holding the rail, using them as a support system, ignoring the poor state of such. They no longer care if something happened to them, their bodies barely could continue.

"I can't keep going, you guys go without me," said Bow, falling to his knees, completely drained.

"This is more than I expected" admitted Glimmer, stopping for a second to sit on the floor, wiping the sweat off her forehead.

"Up up, we're almost there" Archie turned around, as exhausted as them, but trying to utilize all his energy not to give up.

"Can't we take a break?" implored Bow, looking at him with pain in his eyes.

"If we do, it's likely we won't be able to get up, so it's not advisable," the boy took his hand to help his travel partner to rise.

"I can't..." try to protest Bow, but his words were interrupted by a knife that almost impaled Archie's hands in the wooden rail, which immediately put everybody in alert mode.

"What was that? Asked Glimmer, exalted, while Archie armed himself with a dagger and Bow with his arch.

"Be prepared..."

But his words were cut short by one of the red-haired twins, who appeared in the frame holding a big machete. Archie managed to push Bow and jump back, making Kaia nail her saber right into the rail. In a swift move, she took it back and tried to stab the Prince, but he dodged the attack again. Bow tried to help him, but Semira- who, like her sister, had appeared out of nowhere- threw at the knife to stop him, it missed Bow thanks to Glimmer, who teleported him out of sight.

"Thanks," said Kaia, with a smile to her sister, as she battled Archie.

Glimmer and Bow materialized a few meters away, out of breath, Semira walking in their direction.

"You can't run away from my babies!" she exclaimed in between laughter. Bow grabbed Glimmer and both hide behind a tree.

"Glimmer, you have to go on your own," he said, touching her shoulders, barely making eye contact as they hide, "We'll try to gain some time with Archie."

"I won't leave you alone" she hysterically shook her head, "I can help you," she said with confidence, the boy smile, but the moment was interrupted by a knife that flew very close to them.

"No, if the three of us are defeated, then Catra and Adora are doing the rest in vain" Bow spoke as he darted an arrow in Semira's direction, who dodged it with ease, "You must hurry" he pleaded desperately, Glimmer doubted, but, with a curse, she ran uphill.

"You'll need better aim if you want to really hurt me" taunted Semira, Bow abandoned his hiding spot to face her.

Adora didn't doubt, right away she transformed into She-ra, jumping to grab Catra mid-air, and turning them around, so she'll receive the blow.

She-ra lay on the ground, with Catra on top of her, who opened her eyes frightened at the hit that never came, realized what Adora had done, she turned around to check on her.

"Adora, are you alright?" she asked worried sick, thinking she had lost consciousness.

"Yes, but I can't breathe" replied the girl, choking a bit, Catra swiftly got up, giving her room to regain her breath. Adora coughed a little, abandoning the She-ra form, and sat on the ground, a bit shaken up.

"I'm sorry," said Catra, helping Adora get up. even though it was She-ra who took the blow, some sequels were already presenting on her body, so she tried to stretch up a little.

"I'm fine, it could have been much worse," she said, trying to calm her down, cracking her neck, "But next time try to pay attention to where you put your foot, next time She-ra might not be there to save you," remarked Adora with a conceited smile.

"You were the one with the map! It was your responsibility to tell me when the path ended"

"Sure, blame the heroine" replied Adora arrogantly, laughing, and Catra did the same.

"You're an idiot," she said, unable to even fake anger.

Adora, who stood staring foolishly at Catra, quickly moved her focus of attention towards a light that shone right behind the latter. Catra furrowed her brow at her.

"What is it?" she asked Adora, crossing her arms, but the girl wouldn't remove her eyes from that place. Adora didn't reply, just grab Catra's shoulders and spun her around, so she too, could

stare at the majestic crystal cave right in front of them.

"We found it," said Adora, mesmerized by yet another beautiful and glowing feature of the planet.

Chapter End Notes

Hello, how has your week been? I hope it went well ♥. Today I had to upload the chapter a little later because I had a lot to do in the day, and it was a bit complicated for me to do it earlier, sorry.

We are already right in the middle of the story; time’s moving very fast. Thank you very much for being here following and reading it, I hope you like it so far ♥.

Have a great weekend, see you on Monday!

# Chapter 4: Trouble's Coming (Part 2)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"We found it," said Adora, mesmerized by yet another beautiful and glowing feature of the planet.

While Bow and Archie faced against the twins, Glimmer ran between bushes, climbing the big hill with energy gifted by the adrenaline circulating in her veins. The Queen could only think about the boy's safety, since leaving them behind had anguished her, but Bow was right; if they failed, so will their friends, so she had to keep her head cold, to maintain the integrity of the mission.

Sooner than expected, she was almost on top. A strong waterfall sound was heard, and it became strident once she was met face to face with such monstrous cascade, connected in the land by a long metallic platform placed in the center. Amazed, she started to cross it, under the impression that such a gigantic body of water was about to devour her.

She walked until she noticed that, a few meters ahead, the platform ended abruptly. Glimmer went almost to the edge, incredulous. She felt a strong sense of vertigo at seeing the long fall.

"It can be…" she whispered in frustration, gazing at every piece surrounding her, searching for a clue. After a while she found something, in the rail, just before this ended, there was a small inscription: The path is invisible for those who refuse to see it". Glimmer found no meaning to those words, "What is that supposed to mean? I don't have the time for stupid riddles!" she yelled angrily kicking a small rock that frightened the butterflies of

the place, forcing them to fly around into the abyss where they rested as if they were floating in nothing. Glimmer stood there mouth agape, thinking at first they were flying, but that didn't make much sense. The girl then believed to understand what she was meant to do, after a few seconds of doubts, she inhaled and exhaled heavily, looking at the butterflies. "I hope I'm not losing my mind or hallucinating," she said again out loud, making the first step into the void. She closed her eyes firmly but opened them right away when she felt the ground beneath her. Yes, the path was literally invisible. Glimmer, smiling, ran carefully through it until she was in front of the waterfall, which sprayed some relieving drops on her.

Bow and Archie, in the meantime, keep combating the girls, running uphill, trying to keep them away from Glimmer, but this was getting more and more difficult. The sisters had no mercy and were quick to attack, requiring all the attention and energy of both boys, which was no longer at that level.

"Got any plan?" asked Archie agitated, supporting his back against Bows', both scanning their surroundings in search of their rivals, their arches ready to shoot. Bow tried to think; he only had a few arrows left, the same as Archie, so there wasn't much for them to do, "Kid, they're getting away!" yelled the young man, drawing out Bow from his trance. They started to run behind them, shooting some arrows, but neither managed to hit their blanks.

"I think I got a plan, but we need to get to the platform before them," said Bow agitated, but with security. Archie turned around and nodded.

"And I think I know a shortcut" he replied, and both smiled.

Catra and Adora observed the cave, admired and intrigued. That place showed off its magic by a plain view, it was almost hypnotizing. But Catra knew what they were meant to do, and despite trying to show it on the outside, deep down she didn't feel safe at all.

Her body tensed up, her hands started to sweat and her heart raced against her chest.

"Do you think we can do it?" she asked terrified, her voice raspier than ever, Adora was pull off the trance and turned to face her. Surprised by her tone.

Adora was afraid too, there was no point in lying to herself; but as usual, she didn't want to be dominated by that feeling. There was no place for it, she was meant to be the support; that's why she held Catra's hand tightly and gave her a secure look. If both fell, they wouldn't be able to continue, and they'd fail.

"Everything will be okay, we are going to make it like we always do" she assured firmly. Catra inhaled deeply, but then smiled, and trying not to overthink it – as she held Adora's hand- she started to run to the cave's entrance, because she knew that, if she wasted any more time, she'd chicken out.

Catra let go of Adora's hand while she crossed the entrance, recalling the girl's inability to enter with her; but the latter seemed to have forgotten it, that's why when she too tried to enter, the cave sent her a small electroshock discharge that made her fall on her back. Catra turned around to see what had happened, finding Adora lying down on the ground.

“Adora, what happened? Are you okay?” she asked with worry, her eyes scanning the other one. Adora just looked confused, eyeing the entrance, not quite understanding what happened, trying to remember if maybe there has been any warning she may have forgotten.

“I don`t know, I tried to get in and…” she tried to reply, but Catra interrupted her with a laugh, “What are you laughing at?”

“Adora, you are She-ra, a magical being, and magical beings can’t enter here. You forgot, didn’t you?”

“I may have…” Adora replied offended, getting up and dusting herself off. Then she observed the translucent barrier dividing them, “Do you think you can do this on your own?

Catra doubted for an instant; she truly didn’t know if she was ready. It was a lot for her. But she knew she had no other choice, she couldn’t succumb to her weaker side. So she closed her eyes and breathed heavily to try to relax a little.

“It’s okay, I can do it, I knew it was going to be like that,” she replied to Adora as if she could believe her own words too if they came out with her typical fake arrogance.

“Good luck” Adora wished her vehemently, “I’ll be waiting”

Both smiled nervously at each other for a second, and then Catra finally turned around and broke her arrogant grin. She swallowed hard and closed her eyes in fear as she took the first steps into the cave, filled with white and purple crystals. Feeling her flesh shivering in the sharp coldness of the interior.

Adora stood quietly, watching Catra until she lost her sight. Overwhelmed and frustrated, she let out a long sigh and sat on the floor to wait for her. She didn't know how long it would take her, or even if Catra would make it out alive, it sounded like an awful nightmare. But she trusted her partner and knew she could make it if she truly tried, although Adora was conscious that a cave that made your worst fears come true might be too much for Catra, or even herself.

The only thing in front of her was some bushes and trees, which she stared with her head above her crossed arms, and those rested on her knees.

After a while, that landscape gifted a new sight in which focused her eyes: a kind of pig, yellow and pink, very small and completely adorable. The tiny creature shortened the way, walking shyly through the bushes, giving Adora a fearful look. Adora opened her blue eyes, enchanted by the sweet nature of that animal. She started to call it with her hands, trying to attract it to her.

"Hello, little friend," she said with a smile, entirely unaware of the situation forming in her back.

Glimmer supposed that, just like the hidden path, the long cascade was a ruse that hid something inside. And she was sort of right. Because although it was, in fact, hiding something, the fall wasn't fake at all, she realized immediately when the cold water soaked her to her toes the second she walked through. This didn't really bother her; given the high temperature of the planet, for sure she'll dry up in a couple of minutes. So she just sighed deeply and walked into the dark cavern. This time she found another inscription in a stone, clear and visible: "Only magic will light up your way". Quickly, the sorceress deducted her next move; she conjured a bit of energy on her hand, then placed it on

the inscription. Right away the stone started to glow, and, little by little, so did the rest of the place.

Smiling victoriously, she started to walk while admiring the glowing details of the walls, details that soon enough became all too familiar, so she stopped in her tracks to watched them more carefully until it finally dawned on her: it was First One's scriptures.

"No way…." She whispered, her fingers barely scraping the surface of this. Glimmer remembered what they had been told, she understood now this place was more than just magic.

"My name is Amaris, how can I help you?" Glimmer jumped back at the robotic voice that spoke out of nowhere. Startled, she turned around to meet the origin of the voice. It was a hologram, similar to those she was encountered, but of a different appearance. This one observed her, waiting for an answer with a smile.

"My name is…"

"Glimmer, you are the Queen of Etheria" interrupted Amaris; the girl gave her an astounding look.

"How do you know that?"

"I have information from every planet that has made contact with Eternia, that includes yours as well" the hologram explained, nonchalantly, seemingly unaware of the Queen's shocked expression. She wanted to ask far more questions about it since everything was more than odd, but she also knew Bow and Archie were out there battling, and that he didn't have much time to

waste, so she tried to focus just on the mission at play.

"I need a book, can you help me find it?" she asked solemnly. The hologram smiled and started to move with no comments. Glimmer, started to follow her at lack of a better choice, "Where are you going, did you hear me?" she asked a bit disoriented, walking at the same pace as the robot.

They walked until the long, glowing blue hallway ended, and a big library appeared. The number of books was almost immeasurable. Those filled every shelf that was as tall as the ceiling of the room. Glimmer stared at it, mouth agape, completely impressed.

"Which book is it that you are looking for?" asked Amaris nicely, watching her with a smile. Glimmer found herself doubting the answer.

Kaia and Samira thought they had won the race to the two boys, so they share a victorious smile, but when they fixed their attention back to the path, they found Bow and Archie standing right in front of them. Both stopped barely a few steps away, with annoyance.

"How did you get here before us?!" asked Kaia, angered and in guard. Bow just looked at Archie, and the latter smiled arrogantly.

"Clearly, I know this jungle better than you two" he replied, while he pointed his longbow at them.

"I hope you keep that smile when we defeat you," said Samira smiling sadistically, removing a knife out of his pocket, but Archie

wouldn’t allow them to move; quickly he threw a smoke arrow, blocking the girls' view. This allowed the boys to get away a couple of meters. In the middle of the smoldering, Samira heard a whistling sound coming from the platform, and without wasting any time she grabbed her twin to push her out of the way. They barely moved before a big explosion broke the bridge, which started to collapse on its own weight. Bow and Archie started to run to make it to the other side, but to their horror, they noticed they wouldn’t make it in time, so they were forced to jump to land when they were a few meters away.

“That was close,” said Bow sighing of relief, with a nervous smile, trying to observe what the other side looked like behind the smoke which still covered a big part of the view, so he barely could distinguish the knife coming right at him, he screamed loudly and ducked just in time.

“That was close too” added Archie, helping his mate to stand up, from the other side he could see the furious and pained state of the girls.

“I don’t think they will have the best memories from us” commented Bow, with irony, laughing softly while they watched the twins departing, defeated.

Both kept walking to the cave, planning to wait outside for Glimmer to finish, so they could finally end their side of the mission and returned to the town.

Catra walked slowly and with caution, the beautiful crystals lighting the walls weren’t quite enough to get her head out of the perturbing stories she was told, or her awful nightmares. “Control yourself so the place won’t dominate your emotions”, was pretty

much her mission, but to her, that wasn't easy at all, and probably it was requiring a bigger effort than it would to anybody else.

The temperature inside was very different from the outside; it was still humid, but the coldness was so extreme you could feel it in your bones. And despite Catra having a good body heat, it was more than she could handle.

"Why is so cold?" she thought out loud, rubbing her hands on her arms, she moved slower for the numbing she felt.

It wasn't much longer when, suddenly, her path was completely blocked by meters and meters of water covering it all. Catra noticed just in time to stand on the edge, losing all the temperance she was so urgently meant to keep.

"This has to be a joke, there has to be another way, right?" she murmured, her eyes traveling all around her, trying to find some sort of tunnel or alternative route, but to her disgrace, there was nothing.

"What is it, kitty, are you afraid of the water?" she heard the mocking tone of Laurel right in her ear, but before she could react or turn around, she was pushed directly into the water, as she listened to the sadist laughter of the warrior.

Catra, in an attempt to calm herself down, thought to be near the surface. But no. She was actually a few meters away from the ground; so she couldn't help but get desperate, trying uselessly to keep afloat, swallowing water in the process. Still, the worst was yet to come, the girl's despair grew exponentially when the water turned radioactive green. The type of green that brought her awful memories and caused her to tense up even more, but her survival instinct kicked a bit harder. Trying not to think, she

started to swim however she managed; trying to get to dry land, but the water seemed to put more resistance than it was meant.

"Don't be afraid of the light, sister" the calm voice of Horde Prime, rumbling in the walls made her paralyzed, but after a couple of seconds, she tried to keep swimming. Despite her desperate attempts, she couldn't move much further, because the hand of the malign being came out of the water and covered her mouth, muffling Catra's horrified scream, as he pushed her down the deep end.

Chapter End Notes

Hello how are you? I you're hope good ♥

This chapter begins one of my favorite scenes: Catra in the cave. I admit that although I don't like her to suffer, I do like the concept of the scene itself (A little internal fight hahaha). It was one of the first scenes that I thought and that I wrote; the ending being more precisely what I wrote first and this scene what I worte secondly. I do not want to spoil anything, so I hope to be able to upload the update on Friday so you can continue reading it hahaha

Thank you very much for being there, see you in a couple of days ♥

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# Chapter 5: Forever... (is a long time) (Part 1)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Glimmer didn't know what to reply, because nobody told her the name of the book. The Queen cursed herself for not asking before. Now she tried to organize her thoughts to explained herself the best she could, under Amaris expectant look.

"I need a separation spell between a being of this dimension and a being from another one… or something like that…"

"Order received, initiating search in database" replied the hologram.

"How long will this take?" asked Glimmer, tapping her foot on the ground.

"This library counts with magic collections from almost every planet" Amaris explained, Glimmer felt lightheaded, "So it may be between a few minutes or a few days…"

"DAYS?! We don't have much time!" Glimmer started to spin around in her place, nervously, trying to appease her anxiety.

"Without a name, there isn't much more that I can do, my apologies," said the hologram, saddened. The Queen sighed and calmed down.

Glimmer quite resigned, walked to the middle of the room, where plenty of seats, a desk a gigantic shrine occupied the

space. The latter got her attention, because of the broad, open book lying on top. She placed her hands on it and looked at its pages. Once she got it in front of her, she noticed the speck of dust that indicated for how long the book has been put there, with no one to touch it. The sorceress blew in it, causing a cloud of dust to spread everywhere. Glimmer coughed a little and cleaned her hands, and then she paid attention to her new reading. The book was, undoubtedly, very interesting at least on a surface level; there were all sorts of spells that she had never seen, but she didn't have the to get distracted by the whole thing, so she just read over them. It wasn't until she turned a few pages she finally found what she was looking for.

"Ha! That was easy," she cheered with a triumphant smile while she grabbed the book with delicacy. As soon as the book got away from the shrine, an alarm went off, startling her, "Oh, come on! Why it can never be easy?!

"Access denied. Security protocol begins" warned Amaris, the blue light of the place turning red.

Archie and Bow, who were still waiting at the entrance, take notice of the alarm sound. Both shared a confused and apprehensive look.

"I think we should go inside" suggested Bow, worried at the entrance now shining a red light. Archie nodded and tried to access the place, but as soon as they stepped inside, they were ejected, "Why?" asked Bow, upon closer investigation, he noticed the fine yet resistant barrier in front of them, "Now what?"

"I don't know…"

The prince couldn’t quite remember the place but was unwilling to let Glimmer out at her mercy. That’s why he started to look for clues around them, and as soon as Glimmer did, he found it easily.

“Only magic can let us in,” he explained, pointing at the rock. Bow couldn't help but let out another groan.

“What can we do? We can’t leave Glimmer on her own, she may be under attack…” he started to speak quickly, thinking of horrendous scenarios, until he lost it and grabbed Archie from the neck of his suit, “WHAT IF SOMETHING HAPPENS TO HER?” he yelled aphonic, the lows of his voice completely gone, making him sound squeaky. Archie looked at him puzzled, and slowly removed Bow’s hand from his uniform.

“I think I know what to do…”

“What?! Do it” begged the boy.

“But I promised…” Archie knew that he wouldn’t be able to keep any past oaths if he wanted to help Glimmer, who was most likely struggling. So he quickly made up his mind, he placed his hand on the rock, using his magic for the first time in so long, he wasn’t even sure it was going to work. But after a couple of seconds of tension, the cave opened up. Bow gave him an impressed look, with shiny eyes, “We should go” ordered Archie, and so the two entered the place.

Catra could feel the water entering her mouth, the feeling of asphyxia and the gross taste was something that had never abandoned her. She was certain her time was up, there was no more resistance on her body, and when she was about to give up,

the feeling suddenly changed. Her eyes shot open to check what was happening; she was no longer in the water or even wet. A metallic floor was all she could see, terrified she stood up and started to inspect the place, she coughed every once in a while, trying to wash the awful taste left in her mouth.

Soon enough the shape of Horde's Prime ship made Catra realized that's where she was. But that wasn't the worst. Her surprise grew bigger upon staring at her reflection on one of the windows, she noticed her hair was short and slicked back, the uniform was white and grey like it once had been. Just like the time she got the chip on her. Catra messed her hair nervously, grunting in anger. The whole situation felt like a tasteless joke and she wanted to get out of that place as fast as possible; so she started to search for any shortcut that may seem familiar, but there were only three paths ahead of her and they were all dark and long. She paled as her blood pressure dropped, her heart bouncing in her chest.

"What do I have to do?" she murmured in desperation, her eyes traveling to the three possible paths, unable to make a choice, in the edge of tears. Her indecision remained for a couple of minutes until a chilling creak brought her back.

"What's happening, kitty? Are you running away from me?" The familiar voice of Laurel, as well as the creaking sound, echoed behind her, putting her on alert.

Catra didn't think too much, she ran as fast as she could, not looking in any direction. Her heart felt like it was about to escape from her chest. She wanted everything to stop immediately, but couldn't just figure out what to do. She closed her eyes with frustration, trying to contain the tears leaking rapidly; Catra didn't notice her body had morphed. She was now a little girl again and was in the Fright Zone, it became apparent when she collided against Shadow Weaver's back; from Catra's perspective, the

woman seemed bigger and scarier than she already was.

"What are you doing here?" Shadow Weaver turned around, with annoyance. Catra, afraid, gave a few steps back, completely forgetting she was no longer a child, letting the fears dominate all the memories back to life. She felt smaller than she was. "Why do you always have to be so impertinent?" Catra tried to escape, but the sorceress kept her in place, immobilizing her body, "You are a bother, a waste" she said, throwing her aside. The girl morphed again to a slightly older version than the current one. Catra was slowly getting up, holding her bruised side, when Shadow Weaver walked to her and grabbed her face, intently inspecting her, "Why do you keep trying?" Catra, as she always had done, stared at her with hate and fear. And it was the latter feeling which didn't allow her to reply. This upset the woman even more, who, with her magic, threw her a few meters away, "Adora is no longer here, you have no one to protect you" she affirmed, cutting the distance between them. Catra tried to stand once more, utterly defeated and hopeless, ready for Shadow Weaver to give her the final blow. The girl shut her eyes, but to her surprise, She-ra's sword stopped this from happening, going through Shadow Weaver's body and stopping the hit. It made the sorceress vanish in the air.

"Adora, is that you?" hopeful, she got up as fast as she could, trying to run to her.

Adora tried to answer but was interrupted by a sharp hit from Laurel, which made her crash against a ship's wall, it caused her to lose consciousness and the form of She-ra, leaving her defenseless. Laurel tried to lash out against her, but Catra ran desperately to attack. Her attempt was easily defused by the woman, who stopped Catra's fist in mid-air and then hit her in the stomach, leaving her breathless. Laurel grabbed her by the neck of her suit and lifted her as Catra resumed her original form.

The Fright Zone disappeared slowly, handing over the place to a similar scene she saw in her dreams, but this time they were inside Zeiren's palace, which was beaten to the ground, fire spreading in certain places.

Adora remained unconscious and hurt, but Catra, despite all her effort, couldn't let go of Laurel's grip, she had no more strength.

"What? Don't you get it?" Laurel arrogantly smiled while Catra could barely keep her eyes open, "You are nothing compared to her" she remarked, referencing She-ra, "You should have died a long time ago" she threw her against one of the last remaining walls. The girl tried to stand, despite her body trying to quit, her stubbornness wouldn't allow it. When she finally did, a subtle sound of rocks hitting the ground caught her attention; those rocks couldn't be unnoticed given the translucent glow they emanated. Catra's face changed completely and a smile appeared: she was still in the cave, she had never left. "You'll always be second, you could never be better," Laurel said, walking over her, ready to hit her again.

"You aren't real…" said Catra, smiling arrogantly, and Laurel paused a few centimeters away from her face, her snotty expression switching to one of disgust, "None of this is" she added with determination, as the scene before them started to erase itself, including Adora, which served her as a remind her that she was still outside, waiting for her.

"Disappointing…" said the warrior before vanishing.

The cave appeared once again with her shiny gems, and while Catra appreciated being back into reality, she had to double-check that her uniform also came back and it wasn't the awful white and grey one, she sighed with relief when everything seemed to be entirely back to normal.

It wouldn’t be easy to erase the whole hallucination off of her mind. Facing it had been an ordeal, and she was conscious of how close she came to losing control. The latter was something she’ll have to work on from now on, to make sure no one could use it against her.

She breathed deeply, trying to relax. Then she took a look at her surroundings, trying to search for any sign of water, or the long path she believed to have crossed, but not only the place had no traces of water, but the entrance was also merely a few steps away. She understood that everything she lived in happened in just a couple of meters.

“Seriously?” she questioned, pissed off. The girl turned around to continue her quest, but this too was done right ahead of her; a small shrine waited for her, containing that one piece she was looking for, “Finally! You truly like playing hard to get…”

Catra walked towards the shrine, the pain she felt on her body slowed her down, and it made her came to the surprising realization that whatever happened wasn’t just a simple vision or hallucination.

She didn’t doubt for a second to grab the shiny and pretty stone from her resting place, putting it away. She intended to leave as quickly as her body would allow her, trying to leave her mind blank; certainly, the idea to go through the entire experience again was a no-go for her. The only thing she allowed herself to think was how she would brag about her accomplishment to Adora, smiling to such vain thought.

Catra stopped when she was about to leave, turning around to face the cave, she felt a small shiver suddenly remembering every little detail: the cave confirmed a fear she had tried very hard to deny, and it was to fail in their mission, to see Laurel triumphing and ending with her friends and the person she loved the most.

After all, she was out there stalking there, so it was a possibility. One she disliked dearly.

Catra shook her head not to lose it again; she tried to switch her worried expression for a smiling one before she met with Adora outside. Once she left, the latter wasn't waiting for her how Catra had expected, in her place, there sat a small pig, who curiously tilted his head at her, while they both shared an equally confused look.

"Catra!" yelled Adora happily, emerging from the leafy jungle at speed, "It's so good that you're okay", the girl smiled agitated, and Catra noticed how Adora's face was covered by small scratches, but before she could ask what had happened, an enormous animal and seemingly unhappy appeared on their sight. Adora swiftly shortened the distance between her and Catra, and grabbed her by the arm, "Take him and run!" she sentenced while pointing at the small pig.

The girl obeyed while struggling to process the new order of events, and She-ra carried them and ran, feeling the beast following them. Once they ran across a few meters, their escape through the jungle was interrupted by a dagger, thrown by a seemingly invisible person, She-ra barely managed to avoid it. The three of them stared at the weapon with wonder and fear.

"Who's there?" asked Adora firmly, while she placed Catra on the ground, with their new friend, who ran aghast into the bushes.

Both searched their surroundings, looking for the culprit, but it wasn't until Sven decided to climb down the tree in which he was laying down, they spotted him. The boy stood in front of them with a smile, playing with a knife in one of his hands.

“Who are you?” asked Catra.

“Sweetie, you truly thought you could take the gem and leave with your girlfriend all happily” replied Sven, entertained at the blushed cheeks of the girls.

Catra tried to go at him but was promptly cut off by a kind of bear, which lashed out at her, drifting her apart from She-ra. The latter, totally worried and forgetting she had a foe in front of her, tried to go assist Catra, but the boy quickly caught her attention again, darting a knife, barely avoided by the girls’ reflexes but which still managed to create a perfect incise on her face.

“You should pay more attention” Sven let out an arrogant smile, while Adora stared at him furiously, “Let’s start over”

The boy put the knife away, replacing them with a pair of gloves equipped with some large and sharp blades on them, then he stood on guard, defiantly looking at She-ra.

Bow and Archie ran through the cave’s hallway as fast as they could, until they found Glimmer. The Queen of Etheria was battling with difficulty against a bug-shaped creature. Her inconvenience wasn’t just the colossal size of the aforementioned, but also the fact that magic was restricted in there; the place blocked and as just, all she could do was scurry from one side to the other, cursing and lamenting all the damage she had to take to protect the book she was holding. Bow daftly shot an arrow at the bug, catching his attention; the problem was that the boy hadn’t thought of any sort of plan afterward, so he stood dumbfounded, unsure of what to do next. Archie, upon seeing the lack of reaction of his partner and the approaching creature, pushed him out of the way, to avoid getting crushed although this created a small collapse in the entrance, leaving them trapped.

"Kid, do you have a death wish?" yelled Archie as they got up, running towards Glimmer, taking advantage of the creature's temporary daze.

"I'm sorry, I saw her in danger and my mind went blank" Bow apologized in regret and shame. The creature had already resumed its hunt.

"Queen!" Archie called out to Glimmer, catching the attention of the latter, "Please go through that door over there" he pointed.

The girl at first couldn't distinguish it, since "over there" was nothing but a grey wall, but she had no other choice than to oblige, praying the wall was another type of trick like the bridge.

In the meantime, the boys managed to distract the bug by shooting some of Bow's arrows in the face, which leaked green slime on its face, blocking its vision. This gave them some leeway to make a run towards the door too. Glimmer got there, doubting herself.

"Please don't embarrass me…"

The girl tried to take some more seconds to gain the courage to go through it, but before she could do it on her accords, Bow pushed her, so they could enter alongside the Prince.

"Give me the bombs!" ordered Archie at Bow, as they heard the bug getting closer to them.

Bow took the last two remaining bombs with the detonators. Archie took them and placed them at one side of the door, then

they ran as far away as they could.

"Do you think this is a good plan?" questioned Bow, observing the lights of the artifacts blink.

"If it's not then it's too late…"

Archie pressed the detonator that caused a crumple that blocked the entrance in its entirety, it also generated a strong smoke wave. Glimmer, purely instinctive, attempted to stop it with its magic, and to her surprise, it worked this time. The girl smiled peacefully at the two boys, who stared in awe for her reflexes.

"Nicely done" congratulated the Prince, causing Glimmer to smile even wider.

"I'm glad to see you are okay"

"We feel the same, it's such a relief," said Bow as they walked, with a big smile he stretched his arms to hug Archie and Glimmer, passing his good humor to them. The boy kept the hug for a couple of seconds until he remembered this new place, and his curiosity woke up, "What is this room?"

He took his arms from Glimmer and Archie's shoulders, and placed his attention on the crystals covering the walls, it glowed with intense blue color.

"This path will take us straight to the main village" replied Archie, as serious as usual, "and is the shortest way; we'll probably arrive in a few minutes.

Bow and Glimmer looked at him puzzled.

"Why didn't we take this path in the first place?" asked Glimmer.

"Because this is just a way out. The sorcerers built it as an emergency, and while it may look like a great shortcut, it would have left them vulnerable to two fronts of attack, that's why they just left the main entrance of the cave, and they sealed this one for anybody who tried to enter from the town."

"There's no way to break in," asked Bow, looking at Archie attentively.

"No, neither by force or magic. The spell is very powerful, as much as the technology that protects it."

"Well, but at least the return won't be as exhausting," said Glimmer with relief.

"Also, the temperature is very nice" added Bow, sharing her happiness.

Archie gave the two kids a very honest smile. Deep down he had taken a liking in the group, although quite energetic and easily distracted, they didn't seem to be bad people. It caused him happiness to feel he was helping them, and he worried about their safety too. At times he completely forgot that it was something he shouldn't do, and that, soon enough, the kids' adventure would come to an end, but when he remembered, he felt sad.

"Are you alright?" asked the Queen, with a worried expression that Bow mirrored, Archie, came back to reality.

“Sure, just tired” he lied with a fake smile, following his partners' steps.

She-Ra wouldn’t stop throwing hits at Sven, he dodged most of those swiftly, and receiving some now and then, but also directed some punches of his own.

The trees around them served to account for the intensity of the fight, and the force Adora place in each blow. She was tired, but also frustrated and annoyed by the attitude and squeakiness of her opponent.

“I don’t doubt you fight with passion and strength, but that won’t be enough against Laurel,” remarked Sven with a smirk and agitation, he saw the imperturbable angry look that Adora kept since the beginning of their match. She wanted to end it as soon as possible to help Catra, but this didn’t happen, and it angered her even more. Sven was aware of this ordeal, “Don’t worry, she’s probably having a blast with my pet,” he said with a burst of happy laughter, She-ra sent another fist in his direction, which the boy could barely dodge.

Catra jumped from one tree to another, protecting with her life the tiny bag containing the gem. The creature went at her, morphing shapes to catch her and attack. The persecution got untenable at one point, Catra was exhausted and that’s why, during one of her jumps, she miscalculated and fell hard on the ground.

“Shit” she hissed in pain, her vision immediately warned her that the animal was about to jump towards her. Catra had no other choice but to roll to a side a run, abandoning any hope of resting for at least a few seconds. “Can you tired out for once?” she

yelled, out of mind, the creature replied by another lunge at her; Catra managed to dodge it, and the animal, in consequence, slammed his head against a tree. The girl took this opportunity to get as far as she could to hide, begging that the animal wouldn't find her, to go help Adora and get out of there right away.

Chapter End Notes

> Hi, How are you? I hope you're having a good week! Sorry to upload the story later, but I was very tired (I had to work and I'm having some health problems), but I rested and now I feel a little better 😊.
>
> This chapter is my favorite, I am a little excited that you are finally reading it, so I hope you like it as much as I do ♥.
>
> At the time, the part of Catra in the cave was difficult for me to write because of what happens and how intensely it is on an emotional level, but it is without doubt my favorite. I would love to be able to draw some parts, but I don't have the level to do it 💔😢
>
> Thanks for reading the story, see you on Monday for the second part!
>
> Written by: Oriana Ruiz Diaz (@RedLiepard)
> Translated by: Micaela Agata (@BlondePhoenixx)

# Chapter 5: Forever... (is a long time) (Part 2)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

*"Shit" she hissed in pain, her vision immediately warned her that the animal was about to jump towards her. Catra had no other choice but to roll to a side a run, abandoning any hope of resting for at least a few seconds. "Can you tired out for once?" she yelled, out of mind, the creature replied by another lunge at her; Catra managed to dodge it, and the animal, in consequence, slammed his head against a tree. The girl took this opportunity to get as far as she could to hide, begging that the animal wouldn't find her, to go help Adora and get out of there right away.*

Sven fought She-ra as much as his body allowed him to, and even though he had a lot of experience in combat, there was no comparison to his strength or resistance against the magic warrior. His body started to take notice of it, that's why the boy found himself barely restraining She-ra's sword with his weapons. His arms hurt and trembled, but his spirit kept him from getting sliced into two pieces.

"These things are durable" admitted Adora, while she applied more strength, noticing how Sven started to yield a little bit more and her sword got closer to his. The girl couldn't help but smile, her plan wasn't to kill him, of course, just to corner him enough to make him quit once and for all.

"This planet has the best materials on the universe" he replied with a smile like they were having a casual conversation, but before Adora could say anything else, he yielded from the attack and moved out of the way at full speed. Sven expected to end with the warrior, stabbing her from the back, but his plan was

foiled by Catra tackling him, who appeared just in time to save Adora. She-ra stared proudly at the girl, who was on top of Sven, threatening him with her claws, "Fine, I quit" the boy dropped his weapons and rose his hands above his shoulders, laughing and smiling at Catra, a bit nervous and tired. The girl got up, allowing him to do so as well, but She-ra wasted no time on threatening with her sword to stop him from doing anything else. Sven kept his hands up to show his submission, but suddenly his expression shifted of one of worry, it confused the duo: both had momentarily forgotten about Sven's pet, who was getting dangerously closer to them, "Keira, please no", the creature obeyed and stopped behind Adora, mere feet away, grunting in anger. Adora and Catra turned around surprised to corroborate since neither had heard it coming.

The beautiful creature, which looked like a big bear, suddenly shifted, making Catra and Adora dropped their jaws in shock. Now her shape was similar to that of Melog, but with a slight difference in the fur, which was more purple, and the blue bits were instead pink.

"How…?" Catra asked dumbfounded, staring at that being, involuntarily raising her hand to touch the animal.

"I wouldn't do that…" tried to warn Sven, but Keira attempted to bite her before Catra could get any closer, earning a distrustful and angry stare by the girl, "I'm sorry, she has a big personality" the boy let out a laugh, and Keira looked to a side prideful.

"I thought her race was extinct, how did you get her?" asked Adora with curiosity.

"My father liked to rescue animals from the hands of illegal sellers, Keira was barely a puppy when he brought her. He

couldn’t just leave her, even if he didn’t know how to care for her,” he said laughing at the memories of his father nervously trying to figure out what to do with the animal, “Fairly quickly we grew fond of each other, she on her own way, of course,” Sven looked at her with a smile, but Keira kept ignoring him, “We’ve been together for ages now, its all I have from my father” he added with sad eyes but without losing his smile at Adora.

The tale managed to soften Adora a little bit, but she wasn’t going to let her guard down so easily, so she hardened her stare again.

“I miss Melog,” Catra said out loud without meaning to, as she longingly stared at Keira, breaking the tension it had formed between them all. Both Adora and Sven gave her a bemused smile, the girl blushed at looked at the side, prideful like Keira, it made the other two laugh, but Sven suddenly stopped. This caught the girls’ attention.

“About your pet…” he began speaking awkwardly, clearing his throat. Catra immediately got onto him, grabbing his by the suit and harshly pushing him against a tree. Sven knew that nothing good would come after this.

“What did you do to him?” asked the girl in anger, pressing him harder.

“Catra!” yelled She-ra, trying to get her attention so she wouldn’t lose control.

“What?! Are we going to have mercy on him because he told a cute childhood story?!” Catra was exalted and angry; she didn’t want to imagine whatever awful thing that might have happened

to her friend. Adora was worried, she wanted to calm the waters, but felt speechless. Catra, upon receiving no answer, centered her attention back to the boy, "What did you do to Melog?!"

"Me, nothing," he said serious and nervous, the girl pushed him harder, surprising him by the strength she had that he could never have guessed, "Eira and some girls took your ship and your pet, I don't know where they took it, she doesn't give much detail, but maybe I could help you both…"

Catra didn't want to trust, but Adora, instead, was doubtful; the night grew bigger and if it caught them out there, it would be difficult.

"If you help us come back, retrieve our ship and our people, we'll be even," said Adora severely, it made Sven smile, and Catra explode.

"Adora! Two seconds ago he was trying to kill us!"

"In fairness, I wouldn't advise you to stay on your own in the jungle, in the middle of the night, given that you aren't familiar… at least on this zones" interrupted Sven, while Catra gave him a furious and distrustful look.

"We don't need you to get out of here…"

"Yes, we do, especially if he has a way to leave faster" contradicted Adora, trying to convince her, but she couldn't even get Catra's attention. Adora walked over, and placed a hand on Catra's shoulder, "Let him go, I promise I won't let him get away"

she added, giving her a sweet look, and then a cold one to Sven. He laughed nervously.

Catra took a deep breath, considering what options would benefit them, trying to keep her emotions at ease.

"Fine" she accepted finally with gritted teeth, letting go of Sven. Adora couldn't help but smile, seeing she had gotten away with her wishes, "But if he does anything, it's on you" she clarified, between irritated and snotty, but the happiness in She-ra's face didn't vanish.

"How can we go back fast enough?" asked She-ra to Sven.

"I've got the perfect animal for that" he replied enthusiastically, and then he whistled in a loud and unusual way.

"What anima…" tried to ask Catra, but a small quake interrupted and almost trip her. The girl looked up at the sky, where she heard a loud noise, similar to that of a bird. Shortly after, a gigantic and grey-looking fowl made its presence above them. These had a long peak and didn't seem very friendly, in fact, it seemed terrifying to Catra, but Adora found it fascinating, she gave it a thunderstruck look.

"We should find an open space" suggested Sven, pointing at the large number of trees and the scarce place the bird had to land, the girls nodded and followed his step.

Glimmer, Bow, and Archie were already at the end of the path, the glowing blue walls were now simple stone walls and the light had begun to slowly disappear. The prince took one of the torches

from the wall and lit it up, giving enough light to help them finish the last of their trek.

"We are close" warned the young man at the other two, it made them smile happily for how little they had to walk this time, and it didn't take long for them to check that Archie hadn't lie: they could see some a big entrance from afar, that view was enough to give them the energy they thought had lost, to ran towards it.

Archie stood dumbfounded when he saw them moving at full speed; he couldn't believe how much energy they had after all they walked, he was truly exhausted, more than he should have. Bow and Glimmer waited for him in front of the door, as he walked slower and calmer than them.

"There was no need to wait for me, come in"

"We don't know what we might find, I'm not getting into places alone again" admitted the Queen while laughing.

"I appreciate that you're careful."

The Prince went through the gates, inviting the rest to follow him. The group immediately was met with a large living room, ornamented with red, gold, and brown tones, plenty of couches following the color scheme, a big chimney, and plenty of shelves with a large variety of books, which were barely visible by the scarce amount of light entering by the windows. Archie wasted no time and passed the fire from his torch, with those of the room, giving the place a more solemn and mystic aura. Now that they were illuminated, Bow and Glimmer inspected the room with more interest.

“This room is where the sorcerers held meetings” Archie commented, anticipating the questions that the duo might ask, he lit up the chimney and then sat on one of the large couches, feeling immense relief, “Take a seat” he offered to them, while resting his head on the couch’s headboard, he closed his eyes for a moment. The queen and the archer obeyed, and they sat like that for a couple of minutes in complete silence, enjoying their well-deserved break.

“I wonder if Catra and Adora are already here,” said Bow, remembering her friends and breaking the relaxing silence of the ambient. Archie opened his eyes.

“I don’t know, you can stay here looking for the way to cast the spell, I’ll go find someone to ask” the Prince stretched a little, resigned at the idea of using his tired feet again.

“If you want to rest a little more, it's fine,” said Glimmer with a kind smile, one that Bow imitated, trying to not make him feel pressured.

“No, it's fine, also I should let them know we’re here” he insisted, standing up again and walking to one of the nearest doors, “If you need anything, seek for a guard, there’s always one watching the hallways”

The couple nodded, so Archie abandoned the place under their attentive stare.

“Do you think you can learn it?” asked Bow a bit worried to Glimmer, resuming his attention at her.

“We have some time, I guess” she replied with uncertainty while posing her eyes on the book’s cover, “Of course that’ll depend on us not getting attack…”

Bow abandoned his seat that was placed in front of the girl to seat in one right beside her; he put his hand on her shoulder to offer his support. The Queen raised her gaze to look at him, finding a big smile from the boy, which made her smile too, erasing some of her concern.

“I know you can, we’re in this together and I know we’ll make it,” he said, trying to reassure her, while they stared at each other in a way that wasn’t uncomfortable to either, but before anything else could happen, the sound of the door made them instinctively separate.

“Your friends aren’t here, but they’ll let us know when they do” explained Archie as he entered the place and looked at them both; he could sense some discomfort from part of the duo, almost as he had interrupted something, but the Prince wasn’t going to ask about it, it was none of his business, “It’ll be good for you to start reading, we don’t know what might happen even if things had worked in our favor until now,” he remarked to Glimmer, still uncomfortable, as he grabbed a random book and sat in front of her.

“Sure…”

The girl took the book with speed and clumsiness, pretending to read it but unable to ignore her heart, still beating loud on her chest.

In the meantime, the couple and Sven found themselves close to the village, after a trip that for Catra hadn't been pleasurable at all; the bird flew more abruptly than their ship or even Swift Wind, which made her feel nauseous. To try to ease those feelings, she decided to put her forehead on She-ra's back and close her eyes for the remainder of the way. Adora instead was watching the jungle in fascination on that new perspective; she enjoyed it a lot being up there since they didn't have to deal with bugs or the heat, a soft breeze soothed the latter. Sven admired Keira flying freely in the shape of a big eagle, still mesmerized like the first day with her extraordinary abilities. The boy was so absorbed he forgot to pay attention to the road.

"Sven that's not the village" pointed Adora a bit unsure.

Sven came to his senses and stared at the path, realizing the girl was right, for that reason his calmness was replaced by nervousness. The boy quickly scanned for an open space ahead, he found one that required a rather abrupt landing, so he turned his head to warn the girls:

"Hold on, girls!"

"Hold on?" asked Catra raising her head and looking at him in confusion, but her reply came in the sudden descend the bird made, which was almost in a nosedive, both girls yelled.

The landing wasn't nice at all, even Adora felt dizzy. After a couple of seconds, both girls clumsily got off the bird, but Sven didn't.

"Aren't you coming?" asked She-ra, holding her head softly,

trying to recover a little, while Catra used a tree as the stability she was lacking.

"I'm going to try to find out where they hid your ship…" he said, searching for something in his pocket, action what would have caused Adora to react in alert, but currently she wasn't in her best shape, "Take these" Sven threw two communicators which Adora barely managed to catch, "As soon as I got any news, I'll talk to you."

"Yes, you better do so, I still don't know why you're helping us" recriminated Catra with distrust. The boy sighed.

"Laurel and I don't have a great relationship, but when she and Eira told me you guys were our enemy, I believed her. Honesty I no longer think so, so I will save your pup and you'll have to kneel to thank me" he replied laughing arrogantly, Catra just stared at him with suspicion.

"Maybe in your dreams…"

"Don't start again please" interrupted Adora, scolding them like children, "Thanks for your help, Sven, we'll wait for your update" the girl smiled kindly, while Catra crossed her arms, looking at her side, not being able to leave her pride aside, "She thanks you too, her own way"

"Don't talk for me" said Catra, not bothering to look at them, something that bothered Adora.

"Don't worry, I know she is" affirmed Sven before Adora could reprimand Catra. The latter said nothing and just sighed, she was

getting tired of the boy, “I hope to find out anything soon, take care…”

“Likewise” replied She-ra.

Both saw how the big bird flew away with Sven and Keira, leaving them alone again in the gigantic jungle. The sky was now turning an intense type of orange, alerting them of the night approaching. Adora abandoned the shape of She-ra and Catra walked over to her, so they could get to the town.

“I don’t like him,” said Catra seriously.

“Yes, I noticed”

Adora sighed a bit irritated by the tense situation, she handed her one of the communicators. Catra took it without paying much attention.

The couple wasn’t so far from the town as Adora thought, this was something positive since she managed to arrive before it was completely dark. The people of the town were no longer on the streets, the windows were locked and the only noise was the wind moving the leaves from the trees. Neither worried about it, they thought it might have been a normal reaction, a way to take protect themselves from the situation that was about to arrive. So both kept walking until the palace, where the guards let them in right away.

“Your friends are waiting for you in the sorceress room” warned one of them, at that comment, Adora and Catra shared a look, thinking about what to do next.

"I'll go, you go with the Queen," said Catra, taking the crystal from her backpack and handing it to her, while Adora stared at it in wonder of the beauty and glow it had.

"Fine, if anything happens, don't doubt to come get me," said Adora smiling but also assertive, her partner corresponded with another, before nodding.

"Be careful."

"You too"

Catra nodded and was escorted by one of the guards. The other accompanied Adora to the royal room.

Adora's heartbeat harshly, she couldn't stop staring at the crystal she cradled with her shaky hands, and then she took a look at every corner of the extended hallway. She didn't want to be attacked by surprise, and she was aware that could happen at any time. The noises coming from the jungle didn't help either, nor the silence that occurred intermittently, because, unlike her, the guard walked by her side was chill and unhurried. Adora felt like an eternity had passed, but soon enough, to her relief, they got to the big entrance safe and sound. The guard opened the doors and let her in. Adora could see the Queen sitting on her throne, expectantly. She, upon seeing the girl, stood up to meet her. Adora, infected by the woman's euphoria, rushed over her to cut the distance, so she could give her the crystal.

"I can't believe you did it… Well, of course, you did, you're She-ra, I couldn't expect less from such legendary warrior"

Adora blushed at the praise.

"Thanks, but I wouldn't be fair to take the credit, it was actually Catra who got it"

Queen Rose stared at her with surprise but then smiled.

"I must admit her arrogance, lack of discipline, and unbalance made me doubt… but I guess I couldn't have expected anything less from the Kitty, right?" she finally said in a tone that Adora found odd and familiar in a way, it made her smile vanished to stared at the Queen in confusion.

"…What…?" the girl tried to clear her doubts but stopped when the crystal started to glow intensely.

"Now I can do what I've been waiting for…" the woman smiled triumphantly, while her clothes morphed for armor, but not any armor, it was one Adora had already seen in the paintings that adorned the castle.

Adora couldn't move, her body was entirely paralyzed, she couldn't believe this was happening, she didn't want to.

"It can't be.." she murmured, taking a step back, seeing how the shape of the Queen disappeared until it became one of a woman with long, black hair, her outfit was now black and gold, similar to that of She-ra.

There was no time for Adora to react, she could barely

transform, and then she got thrown away to the hallway of the castle.

Catra was still walking in a long, extended hallway, already irritated by the delay and bored because the guard didn't seem interest in interacting, although of course, neither was she. The girl tried to entertain herself, like every other time, by watching the paintings at the ornaments of the walls, but not even that could distract her o ease her anxiety.

"How much do far are we?" Before the guard could answer, they heard a thunderous crash, followed by a slight shake, which alerted her that something wasn't right, "Adora" she whispered looking back, attempting to come back.

"Don't move" warned the guard, aiming his spear at her. Catra gave him a stunned look.

"What's going on?" she asked annoyed and alarmed, seeing how more guards were coming her way.

Glimmer kept studying the separation spell, which appeared to be more difficult than she had thought, so she prayed to have enough time to learn it and properly execute it. Bow spun around the room, nervous because the guards were yet to inform them about their friends' location. Archie limited himself to look at him from the back of the room, annoyed by the constant questions and murmurs of the boy.

"Are they okay?" he asked by the millionth time. The Queen and the Prince no longer replied to him, opting to ignore him in hopes of the boy calming down, but that didn't seem to happen, "We

should’ve adapted the communicators for this atmosphere before launching to this mission…”

“Bow, everything’s f…” Glimmer tried to calm him, but she was interrupted by a loud noise that made them both jump and look at the doors.

The Queen, immediately turned around to face Archie, in search of an answer, but to her surprise, she was met with the young man pointing his arrow at them.

“Please, don’t move or try anything,” he said seriously, leaving the couple shocked and dumbfounded.

“What are you doing?!” Yelled Glimmer, unable to understand the situation.

Chapter End Notes

Hello, how are you? I hope you are well ♡

As I said last time, this chapter is my favorite and now I think you know why hahaha. The next chapter is going to have the big fight, but this one has the revelations and the cave scene, so it won my heart.

I need to ask you something, because from my perspective it is difficult to perceive. Did you realize or suspect about Laurel and the queen? I left some clues during the previous chapters that were mini alarms, but I don't know how obvious it was for you. I would love to know ❤

That's it all for today, thank you very much for reading, see you on Friday with the new chapter!

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# Chapter 6: No Mercy (Part 1)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The hallway was filled with grime and debris. She-ra could barely kneel before Laurel appeared to attack her again, but Adora's reflexes allowed her to take cover in her shield on time. Laurel removed her sword from the shield, to kick it instead; this caused an opening that she took to grabbed the arm of the other warrior.

"We don't want to harm innocents now, do we?" Laurel smiled and She-ra looked at her in confusion, but soon understood what she meant when they got teleported to the outsides of the castle.

As soon as the materialized, Laurel threw Adora against the wall of a small house. The impact caused quite a lot of pain on the girl, who knew that, if it wasn't for She-ra, she'd be accounted for many broken bones. Adora had no time to recover, because the moment she opened her eyes, she had to dodge another punch coming from the other warrior, it made contact with the house's wall, which made the building finally collapse. Laurel charged again with such speed and strength which was barely measurable to She-ra, and that wasn't good news for a battle just starting.

The warriors clashed her swords creating loud noises in each impact, it echoed in the abandoned village.

"What did you do to the Queen?" asked Adora, struggling with Laurel. The latter just laughed out loud, drifting away from the fight they were having, this confused and angered the girl again.

Catra shut his eyes closed, nervously thinking about what to do in the seconds of spare she had before the remaining guards got

to her. But she knew the best choice would be for her to calm down first, so she took a deep breath, cleared her mind, and, suddenly, she opened her eyes staring at the guard with firmness. The boy returned an apprehensive look, something the girl took notice of. Taking advantage of that moment of doubt, Catra used her speed and finesse to hold the guard's spear and pushed it to her, so she could kick the boy, knocking him out.

Looking around, Catra confirmed that the others were a few steps away, so she decided to face them; after all, they were just five young soldiers and filled with anxiety. The girl took advantage of that fact and didn't even give them the chance to stand properly, since she attacked them with agility and elegance; soon enough they were disarmed and unconscious on the ground as she breathed agitated and smiled victoriously. It had been easier than she expected, but the battle wasn't done yet. Catra stopped to stare at both sides of the hallway, doubting if she should go with Bow and Glimmer, or Adora. The girl thought for a few seconds until she decided what to do, and, though she wished this was the last resort, she grabbed the communicator that Sven gave them, activating it.

"I don't know if you found the ship already, but my friends might need your help," she said, annoyingly leaving her pride beside to talk to him.

"Where are they?" replied Sven, surprised it was her who made the first contact with him, and not Adora.

"At the sorcerers' room," she clarified and released the button on the side, stopping him from answering.

It wasn't fun for her to leave Bow and Glimmer to their luck, but it was two of them and Adora was on her own, and if your gut

feeling was certain, she required Catra's assistance with urgency.

"Understood, kitty," he said in an amusing tone, while Catra felt her bad mood augmenting, but chose to leave the apparat in her pocket and go searching for Adora.

Sven and Keira had managed to localize the ship, they hid a few meters away from it, analyzing the panorama: two huge and armed guards were at the lookout. While they didn't seem to be easy rivals to face against, they wouldn't be a gigantic challenge for him.

The boy ordered Keira to stay put, and he abandoned the bushes, alerting the guards immediately, who pointed their spears menacingly at him.

"Don't worry, Laurel and Eira sent me" the boy raised his hands trying to show how harmless he was, but this didn't seem to convince them, they kept the spears uptight.

"They didn't tell us you'd be here"

"Oh, they didn't?" Sven started to lower his hands slowly, "maybe they forgotten, they must be very busy" he added with a short laugh, scratching the back of his neck with one hand, while the other, very slowly, reached for one of his knives he kept in his back, ready for the attack.

"Oh Sven, you are a terrible liar" he heard Kaia said behind him, while she placed a sharp dagger against the boy's neck and her sister pointed a spear at him.

"I'd say I'm at a disadvantage," he said looking around him with a serious face, raising his arms again, "But I got back up too…"

Right away, Keira jumped from beneath the bushes straight to Samira, earning the attention and worry of the sisters for a few seconds. This was enough for Sven, who grabbed her by the arm to reduce her, kicking her neck in the right place to make her sleep.

"I promise I didn't forget about you," he said snottily to the guards, while one of them pounced on him, unable to get his way, shortly after he lay on the ground alongside his partner a few minutes later.

The boy stared at his work done, while he wiped his hands, then he remembered there was another sister, so he turned around to check how the fight was going; Keira got her entirely defeated and surrounded. Sven smiled and started to tie them all up, to then go check the ship.

Bow and Glimmer were paralyzed, they couldn't understand what was happening or what reasons could Archie have to be doing this. Both their minds were blank, unable to react, they didn't know how to, either, at least not without an explanation.

"Why are you pointing at us?" asked Bow a bit more broken than he would have wanted.

"I'm sorry, but just like everybody else, I want this damn thing to end for once" he replied with sadness, breaking the silence. The couple looked at him dumbfounded, trying to help somehow but not knowing how "Laurel planned this from the moment we knew you were here…"

Archie didn’t want this, but he had no other choice. His expression of insecurity was clear, or at least it was clear enough for Glimmer to notice.

“Archie please, you don’t need to be on her side, I know we can get your sister back and getting her separated from Laurel” the girl spoke with more certainty than she truly felt.

“My sister agrees with everything Laurel is doing, they think you were trained and sent by Eternia’s survivors…”

“But you don’t think so, right?” asked Bow hopeful, seeing how the Prince struggled to reply, “Because it’s nothing like that, the previous She-ra, Mara, organized a rebellion to stop Eternia and the plans they had with our planet, she sacrificed her life so Etheria wouldn’t collapse… Thanks to her we are here.”

Archie, who distrusted the original version from the start, now felt doubtful, because Bow's version differed from the one he heard from Laurel. Deep down, he wanted to believe what the couple was telling, he never wanted to help the warrior in the first place, but the problem was his sister; that kept him on a crossroad. If he betrayed Laurel, he’ll betray Eira, and also, if the kids were lying, to his whole planet.

“Please, Archie, you have to believe in us” Glimmer started to get closer to where the Prince was, who hadn’t lowered the gun, “We had to sacrifice a lot of stuff too, Mara’s death stopped the destruction of our planet, but it didn’t eliminate the problem, we all put so much effort to solve it, and even my mother had to sacrifice herself in the process…”

The Queen could barely finish her sentence, although her eyes were now glistening, Glimmer kept the firmness in her stare. Moved, Archie started to lower his gun, that action earned him a surprised look from the couple but also a proud smile.

"I'm sorry I lied to you, and I'm sorry for what is happening" he sincerely said, but then he rose his weapon in Bow's direction, shooting. Bow and Glimmer stood perplexed as the arrow flew a couple of centimeters away from his face, sticking right on the door behind them and liberating a green resistant liquid on it, blocking the access to the guards, "Glimmer, the other door."

The Queen tried to help, but it was too late, a couple of guards had entered the room. Instinctively, Glimmer ran to grab the book and got ready to fight.

In the outsides of the castle, She-ra kept facing Laurel, but their battle wasn't at all what she expected: the girl could barely stop the attacks from the other one, also, it was difficult for her to hit any blow because whenever she was close to it, she was stopped by magic. Laurel was astonished by the level of her opponent; she expected a more leveled confrontation.

The town burnt in flames and they were just a couple of buildings still standing. Adora had tried to avoid such destruction, but it got to a point where her focus had to be centered exclusively on avoiding Laurel's hits, who didn't stop for a second, pushing her to use a bit more strength. This worried She-ra, she did not want to lose control and fatally damaged the woman, after all, Eira was somehow within her, and there was the possibility of hurting them both.

Adora was just a couple of meters away from her rival, defiantly staring at Laurel despite her tiredness and agitation, the latter stuck her sword on the ground, using it like a handstand, retributing the girl's defiance with a snotty expression.

“I genuinely thought you were going to be a challenge” she admitted, disappointed. “But it seems you are not such a big deal as the legends say…”

“You didn’t answer my question” remarked She-ra, ignoring the taunting.

Laurel seemed dumbfounded for a couple of seconds, thinking that, maybe, the girl was messing with her, but she finally understood by the strength in the words and eyes of Adora, that she was serious.

“You’re so dumb, I thought you were joking,” she said between laughter, “It was Eira and I this whole time!” and, of course, the entire town” She-ra seemed shocked, “The Queen died a long time ago, trying to protect this planet, I just took the shape of somebody else and play the role, after all, you never met her…”

“But Archie…” murmured Adora.

“He lied the whole time; everything was planned from the beginning. I needed to convince you to get the crystal for me… and it worked” Laurel smiled, as She-ra filled with rage, stood up again, holding her sword tightly. The other warrior got glad at that reaction: it was what she wished for, for the battle to last longer, “Come on” she said, inviting her with a flick of her hand.

Adora went after her, blinded by the anger and deception, she tried to attack with her sword but Laurel moved in time for the weapon to hit her in her covered shoulder, then she moved the sword with one hand, and punched Adora in the face with the other.

Inside the palace, Catra ran with her newfound adrenaline to the doors. The way out hadn't been calm, and it was easy to tell by the damaged state of her body; plenty of guards appeared in her path, but the concern she felt for Adora gave her enough energy to keep ongoing.

The girl had to employ a lot of strength to open the gates. The chaos created by the two warriors was similar to that of her nightmares, giving her awful vibes for what was to come. Catra started to run, searching for She-ra, but all she could see was fire and debris.

"Adora!"

Her voice echoed in the chaos, and after a couple of seconds of silence, she obtained an answer different from what she expected; a loud crunching sound through the jungle that surrounded the town, indicated where the battle was being held. Putting all of her fears aside, she followed the noise, fully conscious of how kamikaze this idea could end up being.

Sven was inside the palace, running through the never-ending hallways, ready to attack if any guard got in his way, but as he moved, he spotted some of them laying on the ground. Something that showed him that Catra had possibly dealt with, making him smile in pride.

The boy left Keira and Melog on the ship, and despite the reunion between the two creatures wasn't what he had hoped, after insisting for a while he managed to get the two of them to protect the ship together, albeit with a certain distance.

While Sven shortened the way, Bow, Glimmer, and Archie fought with whatever they had left. Both boys had run out of ammo, so they resorted to physical combat, where the Prince appeared to be more prepared than Bow. The Queen fought while she debated teleporting them all somewhere else, but the problem was that

she didn’t know how many guards were out there. Luckily, she didn’t have to risk it anyway, because Sven irrupted in the room, dealing with the last remaining guards.

“ I’m glad you didn’t finish them” Sven pointed at the two, happily, but a bit agitated, resting on his legs, while Bow and Glimmer stared at him with wonder.

“You betrayed them too?” asked Archie with a smirk, happy to see him.

“We never had a good relationship, so when I had the perfect excuse, I took it”

“Guys, I think we need to leave as soon as possible before more guards come…” suggested Bow, interrupting the conversation, the other nodded, but before they moved, a strong earthquake shook them all.

“Was that Adora and Laurel?” asked Glimmer.

“Even worse, I think it was the planet” warned Sven, his smile vanishing, “Someone will have to come with me to get your ship, if this goes on, Zeiren won’t stand any longer.

“Bow will go with you, he knows how to fly the ship” determined Glimmer, the boy nodded. “Archie, you are coming with me, I’m going to need you”

“You’re going to need me?”

“Yes, the spell requires two sorcerers, and you’re one of the few left, right?” she explained, trying to be assertive since she knew the young man would doubt.

“But it’s been years…” he tried to deny, but another temblor interrupted him.

“Dear Prince, “said Sven, grabbing his shoulder to face him, “There is no time for doubts, you have to do it, and I’m sure you’ll succeed. Your sister needs you, and so does the planet” Archie sighed and nodded, unsure, “That’s my boy!” Sven hugged him effusively for a few seconds, then he released it and stare at the couple, “Now we must go,” he said to Bow, “Be careful and call me if anything happens,” he pointed at the communicator Archie was wearing, in a hidden spot.

“Thank you for helping,” said Glimmer.

“It’s no big deal, retrieving your ship was easy peasy… Oh, you didn’t know Laurel stole it?” he said when he noticed Bow and Glimmer's confused stare.

“Clearly not...” replied Bow, already dazed by the sudden and constant change of events, trying to put the pieces together.

“Well, it doesn’t matter, you have it back,” said Sven carelessly, giving the archer a soft slap in his back.

“Is Melog okay?”

“He is excellent…”

"We have to go, soon you'll see him" interrupted Archie, nervous at the prospect of using magic again.

"As you order" replied Sven.

Bow and Sven were ready to leave, but Glimmer grabbed the hands of her boyfriend, making him turn around in confusion.

"Glimmer, what is it? We don't have much time…" he started to say, but she, after a second of doubt, shortened the distance between them to kiss him, it left Bow speechless.

"Be careful" said Glimmer, and without waiting for a reply, she left the place in a hurry along with Archie. Leaving Sven moved by the scene, and Bow furiously blushing.

The fire started to reach the jungle, heating the battle that was already weighing on She-ra. She was laying on the ground, trying to get up, but it was getting harder and harder, not just for the exhaustion and beating, but because she was starting to truly feel she was no match to Laurel, at least not without releasing all of her power. Her last hope was on resisting and hoping Bow and Glimmer were okay and trying to cast the spell. Praying for them to find her if only they followed the destruction. The girl was in a debacle, barely holding on, and it seemed the planet was doing the same, shaking more often, a warning there was no much time left.

"What is it, you can't get up?" Laurel saw how Adora used her sword as a support to stand, the latter replied with anger in her eyes, but she fell again to her knees. That made the warrior laugh out loud, "I know you are not using your full potential, I'm not dumb, give a good fight She-ra, or you don't want to save your

friends?”

Laurel stood expectantly, seeing Adora close her fist in anger, trying not to fall into the mockery.

“I don’t want to hurt Eira, or kill you” Adora replied with honesty, Laurel laughed harder.

“You aren’t capable of neither. You are strong, but your lack of training shows…” Before Adora could reply, Laurel, prepared another magic attack with her sword, it missed the girl by a scrap, “You are the last of them I must destroy…”

Laurel kept looking at She-ra with hate, while she tried to stand again, but the pain put her on her knees again, this time losing the shape of the warrior. She couldn’t keep going, but there was no other option, besides she didn’t want to indulge Laurel in destroying how little there was of the planet.

Taking advantage of the situation, Laurel stood in front of Adora with her sword ready to finish the job.

“I’ll finally avenge Mara,” she said with a victorious smile, almost as a whisper, but loud enough for Adora to hear and react in surprise, at the mention of that name. this was perceived by Laurel, “You know who she is...”

“Laurel, be careful, Catra is coming…” warned Eira, being heard by just her partner.

“Not again, kitty,” said Laurel, seconds before the aforementioned try to attack her by surprise.

“Catra, watch out!” yelled Adora, trying to avoid what was about to happen.

Chapter End Notes

Hello, how are you? I hope you’re good ❤

Sorry for the delay, but I haven't been feeling too good these last few days so I didn't have much energy to correct and upload the chapter on time. I will try to upload the next one as soon as I can, but it will probably be a little more late than usual. Sorry for the inconvenience.

Thank you very much for reading and if you are liking it, leave your kudo, that would help a lot ♡. Do not hesitate to comment. Have a great weekend, see you soon!

# Chapter 6: No Mercy (Part 2)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

*"Catra, watch out!" yelled Adora, trying to avoid what was about to happen.*

At the palace, Archie told Glimmer to teleport them where they had changed, their clothes that very same day; hoping to find Louis. Both looked for him, but the salon was almost full dark, and they didn't want to shout his name, in case there were more guards on the zone. The prince was about to give up and as he tried to sign to the girl to search in another place, the royal stylist appeared from beneath the shadows.

"Archie!" Glimmer whispered, trying to get his attention, but he couldn't quite make up what she wanted.

"Young prince!" exclaimed Louis, happy to see him, making him jump.

"You almost kill me!"

"I'm so glad to see you" he admitted while hugging him, "And I'm glad you follow your gut" he added, looking at Glimmer, who smiled confusedly. The truth was that, during their meeting of the group and the "Queen", Archie confided his doubts to Louis, about Laurel's plans and the true intentions of the group.

"Yeah, yeah, we need your help" he replied, trying to evade the

sentimentalism of the moment, feeling slightly embarrassed of admitting anything in front of the girl.

"What do you need?"

"Laurel is fighting She-ra as we speak, so we have no time, and we need to execute this spell" Archie signed to Glimmer to show the book, "And we need help to practice without being interrupted"

"That seems difficult, and you haven't used your magic in quite a long time..."

"You know magic?" asked Glimmer curiously.

"Yes, my whole family was always integrated by strong sorcerers, but I was the black sheep, only knew the theory" he explained laughing, "I'll try to stop anybody from interrupting, "Good luck!"

"Thanks," said Archie and Glimmer.

Adora tried to get up and stop Laurel from beating Catra, but the warrior pushed her before she could. Given that Catra wasn't expecting to be heard by Laurel, she went straight to her but was swiftly stopped by her and promptly kicked away. Catra tried to stand, but Laurel was already in front of her, grabbing her by the neck and lifting her with ease, while Catra tried uselessly to escape.

"Did you think you could use the same trick twice?" she asked

while smiling sadistically. "I'm no idiot" she added, materializing her sword.

"Let go of her, right now" Adora, who had transformed again, stared at Laurel with her eyes full of anger, the latter turned around to face her with a smile.

"Okay, go for her" The warrior threw Catra harshly against the fire spreading around the jungle. Adora, with inhuman speed, managed to catch her before anything else could happen.

"Are you okay?" asked She-ra. Catra nodded and was delicately placed on the ground, so she could stand on her own.

"See, you can fight still, it wasn't that hard" She-ra and Catra looked at her with hatred, so Laurel got ready for battle, turning her sword in a big spear, smiling arrogantly to both girls who were coming to her, "Let's see who is the last one standing.

She knew she was at a disadvantage, number-wise because despite having Eira, she wasn't a physical ally. Although, to her tranquility, she knew that neither of the girls had any sort of plan or combat strategy, so Eira's magic and her tactical approach would be key to destroy them. Whenever one of them tried to attack, the other was hit by a barrier or by Laurel, who used the spear to keep them away.

Adora and Catra were exhausted, but they kept thinking that Laurel, at one point, would make a mistake and leave a hole in her defense, so far though, the battle was on equal terms. As they were ready to lose hope, Catra found one space, and without wasting any time, she clawed her on a side, that sudden pain made Laurel unable to dodge She-ra's sword. The latter managed

to make a small cut on her face before Laurel, enraged, used Eira's magic to send her flying.

"Adora!" yelled Catra, as she saw the girl falling a few meters away with a loud thud, but her attention quickly returned to Laurel, who spun around a gave Catra a strong punch to the face, knocking her out. She-ra got up, still dazed, watching the scene from afar, trying to regain full consciousness.

"I must admit I don't dislike you that much, but I can't let you get away alive after doing something like this" Laurel said, holding her wound, which bled a lot, and healed slowly.

Laurel raised her spear to finish Catra, but at this, Adora came back to her senses, raising and sending a shockwave to Laurel, who was sent flying towards some nearby trees. Laurel felt the woods breaking against her back and a sharp pain that left her breathless for a couple of seconds. She closed her eyes for a moment, but her instincts made her opened them up with however force she still had left; she saw She-ra's sword inching closer to her face. Laurel could barely stop the sword with both her hands, a few inches away from her face. Adora was almost deranged and the pressure she put showed it.

"Do it" Laurel ordered, removing her hands from the sword. At that moment She-ra reacted again and stopped.

"No, I'm not like you"

"No, you are a complete disappointment" she affirmed, then used Eira's magic to push her away and started to beat her up before Adora could defend herself, bored and disillusioned for the girl's kindness, "How hard could have been to give me a good

fight?" Laurel kicked her in the stomach, leaving She-ra kneeling on the ground. Adora lost her shape, and the other warrior kneeled in front of her, grabbing her face, looking at her with anger, Adora returned the stare.

"Mara wouldn't have wanted this..." said Adora, weakly, remembering the words previously mentioned by Laurel, Laurel inspected her intently, a bit stunned, then she smiled with disgust and held Adora by the neck.

"Don't use her name in vain" Laurel pushed her onto the ground, and pointed her sword at her.

"Mara sacrificed herself for Etheria, and I've been fighting so her death wouldn't have been in vain..." Adora continued Adora, not quite listening to Laurel, which angered her even more.

"They taught you how to lie, right?"

"I wasn't trained by them, I..."

"Enough!" Laurel no longer wanted to hear her thoughts, which most likely were lies, but Eira, who had been listening, started to doubt:

"I don't know if what you're saying is true or false, Adora, but I can't take the risk", said Eira, just to Adora, allowing Laurel to continue.

The latter raised her sword to end with her. Adora accepted her defeat, she no longer had the energy to continue, but before the final hit, Archie and Glimmer appeared and cast the spell, sending

it against the warrior. Laurel, who was not expecting more company, couldn't react on time so the spell hit her right on the chest, separating her from Eira.

Archie stood dumbfounded upon seeing the spell didn't work out exactly how he expected, because Laurel was still there, between them. The warrior was laying on the ground, confused and hurt, just a few meters away from Adora. While the prince was frustrated and angry at the outcome, he chose not to waste any more time on it, instead, he went searching for her sister, who was caught by Adora's tired arms.

"This wasn't meant to happen..." Archie grabbed Eira with care.

Adora turned around to see Laurel trying to get up. The girl searched for Glimmer with her eyes, signaling her to go help Catra, something the Queen did immediately.

"Can you handle this?" asked Adora kindly to Archie, referring to Eira, happy that he had chosen to help them.

The young man nodded, and the girl made a last attempt at getting up and then transformed into She-Ra. She started to walk towards Laurel. The latter raised her hand, trying to transform, but couldn't. Inspecting her bracelet, she noticed the stone that had always been bright orange, was now dark, almost black. Letting out a long sigh of resignation, she remained on her knees, with an arrogant smile on her face seeing how her enemy got closer.

"You were so lucky..."

"No, I wasn't. I got friends, people I loved whom I swore to

protect, and they protect me too" she replied firmly, seeing how Catra was assisted by Glimmer, "Without Mara, I wouldn't be here, or my friends or Etheria. So no, I didn't lie, sadly, Mara had to sacrifice herself to save Etheria." She finished talking, making eye contact with Laurel, whose smile vanished as she lowered her gaze.

"Do it quick, She-ra" she asked hopelessly, seeing how the ground beneath them cracked, finally understanding that Adora was telling the truth and that she had made a big mistake.

"That's not how we do things" Adora abandoned her form and offered her hand to help the other girl to stand up.

"You're so... naïve" Laurel smiled incredulously at the situation, while she stood up on her own, right away she was handcuffed by Sven; who had been slowly making his way behind her with stealth, undetected. "Why aren't I surprised that you betrayed me?" Laurel turned her head to stare at the boy, over her shoulder, while he seemed a bit afraid as if he expected her to break free at any time.

"Thanks, Sven, take her to the ship, please," asked Adora, trying to walk away, but a sudden strong earthquake stopped her in her tracks, making her lose stability.

"I think we all need to leave right now," said Sven, now terrorized, but not for Laurel this time, but because now, the destruction of the planet was inevitable and far nearer than he estimated "We already got the villagers on board, too" he clarified for Adora's calm, who could barely process everything that was happening, "Everybody, follow me, the ship's close by!" he yelled at the whole group, while he dragged Laurel as he ran beside the rest.

That apocalyptic and chaotic path appeared way longer than it was; the ground kept on cracking and breaking, the trees burnt in consequence of the battles. The now prisoner stared at it all with guilt and remorse: she had taken everything way too far and she knew it, and for it, Eira's planet was going to be destroyed. And although in her past life she had destroyed and conquered plenty of planets for Eternia, and even razed her own home, Zeiren felt completely different. She could still remember the moment, and the satisfaction she felt at destroying Eternia:

*The warrior walked through a long hallway, dragging the point of her swords in the walls, watching in fascination how everything around fell in crumbles, amazed at her power, for everything she was about to achieve. Nothing in the world could compare to the happiness she felt at that very moment, except the person for whom she was doing all of this: Mara.*

*She made it to the grand doors of the hall of arms, smiling at it, then she tore it apart and stepped inside. Plenty of guards tried to stop her, but to no avail, they all fell before reaching her. Her formed commander stood still, waiting for her with disgust and contempt.*

*"I can't believe you're still alive," she said, with genuine surprise and a big smile on her face, "I don't know what tricks you pulled, nor do I care, I'm honored to be the one to kill you."*

*"I should have eliminated you the first time I saw you, you're worse than a nightmare" he asseverated with indignation. That made Laurel laugh.*

*"Yes, you made plenty of mistakes..." Laurel's laughter faded abruptly and her expression changed for one of seriousness, one that the man corresponded. "Way too many, Commander."*

*"You can't do this; we are your people... I gave you that power! I saved you from going to that planet and die!" he shouted snottily. Laurel raised an eyebrow.*

*"You gave me this power?!" the girl shortened the distance between them, furious. This alarmed the man slightly, but not enough to break his temperance. "I earnt it! You gave me nothing!" Laurel's voice was almost broken, "Neither did you save me, all you ever did was trick, use, and remove everything from me, just like Mara..." she added, finally standing in front of him with her eyes full of hate, almost on the brink of tears. The man just stared at her, apathetic and quiet, "You people never cared for what you had to sacrifice to get what you wanted" she said, holding her sword tightly, getting ready to use it, "and neither do I"*

Laurel felt no remorse for any of that, even more, she enjoyed her memories, but her feelings on Zeiren were the exact opposite. She didn't want this to happen, it wasn't what Eira and her people deserved, but she was blinded by the battle and her revenge. And if there was something she had always failed, was controlling her emotions at all. She loved to fight and was incredibly good at it, but if any feeling got sorted in the way, she'd become unable to stop even if it meant her demise. That was her biggest flaw, and she damn well knew it. That's why, when they finally made it to the ship's entrance, she stopped, making Sven stop too.

"This isn't the best moment to stop walking!" he yelled nervously, seeing their surroundings worsening, but Laurel was paralyzed staring at the gate, wondering if she deserved to get in and save herself.

"Go without me" Laurel looked down and stepped back, the boy

gave her an incredulous look. The last thing they needed was a dramatic scene.

"You're completely crazy, woman" Sven walked to her with determination and carried her on his shoulder, taking her to the ship.

"What are you doing?" the girl tried to kick him so he would let go of her, but Sven didn't respond, just held her tighter, as soon as the gates shut, he left her down under a murderous stare from her.

"I don't know if you deserve forgiveness, but that's not up to me," he said solemnly, offering his hands o help her stand up.

"You're an idiot"

The girl refused his help, her pride wouldn't allow it, so she got up on her own.

"Oh dear, you aren't dragging behind" Sven smiled mockingly, annoying her even more. The boy tried to guide her through the ship, but Laurel went ahead, ignoring him.

"I know where to go, thanks"

"You know I need to do it regardless" he shrugged, they started to walk to the small prison on the ship.

The warrior posed no resistance, she was tired of fighting and was aware it wouldn't make a difference if she did, also the odds

were against her. So, she walked in silence until they arrived, where only a bed adorned the place. Laurel turned around to face Sven, raising her arms to get her handcuffs off.

"I will, but first I need to take this," he said, pointing at the bracelet.

"Whatever, I think it's broken..." the girl saw how Sven removed it, then he did the same with the handcuffs and left her locked in the room.

"Bow's indications confused a little, but I think all is set"

The boy stared proudly at the force field that kept Laurel from getting out, then he looked at the girl.

"Do you need anything else?"

"I hope you get it," said the boy with half a smile.

"What?"

"Your redemption"

Sven left the room without waiting for an answer. Laurel sighed and then tried to lay down on what appeared to be a rather uncomfortable bed, but strong turbulences interrupted her. At the control station, Bow was trying his best to get the ship as far away from that soon-to-explode planet, the time ran against them and if they didn't get enough distance, they were bound to meet a similar fate.

Everybody observed the scene with expectance, afraid and still shocked by the occurrences. The tension remained until they saw the boy sighing with relief, letting them know they made it. A small cheer ensued among the people, and Bow earnt a hug and kiss from Glimmer, who was immediately by his side.

"You are our hero," she said with a smile, they hugged for a long time until they remember their friends, whom they hadn't seen yet.

"Where's Catra and Adora?" said Bow with worry, already thinking the worst.

"Don't worry, Adora took Catra to try to heal her a little, but they're both okay... now we all are."

As the Queen said, both girls and Melog, which refused to separate from Catra, were in one of the ship's rooms. Adora tried to heal the girl's bruises and cuts the best she could.

"Adora, it's fine, I'm better now..."

Catra sat on the bed and grabbed Adora's hands, trying to be as kind as her bad humor allowed her, she was still upset and annoyed by everything that happened.

"Are you sure?" Catra sighed and nodded with a small smile to try to calm her down, "When she hit you like that and you fell unconscious, I expected nothing good, I got really scared," Adora admitted sadly, then they hugged.

"That whole battle was chaos, we weren't ready," said Catra,

recalling the facts with bitterness, resting her head on Adora's shoulder. "We were lucky"

They drift apart after a few seconds. Adora placed her hand carefully on one of Catra's cheeks, staring at her with fear in her eyes.

"I don't want to think about losing you again" she confessed, a couple of tears streaming down her face, which Catra wiped out then moved a bit closer to her.

"You won't" Catra shortened the distance between them, and, delicately, she kissed her.

The squad didn't manage to get much of a break, along with Archie, they had to organize and calm down the villagers on board. The Prince felt the same hopelessness and confusion as his people while thinking about the future, but he couldn't afford to show vulnerability. Archie, besides trying to remain cheerful to the rest, also cared for his sister, who was still unconscious. She-ra had tried to heal her, but the girl showed no signs of reacting; that kept everybody on guard, especially his brother, who didn't know what to do anymore and could barely hold his need for vengeance.

As per his routine, after attending to all the doubts and worries from his people; he'll come back to Eira and any possible advancement. He'll sit by her side for a couple of hours to tell her all the news, hoping she might be listening while trying to swallow the guilt that maybe, he had done something wrong during the spell. Until the stress finally got to him, a couple of days later, and he started to cry.

"I'm sorry..." he apologized, but not only by the prior incidents,

but for everything: he was just a little boy when Horde Prime invaded them, but he felt partially guilty of doing nothing while his parents and grandmother sacrificed themselves, and then her sister signed with the devil to save them all, "I should have done more, I'm sorry, don't you leave me too..."

"I thought you said warriors don't cry" Eira looked at him weakly, smiling, she grabbed his hand with difficulty. Archie raised his head in amazement, unable to believe she was finally awake, "You aren't going to say anything? If that's the case then I'm going back to sleep, I'm so tired..."

Archie immediately jumped to hug her, so happy to hear her voice again.

"I thought I'd never listened to your annoying voice again," he said between waves of laughter, letting go of her and seeing how she was laughing too.

"I'll never give you that pleasure"

"Thankfully"

Eira smiled, but soon enough her happy expression became of confusion at not recognizing their surroundings:

"What happened?" Eira had some diluted memories, but nothing clear enough to understand anything at all.

Archie sighed deeply, knowing it was up to him to give her the bad news.

"Zeiren is gone" he started to say, under the girl's impacted look, "There was nothing we could do, thankfully Bow and Sven got prepared for the worst and scouted all the people to the ship, so we could escape very quickly after we separated you from..."

"Laurel" interrupted Eira, sitting abruptly in the bed as she remembered a bit more, "Where is she?"

"Why are you worried about her?" Archie couldn't help but raised his voice, annoyed at her sister's priorities. The girl didn't reply, she knew all possible answers would bother him more, and Archie upon hearing no answer, breathed heavily, "Sadly the spell didn't work out how we expected and she's still here, to mine and our people's sorrow. She's locked in one of the ship's cell" Eira lowered her gaze saddened, while she was happy to hear her friend was alive, that wasn't the more ideal scenario, "Say something"

"I'm sorry, but I have nothing to say that would make you happy" the girl lay down again, "I think I'm going back to sleep"

Eira turned around, to Archie's disappointment. He left the room in frustration, almost colliding against Catra. The latter was meant to tell Bow and Glimmer that she and Adora were fine, but she couldn't help but eavesdrop the conversation between the siblings. She tried to justify herself to Archie, but he just kept on walking, uninterested in maintaining a conversation. The girl stood outside the room, trying to wrap her head around all the new situations, before deciding on what to do. After all, she found it odd that Eira would care so much about Laurel, despite everything she had done, but apparently, Eira knew the warrior so deeply not to hate her, regardless. This last idea made her think of her own, former situation; it made her inclined to go speak to Laurel, so

she could finally learn everything about her, and more importantly, her true intentions.

Chapter End Notes

Hello, I hope you are well ♥
I Know it’s been quite a long time but, to cut a long story short, I broke a finger and I’ve been trying to addapt to al lof this. So, I’m very sorry about the delay, I hope you like this one.

The next one I will try to have it uploaded as fast as possible, although since it is the last one I wanted to publish it all at once, but I don't know if you would prefer it to have it split in two, let me Know.

About the chapter, I wanted to clarify that there is an explanation about Laurel's former general being still alive after so many years, and my idea was to explain it in a sixth season of She-Ra that I wanted to write after the finale of this one, but For that I will need a lot of support since it would take a lot of work and time, so if you like the idea, do not hesitate to leave your kudos and comment ♥

Have a nice day, hopefully I can post again soon!

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# Chapter 7: Roads Untraveled (Part 1)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Days went by, and Catra questioned whether or not she should go to talk to Laurel; the last thing she wanted was to foolishly be carried away, for that she needed to be a little distrustful since she had no doubts that the warrior would try to use any sign of Catra's vacillation to her own advantage. While Catra made up her mind, Laurel remained imprisoned, tired, and bored of having no other activity than meditation, exercise (which was limited due to her body's injuries), or sleep. The latter she hated the most. Any time she tried to rest, nightmares of her past would come out, waking her up agitated and melancholic. And although her body demanded it, she refused to sleep as much as she could; Laurel had already revived her memories more than enough while trapped in the darkness all those years ago. She wanted no more.

Time appeared to move slower in there, and she felt hopeless about the "new home": maybe for the rest of them it would be a wonder, but for herself, she expected nothing more than a small and sad room like this one, unaware of how prisons looked like back In Etheria.

Laurel, already resigned from the lack of activities to do, lied down, trying to get some rest. And although her idea was not to fall asleep, she found herself wrapped in the ship's quietness and her eyes closed involuntarily. At first, there was nothing but black and so it remained for a little while until a memory invaded her slumber. One she would have preferred to never remember at all:

She, standing at the entrance of the ship that had once belonged to her, but it was now Mara's, seeing how the latter prepared to depart. Laurel had tried plenty of times to convince their superiors that Mara wasn't ready yet, but for the first time in a long time, she didn't get her way.

*< After helping her friend with the last preparations, Laurel stood outside the ship waiting to say goodbye, with a knot in her throat and frustration never felt before.*

*Once she was done, Mara walked to her, and upon noticing the clear anguish on her companion's face, she asked worryingly: "Are you alright?"*

*"No, I don't want you to go..." Laurel let those words out, at the brink of tears and held her hand. Mara opened her eyes in surprise, she didn't expect such a reaction so sudden, far less coming from such a cold person. So, it took her a couple of seconds, and then she smiled full of compassion and love, but with some sadness in her eyes: she wished she didn't have to go, as well.*

*"I have to, Laurel..." she replied, without letting go of her friend's hand, which she held even tighter, "But I promise, once I'm done, I will come for you, and take you to Etheria with me," she said, trying to appease her, but Laurel didn't know what else to say; she partly understood and knew that avoiding her departure will bring them a world of trouble, so she tried to control herself enough to let her go.*

*"You promise?"*

*"I promise, we'll soon meet again..." c onfirmed Mara with a smile, and dropped her hand, "See you soon..." said for the last time, meeting Laurel's eyes with her own, feeling how the two of them were breaking ever so slowly at that goodbye.*

*Not wanting to cry so as not to complicate things more, Mara turned around and walked without seeing behind her. And she almost managed, until, she felt the doors closing behind her, then,*

*she couldn't help but give one last teary look at Laurel, who was crying as well. Minutes later, the ship took off, taking her to what, unbeknownst to them, would have been her end.>*

The warrior came back to reality almost in tears, her body filled with anger and impotence. And she would have let those feelings take over if it wasn't that she noticed someone watching her from outside of her prison. Laurel opened her eyes and got up to see who it was, meeting face to face with an unsure Catra. The aforementioned had her arms crossed, a was about to retire as she felt the other girl was not available, feeling slightly relieved at the idea of not talking to her in the end, since she had started to regret that idea.

"Can I help you with something?" asked Laurel expectantly, breaking the silence. Catra stopped and thought about it, doubting between staying or blurting out some excuse to leave, she finally decided.

"I came to talk" Catra sighed, stoic.

"May I refuse?"

"No."

"Okay, then. What do you wish to talk about?" asked Laurel, defeated.

"I'd like to allow you to tell your story, and maybe redeem yourself a bit..." Catra said, looking sideways.

"Why? I don't think I have the best reputation around."

"Me neither, and I wasn't always on the right side, I took a lot of wrong decisions and I almost hurt and destroyed everything I loved..." she admitted, lowering her head.

"You said it yourself, Catra, *almost*...." Catra looked at Laurel funny for saying her name, "I did destroy the only planet I considered my home, and there is nothing I can do to fix that." Laurel said, saddened, under the attentive gaze of the other girl.

"The only reason why I didn't destroy Etheria was Glimmer's mom, who sacrificed herself to save it" Catra confessed, voice breaking, "But even then, even after I kept on trying to rule it all, they forgave me, and gave a chance when I tried to get better," she said with a small smile, still ashamed of her past, "It wasn't easy, but we managed."

"I am stunned at their kindness, although, in your case, maybe the special relationship you have with Adora helped a little," she added with a sassy smile while blinking an eye at Catra, who blushed nervously, "What? Am I wrong?" she retorted with arrogance, taunting at the girl, who contained herself before speaking.

"I'm being serious" Catra warned sternly, "Eira, whom according to Archie would never do anything bad, helped you, and I also know you had a connection with Mara, so I am here to hear your side of the story, don't ruin it," she sentenced, ignoring Laurels' shocked face, "If this is a game to you, then I'm out," Catra crossed her arms, impatiently, trying to mask her anxiety.

"Alright, I'm sorry. If you want to listen to my story, I'll tell it, but I warn you it might not redeem me at all," she affirmed, looking in her eyes.

"Go ahead..."

Laurel closed her eyes and let out a deep sigh, trying to calm down before starting, knowing she struggled with it.

"When I was young, I showcased the potential to become a warrior, so the High Commands of Eternia decided I was perfect for the experiment they were conducting. I had nothing or no one. I worked hard to be everything they aspired, being Commander at age sixteen," she rememorated, "I conquered planets, destroyed some others... well, I did everything they wanted me to do, always waiting for *the one mission* they were training me for, but when I thought the time had come, they just told me another person was selected" she recalled, bitterly, "And if it wasn't enough humiliation, they ordered me to train her..."

"Mara?" Asked Catra curiously, Laurel nodded.

"They introduced her to me the very same day, but I didn't react how I thought I would, I was speechless... The energy she emanated was like nothing I ever sense on somebody else; she was so... charming, I was immediately captivated by her. So, I didn't refuse, I took the order, and sometime later we were training together, I thought it wouldn't take long, that she had some previous preparation beforehand. But I was wrong." She sighed, "It took us far longer than I thought, but in that time, I formed a strong link with her, and that was so important to me. But unforgivable to my superiors, who noticed I had started to slow her training.

"You did it on purpose?" she asked, intrigued.

"Yes, I didn't want her to go, I didn't feel she was prepared neither, but of course, I had no idea what.... They never told me what the mission was about, all I knew was they were going to communicate the details to the chosen person at the right time. When Mara left, I couldn't resist going after her, but they detained me and locked me in for a long time until..." Laurel swallowed hard, the following was her least favorite part," One of my former soldiers, a close one, told me what had happened to her," she continued, putting effort on letting her voice come out, her hands shaking, "I couldn't understand, I was confused and angry, I wanted to get out and destroy everything, I wanted to know what happened, how... My head went blank, something broke and doors opened, freeing me. I learned something at that moment: my sword and I were connected, so I immediately brought it to me," she kept narrating, while Catra started to regret her choice, eyeing the security system blocking Laurel in. "I don't remember much of what happened, it was all chaos and destruction, the moment where I regained consciousness was when I found my superior and we fought. I was so close to defeat him, but before that, he called for the Zeiren's sorceress to send me, as you know, to the shadows. There I spent a long time being tortured by my memories on a never-ending loop, until, as Archie probably told you guys, Eira brought me back... I knew Horde Prime allowed someone from my planet to escape, so I thought that, somehow, more people from Eternia did it too, and managed to train She-ra for their purposes... And I'm sorry, but Eternia's habitants weren't known for their honesty and kind essence, so I thought your ordeal was to conquer this planet" she ended, staring at Catra's eyes. The latter was quiet for a few seconds, then sighed, and did what she deemed correct: open the door, leaving Laurel speechless.

"I understand it was a misunderstand, and I think if I lost Adora too, I would have done the same as you" Catra admitted, looking sideways, while Laurel stared at her, "So I might be the least appropriate to judge you"

"Thank you, Catra," she said kindly, getting up from the bed and walking towards the girl, to shake her hand.

"You're welcome... But if you try to hurt Adora again, I promise this time you will be sorry" assured Catra, while putting pressure on Laurels' hand. The other smiled.

"You have nothing to worry about" Laurel tried to be conciliatory, placing a hand on Catra's shoulder, but it made the girl tense up instead of relaxing, "Oh, I'm sorry for that punch in your face, and also for tormenting you in your dreams..."

"Yeah, that wasn't cool. Why did it have to be me?"

"I noticed your connection to Adora, and that you have no control over yourself, in a way, you reminded me of myself," Laurel laughed softly, "It gave me the impression that disturbing you would have been easy enough" she explained, as if it didn't matter at all, "I needed you to feel that way because I knew the cave would place you inside your fears, and I needed it to be a battle scene, for you to be tired during the real one and not get in my way... but I was wrong, you did it regardless," Laurel recalled the face down, while Catra started to get upset, wondering if it was a good idea to set her free.

"Oh, come on, don't be mad, you're my favorite after all."

"Get out before I regret it," Said Catra, blushing slightly.

Laurel obeyed and left, then followed the other girl, who was walking towards the control station. Laurel didn't know what she

was planning but didn't question it. Catra, on her part, hoped to make the group understand her decision, and not be thrown out the ship with her companion, an option more than possible to happen, given Laurel's poor time at speaking.

"Oh, I'm also sorry for making you guys get lost that first day..." she spoke all of sudden, breaking the silence of the walk, and making Catra stop in her tracks and turned around furiously:

"You did what?!"

In the meantime, Bow fought against his need to sleep; the boy had barely rested since they left the planet, and that was because he was terrified something might go wrong, without him around to fix it, he was also far too shocked after all that happened.

Glimmer, who sat by his side, inspected him worryingly. Adora, in addition, walked nervously all over the room, it was a long time since Catra reported her whereabouts; the girl didn't communicate with Adora what was she planning to do, but the latter noticed her partner thinking too much about something, and despite asking about, Catra didn't dare to confess her plans in fear of her reaction.

"Bow, you should go to bed" insisted Glimmer, getting closer to him, "Leave the autopilot on, and if something happens, we'll call you..."

"Glimmer, I'm fine, I can..." he started to say, but stopped mid-sentence as he fell asleep again, although right away he raised his head trying to open his eyes, going against his body's wishes.

"C'mon, you need to sleep..." she repeated, with a smile, a bit

softened, helping the boy to get on his feet, put the ship on autopilot, and carried him outside.

"Promise to call me if something happens?" asked Bow, barely awake, Glimmer nodded and tried to guide him.

"Adora!" she called, catching the attention of the girl and stopping her mid-stroll, "I'm walking Bow to his bed, I'll be right back"

Adora nodded and resumed her nervous pace. Her friends were about to leave, when the doors opened before they did it, showing Catra first, to Adora's relief, but then Laurel, which alerted everyone.

"Wait!" yelled Catra, seeing how they got ready to attack.

"Catra, are you okay?" asked Adora staring at her intently, then she placed her eyes on Laurel, who witnessed the scene far more removed than she should, "How did you escape?!" she added, ready to shapeshift, the other girl just smiled arrogantly, this angered Adora to the point of transforming.

"I let her out!" confessed Catra before an unnecessary battle started.

"Were you manipulated somehow?" Glimmer asked, puzzled, aiming a hand at Laurel, and holding Bow with another, who wasn't conscious enough to understand what was happening.

"No" she denied, trying to relax everyone, "I let her out because I think you should listen to what she has to say"

Adora and Glimmer looked at each other, doubting what to do.

"Yeaaah, let her talk" accepted Bow, sleeping while standing. The girls sighed, defeated.

"Okay, but if this is a trap..." said Adora threatening, leaving She-ra's form.

"It's not" interrupted Laurel, trying to calm her down to no avail, the girl was still hesitant. Laurel was quiet for a couple of seconds, trying to tidy her mind around her own thoughts, side-eyeing with remorse at the villagers who were there, scared. "It was all a misunderstanding on my part and I know what I'm about to say will no justify it completely, but I was trained by Eternia ever since I was a kid, there we used all sorts of tricks and lies to invade, it wasn't just direct attacks...." She started to explain herself under the disgusted guise of the rest, "Putting my vengeance aside, I thought that there were more people from Eternia, besides Adora, that managed to escape and set colonies on Etheria, and then train and send you guys to invade us, because it wouldn't be the first time that they started an invasion behind an amicable appearance.

Glimmer and Adora processed her answer, which sounded a bit logical, but didn't quite clear all the questions they had.

"You mentioned Mara" recalled Adora, thinking back, "How did you know her?"

Laurel was about to reply, but a loud snore from Bow interrupted.

"I can take him to his room if you'd like" offered Catra, to Glimmer's surprise, "After all, I heard the story already" she added, nodding at Laurel with a small smile.

"I'm sorry, you may continue now," said the Queen, seeing how Bow and her former enemy abandoned the room.

Laurel retold her story, this time a bit calmer and more alleviated, but still unable to control all her feelings. Adora and Glimmer, a bit moved, heard it all with deep attention until it was over. While it served to understand the girl a bit more, it caused a bit of conflict inside of them: they were capable to put themselves in her shoes, but there was so much they couldn't justify nor understand about Laurel's action; though, to her favor, they could see traces of regret on her.

Catra came back just as the girl was finishing her explanation, feeling the tension in the ambient.

"Catra told me that, even after making so many mistakes, you forgave her," said Laurel, looking at her, "But I don't expect you to do the same; I took so many wrong decisions, I damaged innocent people and destroyed countless planets, all because of my fury and frustration, and those are things I, unfortunately, cannot fix. I will peacefully accept if you decide I should pay for it and not be forgiven," she sentenced, staring at Glimmer and Adora, who was silent, while Catra witnessed the scene with more anxiety than Laurel felt, waiting for a reply.

"I can understand that what happened on Zeiren was an accident..." Adora broke the silence, "But not Eternia, you destroyed an entire planet, with innocent people in it... do you even regret it?" The girl looked at Laurel sternly, the latter held

her gaze while she thought of her reply, knowing this moment could open or close the doors for her.

"I am sorry for the lives that were affected, I should have acted differently, but back then, I didn't want to look for alternatives, I wanted revenge for what they were doing to all those planets, which just like or was worse than Horde Prime. I tried to eliminate him too, but my calculations failed and I ran out of time," she confessed, "I wish I was able to think it through, but the damage is already done... I learned so much with Eira all these years, but it wasn't enough, and now, maybe I need to learn from you guys if given the chance."

"If you intend to be a better person, I think we should give you a chance," answered Glimmer, "But you will be on trial for a long time" she finished, locking her eyes on Laurel, who smiled, same as Catra.

"That's fine by me, your majesty" Laurel did a small reverence, which amazed the Queen, and also made her smile, "I'm thankful for the opportunity, and before I retire, there's something I need to do..." Curiosity invaded the girls as they saw Laurel walked over to the control station, "I you allow me, I can improve this" she said, pointing at Darla, "I can't stand her seeing her like this..."

"How?" asked Catra hesitant, Laurel smiled in confidence.

"You know, this isn't Mara's ship..." she started to say, puzzling them, "It's mine" she clarified while pressing some buttons which turned Darla orange instead of the familiar pink.

"*Total access accepted... Welcome, Laurel,*" said the machine.

"Mara's version had a block..."

"Like a parental block?" asked Glimmer, confused.

"I don't know what that is, but probably. The important thing is that know you have access to most of the information Eternian's had, and they tried to hide, surely, so Mara wouldn't know the truth about them" the excitement Laurel might have, vanished at the memory of her friend.

"This is amazing" admitted Catra, walking towards Laurel, who smiled.

"Bow would have a heart attack when he finds out, he could barely deal with what we had before," said Glimmer laughing.

"Just one more thing...." Laurel said while turning to the system, "Computer..."

"Her name's Darla" corrected Adora, shily. Laurel let out a small laugh.

"Alright then, Darla, I'd like to give total access to Bow, Adora, Catra, and Glimmer..."

"*Access created; do you need anything else?*"

"Oh, I think Entrapta might want to access that information," remarked Glimmer under Laurel's confused expression, she

quickly clarified, "She is one of Etheria's princesses, she's a whiz with technology and stuff, you'll meet her soon enough."

"Ok, give access to Entrapta as well" Indicated an uncertain Laurel.

"*Access created; do you nee-"* the machine tried to reply but an interference cut her out, it caught Laurel's attention.

"Don't worry, sometimes it happens" said Catra nonchalantly while giving the system a few softs hits, "Don't tell Bow I did this though, he won't like my fixing method" she said laughing.

"*System reestablished, playing message..."*

None of the presents managed to question or react on time before a hologram of Mara formed in front of them, leaving them mouth agape.

"If you're seeing this, it means either the Firsts kept their promise, Adora found you, or you came to Etheria and found the ship," spoke which appeared like a commotional Mara. Laurel and the rest were frozen in place, no one knew what was happening, "I'm sorry Laurel, because if you're seeing this, it means *I* broke my promise," she took a deep breath before continuing, "I couldn't come back and bring you here, but it also means I made it, I saved Etheria and did so with a bit of your bravery and rebellion... it may not be any consolation, but I love this planet and I hope you can love and care for it just like I did," she asked in tears, while Laurel felt the emotions inside her ready to explode, "I love you, I'm sorry for not coming back..." she finally said, then the hologram disappeared.

The place was silent for the longest time, they were all moved but also bewildered. Laurel kept her eyes and fists shut with strength, fighting the urge to cry while the memories and frustration fought for freedom.

The calm lasted for a couple of seconds, suddenly, the doors busted open and gave place to a calm Archie, whose serenity was quickly swift for one of anger and confusion.

"What's she doing here!? It's dangerous to have her roaming around, why did you let her out?!"

Chapter End Notes

Hello how are you? It's been a while since I posted the previous chapter, but it was very difficult for me to edit with a broken finger, so I had no choice but to save it for when I was better. Apologies for making you wait, I hope you liked this first part of the end ♥. I decided to do it in two parts because this chapter is much longer than the rest and I felt that maybe it was going to be too much to upload it all at once.

I thought that Mara's parts were not going to affect me anymore, because I already read them several times, but the scene of her farewell made me cry a little again hahaha.

I hope I can finish the second part as soon as possible. Thanks for your patience, I wish you a very good weekend ♥

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# Chapter 7: Roads Untraveled (Part 2) (Final)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

*"What's she doing here!? It's dangerous to have her roaming around, why did you let her out?!"*

Everybody was quiet, unable to react or even figure out what to say. Laurel, on her part, felt emotionally unavailable to reply; she wished not to fight anymore; she had no more strength.

Archie, bothered by the lack of response, was about to go straight at Laurel, but Eira grabbed him by the arm, stopping him on his tracks, under the astonished gaze of the group, especially Laurel, who felt happy of seeing her at long last, even if she couldn't talk to her just yet.

"Brother, calm down."

"How can I calm down, when the person that destroyed our planet is free?!"

"She didn't do it on her own, I helped her, so some of the blame should be on me" she replied, facing him. "If our planet was destroyed, it's because we thought that following the plan, despite the risk, would have been the right thing to do, but it wasn't..."

"She manipulated you, she manipulated all of us!" Archie gave Laurel murderous eyes, but she said nothing at all, just looked at him.

"No, if I helped was because I truly believed this was the best course of action, and those kids were our enemies." She said, referencing the friend squad. "The plan was to deal with them, and try not to destroy our planet, or leave to chance their intentions and risk another invasion" Eira tried to speak calmly, but Archie wouldn't give in so easily, not after what happened, "At least we managed to save everybody..."

"What about the animals?" he asked, losing his patience, "Eira we lost everything! Our family, our home, and our planet... And all because of her!" Archie felt filled with sadness and rancor.

Laurel, upon listening to the last bit, moved her face to the side; she couldn't help but feel guilty, because she knew the young man spoke the truth, or at least, she too felt like everything was her fault.

"¡Our planet was dying already, Archie! Why do you think the animals and plants were so scarce? Why do you think the weather was completely inconsistent? I sacrificed years of my life sleeping so I wouldn't exhaust its magic" Archie was speechless, "And if I was in that state, it's because we couldn't defeat Horde Prime by ourselves and we needed Laurel to do so, and because we weren't ready," she remarked in tears, "We all had to sacrifice what we loved to protect our home, we did what we had to and sadly we messed up, but now we got a second chance." Eira spoke calmer now, then she placed her hands on her brother's shoulders; the latter had his eyes fixated on the floor and his hands closed in a fist, but deep down, he understood, "We all have a second chance..."

Eira side-eyed at Laurel with a subtle smile, making the other girl feel a bit comforted.

Archie said nothing at first, creating certain tension in the atmosphere. Eira knew her brother could be stubborn, but she hoped this time he'll see-through. The Prince quietly moved forward to hug his sister, making her smile.

"Let's try not to mess up this time" pleaded Archie in a whisper.

"We won't..."

The serene hug of the siblings was broken with the sound of sobbing, it came from Bow who had listened to the argument and, alerted, he had drowsily walked over the room.

"Bow! You should be sleeping..." started Glimmer, but the boy ignored her and went straight to Eira and Archie, to hug them.

"Guys, don't ever fight again" he begged.

As this scene played out and taking advantage of the diverted attention, Laurel abandoned the room; while she wanted to talk to Eira, she knew right now wasn't the time, so she chose to take some time for herself, to think about everything she now knew about Mara, and of what her future might become.

Laurel strayed further away through the hallway, making her way up to a hidden spot she knew where to find when suddenly she felt someone sneaking behind her.

"What do you want?"

Adora stopped right on her tracks just a few meters away from her, and took her sweet time to reply:

"Why did you leave?"

"That wasn't the place for me, not now..."

"And where are you going?"

"If available, I'll use Mara's old room, the hidden one." She explained, leaving a big clueless expression on Adora, "You never found it, right?" Adora shook her head and Laurel sighed loudly, then she pointed forward, "Come on, I'll show you..."

The warrior showed Adora to one of the walls, which opened at the touch; opening the space to a cramped space, with a bed and some screens around that showed the ship's most important parts. Adora stared at it in disbelief, astonished that something like it could pass under their radar for so long.

"This place is for resting, under protection, and with the ability to never lose sight of your surroundings, something handy if you have unwanted visitors."

"We have to show this to Bow and Entrapta!"

"Sure, but now I need some alone time, then you might bring all the friends you want, and maybe even your girlfriend..."

Adora blushed as Laurel smiled mischievously while subtlety tried to shut the door, but the other girl stopped her using one of her hands.

"Excuse me, but I'll like to clear something up," she said, trying to regain composure and remembering the reason why she followed her, to begin with, "I understand why Catra trusts, or in some point, sees herself in you, but if you try to do something to harm her, my friends, or Etheria, I promise to be merciless this time" she sentenced in coldness, maintaining eye contact; Laurel keep the stare and took some seconds to respond, measuring her words.

"I don't wish to fight, no more" she sighed, "I know nothing I do will ever suffice, but I thought my reasons were justified... You see, Mara was so important to me, even right at the start when she took everything that I thought was important to me, I couldn't hate her... I could never. She became all and then she vanished like she never existed, or that's what I thought, that she was forgotten. It became my only reason to resist the madness: don't let her die into oblivion... I now see that I was wrong, I wasn't the only one remembering; You have been fighting for her, you even saw her" she said, looking right into Adora's eyes, "When you said her name it was painful... of all the weapons an enemy could've used against me, that was the more effective, so I became angrier, I should've stopped right at that moment, yet I couldn't... I'm sorry." She lowered her gaze, "I made a big mistake and as you said, Mara wouldn't have wanted me to keep going. So, I am sorry Adora, I know it's not enough, but I promise I'll show you all that believing in me won't be in vain."

Adora fell silent; she was moved and confused. Because she clearly had intentions to be distrustful of Laurel, but at the same time everything she said felt honest and, to some extent, she could understand her pain, so she took a step back, allowing the other girl to shut the door behind her.

"I hope it works out Laurel, we are giving you that chance" she spoke kindly, easing the girl's worries, "We'll let you know when

we land."

"Thank you for everything." Replied Laurel with a slight smile, one that Adora corresponded, and then she departed.

Laurel saw her walking away as she closed the door, staying hidden in that small compartment. Tired and dazed by all that transpired, she grabbed the thin mattress and flip it to the other side, dispersing the layer of dust on top of across the room, it made her cough for a little while, then she sat and inspected the place. Perhaps hoping to find traces of her old friend, but around here there was nothing more than barely functioning screens and replacement for controls and stuff. Only some holograms and memories of Mara were left on the world; of which Laurel had repeated so often in her head, she had the certainty of never forgetting.

On the edge of finally collapsing, a rustled sound coming from under the bed catches her attention, she looked down to meet face to face with the small pig Eira found. The very same Adora and Catra took while being chased by Sven and his companion.

"Were you up here all this time? How did you get in?" The creature growled then got closer to her, "Okay, if you want to stay, I can make your space up here..."

The girl stretched her arms to grab him, the little pig opposed no resistance. Both stayed in silence, in that dark and cold space.

Adora, on her own, still felt as if something was left to resolve. The battle against Laurel and the happenings of Zeiren wouldn't stop popping up in her head. She hadn't had the time to talk with the friend squad; she didn't intend to suffocate them, as they were probably struggling with processing it as well. But she needed to vent, the guilt was eating her alive.

Still debating and thinking, Adora decided to meet with her friends once they were all up and well-rested. And so the girl waited for a couple of hours until it happened. Bow got up first after his well-deserved break and got back into the control station first thing; discovering all the new stuff Laurel had activated, feeling a bit nervous about the news, but also a bit excited. Catra and Glimmer were already there, so once she saw them all, Adora made up her mind.

"I need to talk to you" she sentenced, addressing the whole squad.

"Is something wrong?" asked Glimmer.

"I think it's time we speak of what happened on Zeiren."

"Adora, we did the best we could, and while it wasn't enough, at least we saved them..."

"You said it Bow, it wasn't enough. We underestimated the situation, we weren't ready to face it, we could have done it better... and it's partly my fault for thinking it was going to be easy" whispered the overwhelmed girl.

"Adora, we are a team, if something goes wrong it's not just your fault, you are not supposed to carry that guilt on your own. We are together in this, don't forget it," intervened Catra, trying to appease her.

"You had a bad feeling about all this since day one, and we didn't listen..."

"How could we have known it was so bad? All past missions turned out fine, what happened was unexpected," Glimmer was also trying to make her best friend feel better, but truth be told, neither felt free of guilt.

Bow walked over to Adora, and placed his hand on her shoulder, trying to catch her attention.

"We might not be able to fix what happened, but we can try to make it better now for these people and our own," Adora couldn't help but smile, Bow did so as well, "Now c'mon here", the boy scouted Catra and Glimmer to hold them all, in a big friend group, mutually comforting each other.

Deep down the group needed that moment to release their regrets; after all, they were all put to the limit, on stressful situations that put them all to the test both as a group and as individuals, mentally and physically. After Horde Prime, the group never thought something as bad would ever appear again.

Days came by with ease, everybody living together, trying to get to know each other a bit better. Everyone, except for Laurel who decided to be locked in as much as she could for the remainder of the trip. The feeling of lockdown didn't bother her, she wasn't a prisoner anymore. She had freedom, but now she wished not to utilize it.

She wanted to take advantage of that solitude and calm to gain the courage to talk to Eira, but nothing seemed good enough, and the idea of abandoning her space caused her a bit of panic. Sven had tried to cheer her on, but the warrior would have rather jump off to space than listen to, what to her was, an annoying being. The boy was aware of her feelings, so he took great pride in continuing with their conversations, which was mostly a monologue on his part.

"Can you get out?" she pleaded for the hundredth time, but he seemed not to hear her.

"Can you?" re-asked the boy, making Laurel sighed in annoyance.

"Don't you have anything better to- "

"Is Laurel there?" asked Eira, appearing at the door frame and cutting Laurel's words off her tongue. Sven simply nodded, got up, and left, leaving them alone. His job was simply over. Eira waited until he disappeared, then she stood in front of Laurel and asked with worry, "Are you okay?"

"Yes, I'm okay" she affirmed, sighing again, still doubting if she was ready to talk to her, and opened the door that divided them.

"Bow said we are almost there, so I wanted to let you know..."

"Is that all?" Laurel asked impulsively, realizing how open-ended that question was.

Eira took a few seconds to reply. Although they were no longer connected, she could sense the aura of sadness and guilt the girl carried.

"Laurel... I don't hate you" she admitted, a bit eager, "and I don't think this is your fault."

The warrior was surprised at hearing that, because she wasn't expecting it, at least not suddenly or at that moment.

"Archie does, and to be honest, so do I"

"Well, then you're both wrong. What happened was a mistake on everybody's part; maybe my brother was the first to have a change of heart, but there was no certainty on the goodness of these people."

"No, Eira. This happened because I got carried away with my hatred, by my vengeance, I did what they've done to us, and got blinded to see the reality. I dragged you all to do the same, and the price to pay was what you all cared for the most..." Laurel opened the door and met Eira's eyes for a couple of seconds, then she lowered her gaze, ·I don't deserve the forgiveness from these kids, or your brother's, your people, or even yourself. I truly messed up, I know I did," she sentenced in frustration.

Eira couldn't help but give in upon her impulse to go hug Laurel, knowing she could be rejected, but she wasn't. Laurel accepted the hug, feeling her friend's love.

"I forgive you, and I know the rest will do too in due time," Eira said, drifting away to meet Laurel's eyes, "You are good, I know it, and this will be a great chance for you to show it."

"Thank you" she thanked her sincerely, her voice shaking, "Oh, I got a surprise for you..."

Eira looked at her with a curious smile; Laurel entered the room for a couple of seconds and exited again, this time holding the small pig.

"Oh my God, Rem!" said the girl, taking it from the other woman's arms and holding it as Laurel witnessed the scene, moved, "I'm so glad you're okay."

Laurel felt happy at her friends' excitement and wished to be a bit more expressive, but she didn't want to feel more anguish, she didn't want to keep rejecting her feelings, and more importantly, she didn't want to keep fighting. She was tired of fighting with others and herself. So she chose to believe in Eira's words, at least at that time. After all, only time could tell if Eira was right, and Laurel was truly, or if at shown different challenges, she would choose the wrong path.

At the control station, the friend squad could already see Etheria. So happy to be finally returning home after months of adventure, and to see everybody again. Their promise had been partly successful and they felt a certain amount of pride for it, despite the guilt of the happenstance on Zeiren, something they were going to feel for years to come.

Eira and Laurel entered the control station, catching the same view, feeling the wonder of the spectacular view, and also the curiosity and anxiety for what was to come for them.

"Wait, why is there a tree in the middle of the galaxy?" asked Laurel puzzled, gaining the attention of the friend squad and earning a big laugh from them.

"Adora did it" pointed Glimmer smiling, leaving more questions on the young woman, who wondered how that could be possible.

Thankfully, unlike the time they arrived at Zeiren, they landed smoothly and easily. Bow, who tensed up until they touched land, did everything within his power not to land so roughly; especially

considering the number of people they now had inside the ship and the possible danger of hurting them.

Glimmer, Adora, Catra, Eira, and Laurel dealt with reuniting all the former habitants from Zeiren in the landing area. Bow chose to give a small introduction before opening the gates, and after everything he has done, no one denied it.

"Ladies and gentlemen, beings from other planets," Bow raised his voice, trying to sound solemn, "I know what you have been through, and that's why I want to tell you that I hope you can love this planet as much as I do, and maybe, someday, feel this is your home too" he expressed kindly, moving everybody a little bit and even himself, " so, without further ado, this is Etheria..."

Smiling, he opened the gates and moved, allowing the rest to get off to meet the beautiful planet.

The ex-habitants from Zeiren stood at the gates, afraid and undecided, Eira upon noticing tried to step up and give the people some words of encouragement, but her brother went ahead with the same idea:

"I know you're scared, but it is time to let our fears behind, to start a new era of peace and harmony" he spoke firmly, "I know these people are strangers for you and, not long ago, our invaders, but we were wrong. They are good and had shown it by assisting and bringing us here. So fear not, we are in good hands..."

With that impulse, his people abandoned the ship. Before doing the same, Eira stopped beside Archie.

"I'm proud of you, you are an extraordinaire leader," she remarked with a smile, making Archie sighed and leave his pride behind.

"And I am proud of you, sister."

One by one, the ex habitants from Zeiren left the ship, curious of meeting the new planet and the people living them. No one wanted to be left behind but Laurel. Who doubted if following them would be the best idea; Eira's words still resonated in her head, but she still felt unworthy of them, or even if she could be worthy of this planet that Mara loved so much.

Catra, who was beside Adora ready to leave, noticed this demeanor when she turned around, noticing Laurel's hesitation. The girl let out a long sigh and dropped Adora's hand, the former looked at her with confusion but immediately understood when she turned around too.

"Go ahead, I'll meet you outside," she said with a smile, Catra nodded and walked straight to Laurel.

"Do you need someone to carry you?" said with a sarcastic smile, bringing Laurel back to reality.

"Would you like to?" was her quick retort. Catra couldn't help but blush slightly, and then she softly hit her in the arm.

"You are an idiot; you can stay here if you want..." Catra spun around with her characteristic pride, abandoning the ship.

Laurel smiled, she liked that girl quite a lot, and while their silly interaction helped her ease some of her nerves, it wasn't until she

saw Eira down smiling at her and winking, that she didn't dare to move. So, without thinking anymore, she started to walk at that incandescent light that showed her the way out, it blinded her when she met the ground. No doubts the lights around her were way too bright for her eyes, which spent so many times in absolute darkness.

When she finally got her vision back, she tried to find Eira, to no avail. Everybody around her was hugging each other with emotion and love; it was a big reunion, which made her feel like more of an outsider. So she started to walk around, with certain shyness uncharacteristic for her, trying to find her friend somewhere. But when she tried to change directions, she was met face to face with Swift Winds'. Laurel jumped back, startled at that colorful and eccentric being.

"Who are you?" asked the horse.

This action terrified her even more, to the point where she shifted forms without even thinking about it. Swift Wind and everybody else stared at her in shock. Adora and the squad, upon seeing the commotion ran towards them.

"Why is this..." Laurel started talking, eyeing him up and down, while pointing her sword at him, "horrid and colorful creature talking?!"

All, but Swift Wind laughed out loud.

"Adora, are you letting this cheap copycat insult and point at me with a sword?" yelled the horse in indignation.

"What did you say about me?" said Laurel, facing the horse, who didn't back away either.

"Calm down you two," said Adora, placing herself in the middle; Glimmer imitated her while trying to contain the laughter from such a bizarre face-off.

"Adora was trying to test She-ra's powers and made a mistake" explained Glimmer, almost crying.

"Yes, I see that" Laurel lowered her sword.

"Tell her to stop," said the horse to Adora.

"I'm sorry," She said, caressing his crane, "Laurel, please don't be mean to Swift Wind," she asked as seriously as she could.

"I'll do my best, but I can't promise..."

"Woah, you're real?" asked Entrapta, walking to the warrior staring at her in wonder, "I got so many things to ask to you," she said to Laurel, who looked at her puzzled.

"Do you know who she is?" asked Bow, "I don't remember sending you any report on her..."

"I read about while on Beast Island..."

"And you didn't warn us?!" screamed Glimmer at her.

"I just thought she was some sort of legend...But she is real!" said Entrapta raising herself with her hair, and touching Laurel's face.

"Yep, I'm real" affirmed Laurel, a bit uncomfortable by the sudden contact.

"Adora, can I keep her? I need her to help me with some stuff" she explained barely containing her excitement, while Laurel gave Adora an expressive look; but the aforementioned girl just smiled and looked at Entrapta-

"Sure, but don't break her," she said laughing, ignoring Laurel's murderous stare.

While this happened, Hordak witnessed the scene from outside, feeling a familiar sensation at that girl that Entrapta was so fascinated with. Laurels' transformation had shocked and left everybody with a lot of questions to solve, but he didn't feel as if this was news, although he couldn't quite figure out why.

Unlike him, in a far different place in space, one darker and somber, a man was ecstatic of finally having found her, perfectly remembering who she was and what she had done. The man walked at high speed through a long and poorly lit hallway, which he found endless. At the end of it, he crossed some gigantic gates and inside that room, tree strange looking and tarrying creatures inspected him from their thrones.

"What do you wish?" asked one of them, with such a deep voice that shook the room.

"I got two important news" explained the man, trying to hide his smile.

"Please, do tell" ordered another one, leaning ever so slightly.

"I received a report informing me that Zeiren has been destroyed," he said, to the amazement and disgust of his listeners, "but the good news is that I know who did it, and where to find her."

"And what creature produced such saddening lost?" asked in shock the third of them.

"The very same that destroyed Etheria, the one named Laurel..." finally replied the man, savoring the astonished expression from the three at the thrones.

"And where is she?" asked the first.

"Etheria..."

**The End**

Chapter End Notes

Hello, how are you? I hope you are fine. I know that it has been a long time since the first part of the end, but I had personal problems and a lot of work. Thank you for being patient and be here for the end, I hope you liked the story and especially the ending ❤. And speaking of endings ... Yes, the idea was to leave a window open for a continuation that would be like an entire season of the show, where various

subjects would be touch such as Angella’s rescue, Laurel and Mara's past and some other problems that were left off the original series. The thing is, it would be much more work than this project and it should have a lot of support to justify the continuation, so if you want it, leave your kudo, a comment and share it with your friends. If you want, follow me on twitter (@RedLiepard), I'm going to put a poll to see what project to follow since I have several things in mind: both fanfiction and my own projects.
I also want to give a special thanks to my girlfriend (Micaela Agata) who was the one who translated the all story
Well, I am not longer taking your time, again thank you very much and I hope soon to be able to bring you some other story, see you later ❤

PS: At the time, I had the idea of making a playlist for the whole story, but in the end, I was only able to do Laurel's one. If you have Spotify, and you want, you can go and listen it:
https://open.spotify.com/playlist/78cFEkjZw6T7QtOPTokzJh?si=99338cb7c93745e9

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!